She-Ra|He-Man: The Power of Grayskull

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam & Adora (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela (He-Man), Man-At-Arms (He-Man), Keldor (He-Man), Hordak (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Kronis (He-Man), Stinkor (He-Man), Sorceress of Castle Grayskull | Zoar the Falcon, King Grayskull (He-Man), Mer-Man (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man)

Additional Tags:
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by ChapstickPenny

Summary

Adora sympathizes with Man-At-Arms' obvious distress. He tugs at the corner of his graying mustache. "So the entirety of your plan—that is, the way you mean to save the king of Eternia and defeat an evil sorcerer with an ancient staff of untold magical power—is to go to his ship and, 'Talk him down or punch him out?'"

Glimmer grimaces.

Catra smirks.

Bow rubs the back of his head, then smiles. "You're not very familiar with how we do things, are you?"

Notes

A little preamble before we start things off:

Catradora is going to be an element in this fic in that Adora and Catra are in a relationship and they're two of the PoV characters. The story isn't focused on it and there isn't going to be any drama regarding them; I just wanted them to have a fun space adventure together and be girlfriends at the same time. Bow and Glimmer are also together, but for soon-to-be obvious reasons, that will be coming up considerably less often.

If you're coming into this fic as a He-Man fan first, I've pretty heavily re-imagined some of the lore to fit in with She-Ra's continuity, but I hope you all find it done in an entertaining manner.

In short, this is my self-indulgent attempt at writing a post-S5 "movie." I hope you all enjoy reading it as much as I did writing it.

From the Stars

Bow folds his arms. “Absolutely not.”

“It’s not *that* far. I can teleport to Prime’s flagship, y’know. That thing’s already in space.”

“And we’re halfway across the galaxy!”

“I’ve been practicing.”

“It’s completely out of the question.”

“But I want to see you!” Glimmer draws the last word out in a playful whine.

“You can see me right now.”

She slumps back into her chair. “In-*person,* Bobo.” He smiles. That nickname was the last gift Glimmer gave him before he left Etheria for the stars. Her face shifts and warps like an image underwater and is briefly hidden by a moment of static that an offhand screen tells him is the result of a nearby solar flare. Glimmer sees his smile and sports a conspiratorial grin of her own. “Whatcha thinking about?”

“Coming home.” He doesn’t bother trying to hide a look of longing.

“Aw.” Her pity turns to a tease. “Miss me already?”

“Since the day I left.”

She blushes. “It’s really hard to make fun of you when you’re so nice all the time.”

“I can’t fight my nature.”

“And I love you for it.” She pokes her side of the screen. Bow reaches out. The holo-projection sputters and fizzes around his skin and though he can hear Glimmer sigh, Bow feels nothing but the cold air. “Who knew being a queen had responsibilities and junk?”

“I’m surprised we ever got you off-planet at all.”

“After my first time in space, I’m surprised I decided to go back.”

“Do you want to talk about that?”

“No.” She slides further down. “I’m just sulking.” Gesturing at a table Bow can’t see, she says, “Paperwork.”

“Eugh.”

“That’s exactly what I told my dad. He laughed at me, Bow. Laughed!”

“I have no words.”

Glimmer hums. “I bet you’ve got some stuff to say about your *space trip.”* She waves her hands and leaves trails of glowing glitter. “How’s that going?”

“Remember the last time I told you about it?”

“Where you told me to remember the time before that?”

“Yeah.”

“Ouch.”

Magic is returning to the universe. They’re using She-Ra to restore what won’t return naturally. It’s more difficult to do the further they go from Etheria. Most Horde clones are being rehabilitated by those kind enough to take them in. Some try to start empires of their own. The Best Friend Squad—sans one—is there to stop them.

And so it has been for nearly three months.

He is alone in space, kept company only by himself, this ship, the infinite cosmos around him...

Something falls.

It shatters.

Someone swears.

...and Catra and Adora.

Bow can hear Catra's heavy breathing before her footsteps, as light as any true feline's. She races into the bridge and slides to a stop next to the captain's chair. She waves at Glimmer. Glimmer waves back. "Hey, Sparkles. We having a conference or something?"

"Just chatting. But you're welcome to join… us…?" Glimmer looks behind Bow. Catra's ears perk up. Bow leans away from her.

The heavy thudding of Adora's running fills the bridge in a rising sound like the battering of meteors against Darla's hull. By the time Catra turns around, it's been replaced by utter silence and the blur of Adora's flying body.

Catra's yelp of surprise turns to a wheeze. Adora's impact is sudden and violent, throwing both women to the floor in a sprawling mess. One of them groans. The other swears.

They haven't even begun to untangle their limbs when the fits of giggling start.

"Hi, Glimmer!" Adora says between breaths.

"Hi, Adora."

"Catra broke another plate."

"That's a lie and she knows it."

“Oh?” Glimmer and Bow ask in unison.

“It was a bowl.”

They all laugh, one more exasperated than the rest. “You’re going to clean it up this time, right?” he asks her.

She scrunches her nose then turns to the woman still lying atop her. “Adora,” Catra draws out the last syllable of her name, “can you clean up my mess? A mean blonde lady tackled me and broke all my bones. I can’t do anything.” She flops her arm to illustrate the severity of her injuries.

“Oh, how terrible,” Adora says, pulling herself up. “I bet you can’t even stand up.”

“I mean, I don’t think it’s that ba—!” She shrieks when Adora scoops her off the ground in a bridal carry. “Adora! No!”

“I don’t know, I think you like it.” She turns to Glimmer and Bow. “She likes it, right?”

They both agree that Catra seems to be having a wonderful time in Adora’s arms as she tries to push, squirm, and claw her way out. But despite her protests, her claws are retracted, her movements only settle her deeper into the crook of Adora’s elbow, and her cries of indignation are already being drowned out by the purr coming from deep within her chest.

“No, I hate this. Stop. Please.” She smirks and traces Adora’s jaw with the tip of her tail.

The two say nothing, staring into each others’ eyes with scheming smiles that leave Bow looking away in a flushed embarrassment.

“I wish you’d break all my bones,” Glimmer mutters.

“I promise I will when we get back.”

“And that’s going to be soon?” she asks, already knowing the answer.

“I’m sorry, Glimmer.”

She waves him off. “I guess you can keep saving the universe, or whatever. I’ll just be here. Being the queen of paperwork.” She waves a hand at the table again.

“Oh, Glimmer!” Adora says. “If you want to, I can show you one of the magic-y things we found. It looks pretty old and I’m not sure if you’d know what to do with it, but if anyone here would…”

“Oh, yes, please. Anything to stop all this—” She cuts herself off, then looks to the side. Bow turns but realizes that she’s looking past her own screen. Her face falls into one of bored annoyance, and he can hear another voice in the transmission. “Already?” she asks the unseen intruder. “That isn’t for another hour!”

They wait for a response they cannot hear.

“It has not! Bow, how long have we been talking?”

“About an hour.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?!”

“I like talking to you.” He shrugs and puts on the most charming smile he can.

“Oh, you—!” Her face gets that cute look she has whenever she’s angry, but not *angry.* “Fine! Adora, raincheck on the magic-y thing, and Catra, you’ve got to tell me what’s going on with the dishes.”

Catra sticks out her tongue.

“Bobo, call soon, we’ll have to talk later.”

“Yeah, Bobo, call soon,” Catra says. She flashes her claws. “I’ll make sure he doesn’t forget,” she says to Glimmer.

“You’re not very scary when you’re being held like a baby,” Bow says. As if she is at all, anymore. Strip away everything she’s done before and Catra can be described as a ‘nefarious toddler’ at worst. ‘Nefarious toddler with knives for fingers’ might be more accurate. Not that he’d ever tell her that.

She sticks her tongue out at him this time, and Glimmer thanks her for keeping him in check. They say their goodbyes, and Bow hopes that the smile he shows tells her more than words ever could. From the look she gives back, his message was received. The screen fizzles out, then closes in a small white flash.

“Uh oh, Adora. I think Bow’s in love.”

“Really? I never would have guessed. All that smooching they were doing with their eyes was very subtle.”

“And you two are supposed to be... what? Incognito?”

Adora holds Catra in her arms and rubs circles into the small of her back while Catra lazily rests her arms around Adora’s neck and rubs her tail up and down the side of her face. Bow thinks he can see bite marks hidden beneath the collars of their shirts. They both shrug.

He chuckles, breathlessly, and finally notices Melog winding their way between his and Adora’s legs. “Hey buddy,” he says, scratching behind their ears. “When’d you get here?” The alien cat stops at his feet and begins to purr.

“They say to move a bit to the right,” Catra says.

“Here?”

“A little higher.”

Melog purrs louder, and Bow doesn’t need Catra to translate.

“Any updates, captain?” Adora asks, stepping closer. Captain was a rank used loosely aboard Darla, with the title belonging to whoever was sitting in the captain’s chair, or had done so most recently. Melog was, of course, no exception.

“We’re about a day out from the nearest planet. It’s also the one with reported Horde activity, but if these read-outs are right, it’s only one ship. A big one. Should only be a couple more hours before I can get some better scans.”

“We’ll have to wait on deciding anything until we get more intel,” Adora says, mostly to herself.

He nods. “Either of you feel like taking over? My legs are going numb.”

“Ooh!” Catra says. She’s scrambled out of Adora’s arms and onto the back of the captain’s chair before Bow has even finished standing. “Adora,” she continues, “my first order as new captain is for you to clean up my mess.”

“No.”

“Bow, throw her out of the airlock.”

“No.”

“Ugh, mutinies are only fun if I’m the one doing them.” She rolls off the chair and scratches her leg as she looks around the bridge. “Where’s the vacuum? I don’t want Melog to cut themself.”

The shapeshifting space cat meows something at her in an annoyed tone.

“Oh, get over yourself. Just help me find it,” Catra says, already wandering away.

Adora sits in the chair as Bow does a series of stretches and squats near the ship’s consoles. The tingling feeling fades. He lets out a sigh.

“Feeling better?” she asks.

“I don’t feel any worse.”

Adora chuckles, then pulls up a screen. “And you’re sure it’s only one ship? I don’t want this ending up like Tetral-7.”

“There’s no way to know until we get closer.” Bow skims over what limited information they have, this far from Etheria. “But as far as I can tell, this is the only Horde vessel that's been here since Prime fell. There aren’t any reports of this being another wannabe space god, but…”

“That’s why we’re checking it out,” she finishes for him. “Hopefully this is an easy one.”

“Hopefully.”

The remainder of the day passes without incident. Bow keeps himself busy by re-reviewing supply stores with Melog keeping him company as Catra and Adora keep watch over the bridge and raid the kitchen the minute he’s finished stocking it. They retire to their rooms for the “night” and after a thirty-minute video call with Glimmer that lasts for two hours, Bow finds himself restfully sleeping.

As always, Adora is the first to wake. It is hours before the first alarms will sound and the sun lamp on the room’s ceiling glows in a cool facsimile of moonlight, blanketing the room in an ethereal glow. The lamp’s dim flicker sends scant shadows dancing across the walls. There are few to be seen, as there is little they are cast

from. A cabinet of clothes. A set of chairs. A chest of upholstery: rugs, curtains, pillows, all still packed and almost forgotten. Its spartan furnishing is a consequence of her upbringing, she recognizes, but cares too little to change. In the open-walled rooms of Brightmoon, the nights of Etheria were warm and filled with sounds of life; either the call of a bug, animal, or the distant song of another who could find no rest in the dark. But this ship is quiet, sealed tight against the silent murk that surrounds them. Its engine is little more than a thrum that fades into her unhearing subconscious. Even the Fright Zone felt more alive. Be it the grinding clank of machinery or the heavy stomps of guards making their rounds, Adora always knew something or someone was at work, even into the long hours of the night.

The air is cold. The only warmth comes from the quilt atop her and the woman she sleeps beside.

Catra.

More thoughts than she can process rail against her addled mind, but simply looking at her face fills Adora's chest with a glowing warmth and sense of calm almost strong enough to lull her back to sleep. What dim light the room provides rests on Catra's head like a halo and highlights the soft form of her body beneath their blanket. Her breath is whistling and quiet, almost imperceptible, if not for the fact that Adora always—when the crushing silence of the ship becomes too much to bear—listens for it, finding solace in yet more proof—more than the warmth of her body, the softness of her fur, and the weight of her touch—that she is not alone.

Adora slips out from Catra's grasp in a delicate game that lasts several minutes. Catra is not as light a sleeper as she once was and on some days it would take Herculean efforts to wake her, but one of the few things that always drew her to wakefulness was Adora leaving their bed.

She murmurs something and reaches where Adora was. Adora holds her hand there until she falls back into a deeper slumber. It

takes all she has not to do more, and it is with the greatest difficulty that she keeps herself from stroking Catra's hair, grown out now past her shoulders for the first time since Prime took her. Adora's grip on her hand tightens. "It's all right," she whispers before letting go.

She steals a blanket, smaller than the rest and discarded at the edge of the bed, and drapes it over her shoulders, too cold to leave in nothing but her sleepwear, but too tired to bother dressing.

The door opens with a hiss, deafening in the quiet. She slips into the hall, the engine's thrum now ever-present. The entire ship is a wonder, made from metal unlike any found on Etheria, yet the floors are still cold and she finds no comfort in the angular, dark walls. She passes a reflection, its hair down and disheveled—eyes sunken and tired. She doesn't stop to look closer.

The hall opens to the bridge, and the ceiling, to the stars. She reaches the center of the floor and sits there, wrapping herself tight. For the first two decades of her life, Adora knew the stars only through myth and song. To see them was a marvel. To travel among them, a miracle. In every direction, even beyond the ones she can see, as far out as creation itself, little motes of light stave off the dark, bringing life to a universe she'll never fully know. Every one of them is a question. How many have planets? How many planets harbor life? How many of those lives can think? Feel? How many look up at the stars and wonder if another is doing the same?

How many more will she have to save?

How many will she fail to protect?

Adora pulls the blanket tighter.

One ship, she reminds herself. A single remnant ship to be dealt with and they can go home.

Home.

But where is home, for someone like her?

She was raised in the Fright Zone. It is where she grew up and spent most of her life. Brightmoon is where she found herself and became the warrior who would free the stars. It is where she lives, with all her family and those she loves most. Surely, one of them is home? Etheria, at least, in this new universe they've found.

Fine, she tells herself, not for the first time.

She knows her home.

What is it, then, that she searches for?

What is it that she looks to the stars and hopes to find?

"Adora?" Catra stands in the doorway, holding the frame. Her eyes are only half-open and when she walks, her steps are heavy and uncoordinated. She crouches beside Adora and wraps her arms around her shoulders.

"You should be in bed."

"So should you," Catra murmurs into the crook of her neck.

Adora mumbles a wordless acknowledgment and wraps the blanket around them both. Catra slides a leg between hers and her tail around Adora's waist.

"Are you still looking for it?" she asks in a drowsy voice, almost a yawn.

Adora has never told Catra why she slips away in the night to sit here and stare at the stars. It's difficult for someone to confess what they do not know.

Or what they're not willing to admit.

“Yeah.” She lays her head against Catra’s and lets the soft rumble of her purr and whistle of her breath lull her back to sleep.

“That floor must be really comfortable,” Bow says from the captain’s chair as the two untangle themselves and rub the grogginess out of their eyes. “Remind me to try it instead of a bed.”

“Pound dirt, Arrow Boy.” Catra stretches out over Adora’s lap and almost goes limp when the other woman scratches along her spine. They pull themselves off the floor and shake out the achiness from their limbs. “What’s the status on that planet?”

Adora nods in agreement through a yawn.

Bow waits for her to finish before speaking. “Well, I’ve done some scans, and we’ve been in communications range for about an hour —”

“What?!” Adora shouts, her eyes wide open. “Why didn’t you wake us up?”

“You looked comfortable.”

“I’ll be comfortable when the Horde is gone.”

“I was comfortable,” Catra says.

Adora stomps to the control panel and pulls up a flurry of scans that go by too fast for her to read. “What did you find?”

"It is just the one ship, and as far as I can tell, it's one of the only interstellar ships on the entire planet." He pulls up a new screen. "Speaking of the planet, every map I've checked gives it a different name, and most of them are just placeholders. It's like people don't even care this place exists."

Catra folds her arms. "And Hordak called Etheria a backwater."

"Are there life-signs?" Adora asks.

"Some. But it's lower than average."

"Any evidence of civilization?"

"I've been working on patching us in with the largest hub of radio chatter. None of their signals are outgoing. Not intentionally."

Adora grimaces. "Out-of-the-way planet, few lifeforms, and underdeveloped with almost no contact with the outside universe."

"It's the perfect hiding place," Catra says.

"And an easy target. Where's the Horde ship now? Near the hub?"

"It looks like it's in a desert a few thousand miles away," Bow says. "If there's anyone nearby, they don't have a lot of tech."

"Patch into the hub. See if they know anything about the ship. I want to get the locals' opinion on it before the Horde knows we're here."

"If it even is the Horde," Catra says.

Bow nods.

It wouldn't be the first time a third party had decided that such advanced technology was better off in their own hands. It wouldn't be the first time a Prime clone had been severed from the Hivemind and decided to do some good with it instead. But the risk such technology presented, either in the hands of a Horde

loyalist or malicious third party, meant that caution was to be exercised in every encounter.

If this hub of activity could provide no information, then they would simply move on to the next, and any after that. Should that not be enough, then they would go undercover, disguised and unseen until they could discover the ship's reasons for being there. Direct contact was saved only for ships deemed non-hostile, or as a last resort to prevent further conflict.

Bow wished that it worked as often as he hoped it would.

He presses a button on the arm of the chair. "Communications are primed for action."

"Then what are you waiting for?" Adora asks.

"You guys might want to get dressed first."

He plugs in while they put on real clothes, expecting a delay in response.

By the time they come back—Catra pulling tangles out of her hair while Adora puts hers in the same ponytail she's worn as long as Bow has known her—there is still no answer.

They wait, watching the screens and consoles for any signs of messages or radio signals. Minutes pass as they drift through the void toward a growing speck of light: the mystery planet on which the Horde ship has stationed itself.

Adora stares at it, her jaw fixed shut.

Bow drags his hand along the armrest and taps his foot.

"Maybe no one's home," Catra says with a shrug.

"I'll try somewhere else." Bow punches a series of controls and opens a new channel.

The dashboard blinks.

"Incoming message," Darla, the ship's AI, says in her robotic intonation. *"Would you like to respond?"*

"That's new," Adora says.

"That's coming through one of Darla's base channels." Bow pulls up a reading. "They're using a base channel. How do they have access to a base channel?"

"What does that mean?" Catra asks.

"They're using First Ones' tech," Adora says, quietly. She leans forward. "Darla, respond!"

"Adora, wait, we don't—"

Bow is cut off by harsh static—a new holographic screen appears in the center of the bridge, twice the height and triple the length of anyone on board. The electronic buzz fades into an image of a man, grim-faced and sporting a thick mustache. He wears some kind of mechanized orange armor over a green jumpsuit and holds a steel helmet at his hip. He looks at Bow, his chair, and the surrounding bridge, then squints his eyes. "You speak with the Man-At-Arms of the Eternos royal court. State your identities and intent, as well as how you came to access this *restricted* communications channel." His voice is gruff and projects an authority with decades of experience behind it, yet underneath that and by the look in his eyes Bow only hears the words of a very, very tired man.

Before he can speak, Adora almost trips over herself to come to the other side of the screen and wave a hand. For the briefest instant, his eyes widen.

"Yes! Hello! This is Bow, this is Catra, and I'm—Well, you probably know me better as She-Ra."

"I've heard of you."

They wait for him to continue.

The screen flickers, and a line of static runs across his face.

Adora clears her throat. "Oh...kay. Well, we beat Horde Prime, and we noticed you have a Horde ship on your planet. We were just checking in. Y'know, making sure it wasn't causing any problems. And if it is, we're here to help!" She flexes an arm, and Catra and Bow both try to look a little more serious.

"You've dealt with the Horde before?" He should already know the answer to that question, and Bow wonders why he'd even ask.

"We *beat* the Horde."

He seems to mull it over, clenching his jaw. "And what of magic? Have you beaten that as well?"

Adora closes her eyes and smiles. Holding a hand out, a golden glow shimmers into existence, and the sword of She-Ra appears in her hand. She holds it width-wise beside her face. "I *am* magic."

The Man-At-Arms can't help but show—or doesn't care to hide—the surprise on his face. But he steels his look and nods. "One moment, if you would." He reaches forward, and the screen goes back to static.

The droning electronic buzz echoes on the bridge.

"So was that a good reaction, do you think?" Adora asks. Her sword returns to nothingness. "Bad reaction? Any thoughts?"

"If they have First Ones' tech then they can probably track us," Catra says. "If we get blasted into oblivion, then that's your answer."

"He seemed kinda tense," Bow says. "There's definitely something going on."

Adora hums in agreement.

The screen fizzles back into an image of the Man-At-Arms, with several more people behind him, all wearing similar, but less elaborate, suits of armor. “We’re preparing a landing point for you. The coordinates should be reaching your ship shortly.” A light on the chair’s arm blinks, and Bow confirms the destination. “We can discuss things further when you’ve landed. Hopefully in a more secure environment. Catra, Bow, She-Ra... Welcome to Eternia.”

Prince Adam

Chapter Notes

> This one might be a bit heavy on the exposition, but it's also the last one before the adventure kicks off.
> Here's a handy dandy little map of Eternia I found that I'm basing the geography in this fic on https://www.deviantart.com/bluejaysquill/art/Map-of-Eternia-Masters-of-the-Universe-853506372
> Regarding the MotU side of this, an important thing to note is that I'm not following any particular continuities' lore since this is meant to fit into She-Ra first and incorporate MotU elements second.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“How do we know this isn’t a trap?” Catra asks.

“We don’t.” Adora folds her arms. The view from the bridge is gradually filled more and more by the blue-green swirl of Eternia. The closer they get, the tighter Adora’s chest constricts. Her throat closes in on itself and she has to force her lungs to breathe. Her eyes dart over every read-out and scan that flies past, memorizing and compartmentalizing every detail and note that could be of the smallest importance. Increased radio frequencies could indicate heightened communications in preparation for their approach; either to welcome them or make sure forces are coordinated so as to destroy them with the utmost efficacy. A surge in power levels could be the charging of a weapon. Moving lifeforms are the shifting of troops or civilians to clear the way for remote bombardment. Even something as simple as a fluctuation in atmospheric pressure could be disastrous if the hull of the ship is compromised. Every detail must be accounted for, every situation planned against in order to ensure success, and, more importantly, survival.

Such attitudes—these methods of planning—have been described to her as unnecessary. Overly complex. Paranoid. But in this new universe of danger, they have and would continue to keep her and her family safe. Bow may disparage them, but Catra understands. It is a consequence of their upbringing, she recognizes, and thanklessly acknowledges.

"Darla," Adora says. "Direct power to frontal shields until we've cleared the mesosphere. Shift to horizontal and underside shielding for the landing. Catra, get Melog ready. If they try anything, cloak the ship. It doesn't look like they have much experience with magic, so it should be enough to get us out of range of whatever they have." This is an assumption. A dangerous one. But if their goal was to shoot them out of the sky, then they would have done so already. So, they lack the range to hit them at this distance. Or, they want to bring them closer first. The Man-At-Arms asked if they were capable of beating magic. This implies they lack such abilities themselves. Or, that the Eternians are testing theirs.

Yes, all she has are assumptions. Assumptions, and a team she can trust. Her lips twitch in a smile. When have they ever been more prepared than that?

Catra sees her through the corner of her eye. "Nervous?" she asks with a smile of her own.

"Terrified."

Eternia dominates her view and Adora can make out the formations of individual mountains and sea storms that run along the coasts. The coordinates given point them toward a large patch of unforested green.

Darla starts to shake.

A red glow appears against the shielding.

The closer they get, the brighter it becomes, shifting from red, to orange, then yellow, until they have to turn away and cover their

eyes, and the shaking turns to tremors that rock the entire ship and nearly send Adora flying from the captain's chair.

Bow holds onto its side and screams, "I hate this part!"

Catra tries to keep her balance unaided, but Melog cowers between her legs and her smile has turned to a wide-eyed grimace.

Adora takes their hands and grits her teeth.

The keening whine of the ship as it burns through reentry turns to a droning groan and peters out into the dull hum of standard flight. The flash of heat against the shielding cools. Smoke trails behind them, but no systems appear damaged.

"Rerouting power to lower and horizontal facing shields."

They all sigh. Bow wipes his hands on his pants and Catra lets out an annoyed huff.

"Did that seem worse than usual to you guys?" Bow asks.

"It's always bad," Catra says.

"Maybe Darla's just getting old," Adora says.

"I cannot age."

The ship rolls, directing them toward their target. Now only a few miles above the surface, Adora can see the vague shape of the city they fly to. It seems almost thrice the size of Brightmoon, but there are no forests or mountains nearby. A river runs through the plains and the city stretches out along its bank. Hovercraft, little more than black specks against the pinkish stone, fly between dozens of spires. As they make their rapid approach, Adora can almost pick out the movements of individual people in the streets. Black scars from laser fire score the buildings, some of which are crumbling or outright destroyed. Rubble lines several streets and people, small as ants, clear it away by hand and machine. In the

city's center is a raised outcropping with a sprawling palace crowned by a large, pyramidal structure capped off with a shingled dome. Adora's eyes widen. "That's a First Ones ruin."

"It doesn't look very ruined," Bow says. "Except for that part." He points to what could have only been its main entrance, now nothing more than a pile of shattered stone.

"Darla, where are those coordinates putting us?" Adora asks.

Darla brings up an overlay on the cockpit window with a flashing red marker placed on what looks like a courtyard, almost directly in front of the pseudo-pyramid. A retinue of the soldiers stand ready, but not in any kind of combat formation.

"I guess they're not trying to kill us," Catra says. She cocks her head. "Unless they want to make a show out of it."

"They make a landing site and wait for us to get off the ship before executing us. Then they can take Darla without risking any damage to her." She holds her chin and sits her elbow against the armrest. "It's smart, I'll give them that."

"Or *maybe,"* Bow says, holding his hands together as he steps between them, "They're *welcoming* us to their *palace* because we offered to *help them."* He looks at Adora. "You were the one who did that, remember?"

She forces her eyes shut and nods. The Horde is the enemy. The Eternians could be allies. She cannot confuse the two. "Right. But when we land, I want all of you to stay behind me. I'm going as She-Ra, just until we know for sure what's happening here."

The ship stalls until it hovers over the landing site, ruffling the grass and flags lining its walls. It yaws until the exit hatch faces the main body of soldiers. Adora stands, and in a brilliant flash of light, summons her sword. Bow steps back. Catra smirks.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!"

Power, unlimited, surges through her like a thunderbolt. Rising from the ground, her body transforms: she is taller, stronger, mightier in every regard. Gone are her jacket and clothes, for she is now adorned in a suit of white and gold. A tiara gilds her crown and glimmering vambraces guard her arms. A cape falls from her shoulders and her hair grows out, shining like molten fire. She touches the floor with the force of a whisper, but her eyes glow with all the might of Etheria. She-Ra, the Princess of Power, has come.

The landing ramp lowers, overflowing with the golden glow of her magical aura. Catra, Melog, and Bow stand behind her. She keeps her sword low and her head high.

The courtyard is vast, covered in grass, and bordered by a wall of flowers and a balcony behind that overlooks the rest of the palace and city. A single door, three times Adora's height, even in this form, leads to the palace proper. A platoon of soldiers stands between it and her, with squads flanking either side of the ship. Each is armed but at rest. The Man-At-Arms stands in front of them, the myriad of different weapons Adora can see on his person holstered, sheathed, or otherwise stored away. He holds his helmet against his hip. "I heard you could transform," he says, "but I wasn't expecting something so dramatic. Your necks, if you would. Before we allow you any further."

Adora nods, and they each bare the backs of their necks to him.

"The cat, too."

Catra scoffs, but crouches down and tilts Melog's head forward.

He nods. "Guards," he says before twisting to show his own neck. The soldiers mimic their commander. As unsurprising as the result may be, Adora allows herself a feeling of relief knowing these few, at the very least, are not chipped by the Horde.

Adora steps forward. "I am She-Ra, the Princess of Power, and the warrior who killed Horde Prime. These are my companions, Catra

and Bow. We come to you from the planet Etheria on a diplomatic mission under the authority of Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon. There is a Horde ship on this planet. If it is acting under their will and you consider them your enemy, then we have a common cause and will help you fight against them."

It's a well-practiced speech that Adora has lost count of how many times she's performed. It's typically met with looks of awe, confusion, hatred, or a mixture of the three. On one unfortunate occasion, they were being shot at before she could finish.

The helmets on these ones make the response difficult to tell.

The Man-At-Arms wears that same steely look that Adora is already growing tired of. Then, he nods. "The authority of a queen, eh? Then you'd better come with me. I think the royal family will want to speak with you as well." The guards behind him step aside, opening a path into the palace.

Bow and Catra look to Adora. She nods, and they follow.

The Man-At-Arms says, "Gold squad, with me. Red squad, blue squad, keep the courtyard secured and see to it that no one comes near their ship. That includes any of you. The rest of you, return to your posts."

"Sir!" they shout in unison, before filing themselves away. Adora, Catra, and Bow stop behind the Man-At-Arms, and a squad of six guards moves around them in a rectangular formation.

The insides of the palace are made from the same material as the exterior, though it's almost completely covered with carpeting, drapery, tapestries, and paintings of figures Adora does not recognize. The architectural style is nearly identical to that of every First Ones ruin she's seen, but the halls are lit by candlelight and chandeliers. The passageways are open, and what ones are sealed are done so with wooden doors. Other guards stand at attention or walk the halls with purpose as noble-looking individuals wander about in an aimless sort of arrogance. Yet they

all turn to the outsiders as they pass, and their attentions are focused on Adora. It's a common occurrence, but still enough to leave her face slightly flushed.

"I like your armor," Bow says to the guard closest to him.

"Thanks," they say, muffled by the helmet. "Cool bow."

"Thanks."

The Man-At-Arms shortens his stride until he walks in step with Adora. "You'll have to forgive our cold welcome, but it's not often we receive visitors from beyond the stars, and these are trying times for Eternos."

"The Horde?" she asks.

"I wish it were that simple. There is a Horde ship here, and it has been for several months. The creature that commanded it made no illusions about his allegiance or where he came from, but he told us that he was on Eternia only to understand its magic. He wanted to know how something so simple could defeat a being most of the universe considered unstoppable." He stares forward as he speaks.

"There's magic on Eternia? We haven't found any in nearby systems."

"No. And there hasn't been for more than a thousand years. But he was true to his word and left us alone. Eternos—all of Eternia—holds no love for the Horde, but the King and Queen would not risk the lives of their people against someone who was not proven to be a threat."

They round a corner past a door to a large, bustling kitchen whose activity slows as Adora walks by. They pass through a larger door that is closed behind them. The hallway ahead is even more ornate, and a bright light waits at the end.

He continues. “But that doesn’t mean they trusted him. Lord Keldor, the half-brother of the King, offered to parlay with the Horde and open a diplomatic channel so that their actions could be better understood.”

“He was spying on them,” Catra says.

Bow grimaces at the bluntness of her comment, but the Man-At-Arms nods. “Yes. He went alone and, as far as we know, was successful. We received reports for the next four months detailing what he learned. The Horde was here to study magic, yes, but they were looking for something specific. Something powerful. They were scouting Eternia’s Dark Hemisphere and began an excavation at Snake Mountain.” He stops, and they all stop with him.

The chamber at the end of the hall is only a few dozen feet away, but all Adora can see through it is a wide, gently rising staircase and a near-blinding light.

“That was the last report we received, more than a month ago. But it was not the last we heard of Keldor.” The Man-At-Arms speaks with a low growl. “One week ago, he returned.”

“That doesn’t sound so bad,” Bow mumbles.

“He had a madness in his eyes and a terrible staff in his hands, following an army of Horde machines that attacked the city.”

“Oh.”

“The royal guards tried to stop him, but he fought through them alone.” His voice is dark and he holds a trembling fist at his side. The guards around them look between one another but say nothing. “He was casting magic. *Real* magic. We had no defense against it. The Horde machines kept most of our forces occupied while Keldor fought his way to the throne room. King Randor tried to reason with him. He begged Keldor to explain what was going on, but he only laughed. He cast a spell on the King. Some sort of dark sorcery that broke his will and bent him to Keldor’s control.

My soldiers fought off his army. But Keldor escaped with the King." He looks Adora in the eyes. "We've heard nothing from the Horde itself since Keldor's return and all our parties sent to reason with him have been turned away. He has a simple set of demands: Queen Marlena and the Prince are to abdicate the throne and denounce all claims and inheritances to it. They are to flee the lands of Eternos and never return. Anything perceived as an attack against him means we are voluntarily forfeiting the King's life. Keldor claims that King Randor has already agreed to this, but…"

"He's definitely still being mind-controlled," Bow says.

The Man-At-Arms nods. "Beyond this hall is the throne room. The Queen waits for you there. She has been told of your arrival and is eager to meet with you."

"Could we have a moment to speak with our queen first?" Adora asks as diplomatically as she can. "Diplomatic… permission, and all that stuff."

He raises an eyebrow, but nods.

Adora grabs Catra and Bow by the shoulders and pulls them away from the royal guards, hopefully out of earshot. "Do you have your tracker-pad on you?"

"Always," he says, already pulling it out.

"Call Glimmer. If we're doing this, we're getting her go-ahead first. That's a requirement for this political stuff, right?"

They only shrug.

She sighs. "And that's why I'm the princess of punching things. Let's get her caught up."

The tracker-pad activates with a beeping sound and a crackling screen. Glimmer is quick to respond, and Bow summarizes everything they've learned as succinctly as possible.

“Oh,” she says. “Yikes.”

“Yeah,” Bow says. “You’re the one with all the royal know-how. Any advice on this?”

Glimmer forces out a breath. “Honestly? Go for it.”

“Wait, really?” Adora asks.

“Etheria needs allies. If you help these Eternians get their king back, then that might be one more than we had before. You said the queen was already waiting for you?”

They nod.

“Let me talk to her. We can figure out more that way.”

“Alright,” Bow says. He holds the pad against his chest so that Glimmer can see the hall and chamber in front of them.

They walk back to the Man-At-Arms. He looks at the tracker-pad. “Queen Glimmer, I presume?”

“You presume correctly.”

“Your majesty,” he bows, then holds a hand out toward the throne room. “Right this way.”

The dark hall opens into a grand, shining chamber with a gargantuan domed ceiling lined with thousands of hanging crystals that refract and shine sunlight in a kaleidoscope of color. The light is directed to the top of a crystal staircase that stretches from wall to wall and slopes up dozens of feet with three thrones at its peak. They are carved from red stone and feature tall, slanted backs. The leftmost one sits shorter than the rest, while the rightmost throne has a rug covering the floor next to it. It is the only throne occupied. A woman, red-haired and wearing a green gown and golden crown, sits tall, her face proud but eyes sunken and dark. A boy, blond-haired and blue-eyed, lounges on the steps beneath her. A green tiger as long as he is tall lays

beside him, leaning into his touch as he scratches behind its ear. But the tiger watches them as they enter and its ears flatten. The boy—a man about Adora's age, she realizes as they come closer—props himself up on his elbow, but does not stand. They stop at the foot of the stairs. The red-haired woman, who can only be the queen, gestures to the Man-At-Arms.

"Queen Marlena and Prince Adam of Eternos: I present to you Catra, Bow, She-Ra, and Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon."

"Your majesties," they say and bow slightly out of sync. Bow holds his tracker-pad forward so that Glimmer remains upright.

"I welcome you not only to this court, but Eternos and all of Eternia as well," the queen says.

"You are most gracious in your hospitality," Glimmer says in what Adora recognizes as her "queenly duties" voice. They continue on in some formal rapport that Adora loses interest in and track of. She would have studied monarchical formalities if she'd known there would be a queen involved. For now, she simply trusts Glimmer to navigate them into the Eternian's good graces and elect their next course of action. The prince takes his time looking between each of them. Adora briefly meets his eyes, but his focus falls to something lower, though if it is the sword she holds or Melog, who sits between her and Catra, she cannot tell. He whispers something to the tiger, who quickly stands up and sits behind him, warily looking over the prince's shoulder. Adora holds back a confused smile, while the prince laughs out loud.

Queen Marlena stops talking and turns to him. "Adam, is there something important that you'd like to add?"

"It's nothing, mother." He stands and pets the tiger's head. "I was just trying to help Cringer make a new friend."

"Oh yeah?" Catra asks. "And which of us were you trying to set him up with?"

“Catra!” Bow says from the side of his mouth. “Queens are talking.”

If Queen Marlena or Glimmer take offense to the bantering, they don’t show it.

“Well, the little one, of course,” the prince says. “He’s already scared of you. But you’re scared of a lot of things, aren’t you, buddy?” He pets the tiger again, who refuses to come out from behind his legs.

The queen sighs.“Your attempts at levity are always appreciated Adam, but perhaps you should leave the jestering to the court’s jester.”

“But we don’t have a jester?” He blinks. “Ah. Of course, mother.” He turns to them and bows his head then clears his throat, a slight redness to his cheeks. “My apologies.”

“It’s fine,” Bow says. “Right? It’s fine.”

Adora nods.

Catra shrugs.

“Your humility is appreciated and respected, Prince Adam,” Glimmer says. The prince stands a little taller hearing that, and the Man-At-Arms hides a sigh. “Queen Marlena. If Keldor has made himself an ally of the Horde, then he has made himself an enemy of not only Brightmoon, but all of Etheria. Even if he’s only used the Horde’s weapons, that is an action we cannot condone. My warriors,” they all try to subtly pose more heroically, “are prepared to do battle, if that is what it takes.”

“I don’t doubt it. But what of my husband? Keldor has threatened his life if anyone takes action against him. Would you be willing to risk your lives to save his?”

“Not to brag, your majesty,” Adora says, “but that’s kind of our entire M.O. Besides, we’ve fought worse than some schmuck with

a magic stick.”

Queen Marlena smiles. “I suppose I can’t begrudge the confidence of the one who slew the Old Enemy.”

The Man-At-Arms steps forward. “With respect, my Queen, they have not seen what Keldor is capable of. If we send these outsiders to face him alone we could be sending them to their deaths. The King would die with them. If you would allow me to accompany them, I could provide them with experience against Keldor and Eternia as a whole.”

“Your services are needed here, Man-At-Arms.”

“They need a guide.”

“And Eternos needs its greatest soldier.”

“So does her King.” His back is stiff, held perfectly perpendicular to the ground. He stares forward, expressionless, but his voice betrays a rising anger.

Queen Marlena shakes her head. “I cannot risk leaving Eternos undefended. What if you were to leave and something happened to the city? To Adam?”

“There are guards that remain here, champions all. They drove out the Horde and were only stopped by Keldor’s dark sorcery. He will not risk showing himself again.”

“And my son?”

The prince looks down, obviously uncomfortable with the sudden focus directed at him, completely unable to speak for himself. It is a feeling Adora knows well.

“Adam has his warrior. Teela defended him in the first attack and would doubtless succeed again. There is no one better suited to the task.”

Queen Marlena closes her eyes and holds the arms of her throne until her knuckles turn white. “There is none better suited to defending this palace.”

“And while we defend this castle, who will protect the rest of our people?”

She stares at him. Her eyes are narrow, but slowly begin to soften until her face drops and she holds her head. “Very well,” she says, quietly. “Etherians. I leave this decision to you. Duncan, our Man-At-Arms, offers his services in your quest. Will you have him in your party?”

Bow and Catra look at Adora. Adora looks at Glimmer. Glimmer is already looking at her. Adora looks at the queen. “A moment to convene, Mrs. Your Majesty?”

“Of course.”

The Man-At-Arms—or, just Man-At-Arms—has not moved and still stares straight ahead. A bead of sweat runs down the side of his face.

They huddle up, Bow’s tracker-pad sitting on his and Adora’s shoulders and resting against their heads.

“Glimmer?” Adora asks. “This is your mission. Your call.”

She shakes her head. “I’m not in the field, and you know this Man-At-Arms guy better than I do. This is up to you guys.”

“Hmm.” Bow holds his chin. “He’s right about experience. We’re in uncharted waters. We could use the extra help.”

Adora grimaces. “But we have no idea how he works in a team. I don’t even think he wants to be in a team.”

Bow frowns. “Maybe we can—”

“I vote yes,” Catra says.

“What?” Adora asks. “Why?”

“I want to see what his guns do.”

“They look pretty powerful,” Bow says.

“Can you turn me so I can see them?” Glimmer asks.

“Guys!” Adora says. “We need to focus.”

“I’m focused on how useful he could be,” Bow says.

“I care about that too,” Catra says.

“You’re in charge out there. It’s up to you, Adora,” Glimmer says.

“Course it is,” she mutters.

They’ve never fought Keldor before. He has.

They’ve never been on Eternia before. He has.

They know almost nothing about this world or who they’re fighting. He does.

But they know just as little about him. Who he is. What he’s willing to do.

But he’s just as driven to fight the Horde as they are. At least, in this specific circumstance.

Who is she to deny her friends potential help?

Doesn’t she have a responsibility to protect them from a potential threat?

Potential risks.

Potential rewards.

Insurmountable odds and only herself, the squad, and a host of strangers she has no choice but to trust their lives with.

What's new?

"I hope he's not this grumpy all the time." Adora brings herself to She-Ra's fullest height and looks at Man-At-Arms, then the queen. "We shall," she declares.

Bow scrambles to catch his tracker-pad after her dramatic stand-up.

Queen Marlena nods. "Man-At-Arms, I appoint you to guide and protect our new allies. Take them to Keldor, see to it that he is dealt justice, and bring my husband home."

He steps forward and nods. "My Queen, it shall be so. I swear this on my life."

"I hope you will not have to make good on that promise."

Man-At-Arms addresses them. "Keldor and the Horde have remained at Snake Mountain, and so that is where we must go. A larger party risks drawing too much attention. It can be no more than the four of us now."

Melog mews.

"Five," Catra says.

"Five," he says. "We'll travel by Wind Raider. They're small, fast, and difficult to track. We take one to the western coast and chart a ship to ferry us across the sea. From there, it's a matter of reaching Snake Mountain, finding the King, and making sure he's safe before eliminating Keldor and the Horde."

"When do we leave?" Bow asks.

"Take the rest of the day to prepare what you'll need. Rest well, tonight. We leave at dawn."

It always sounds so simple, Adora thinks. Get in, beat the bad guy, save the day. All they have to do is kick Keldor's head in and bring the king home.

So why does the prince look so scared?

Catra sighs through her nose, leaning into Adora's touch. For the past half hour, she has tried—that really is the keyword, Catra thinks—to braid her hair. But Catra's hair is as wild as the rest of her, and the thick, wiry stuff comes undone once more, springing out of the braid back into the unruly spikes she never imagined she'd miss so much.

"Dammit!" Adora says.

"I think you're getting the hang of it," Catra lies. "You should try again."

Adora folds her arms and huffs. "You just like it when I touch you."

"Obviously."

They had been offered a room in the palace for the night. A small token, Man-At-Arms had told them, in thanks for offering their help. More would come, Catra was sure, that Adora and Bow would try to be humble about and refuse. "Helping the universe is its own reward," he had said once.

“We learned our lesson about parties,” Adora had agreed. Catra would see to it that they’d all reap the just rewards of their efforts, as she had before. It is not a matter of selfish desire—if she wanted more for her work she’d have no problem “negotiating” it, she recognizes with pangs of regret that she does not force away—but practicality: you can’t save the universe on an empty stomach. And their stomachs are not empty, not tonight, thanks to the meal provided before they had all retired for their final preparations. Catra had no idea how something so simple as baked fish could taste so good.

“So this is really how you’re prepping for a deadly mission?” Bow asks from the single, very large, bed provided. He sits cross-legged with his bow beside and a comical amount of arrows arrayed before him. Some of them are even normal-looking.

Rations are to be provided by the Eternians, and none of them have any desire to eat more of the ones stocked aboard Darla. Extra clothes took less than an hour to pack. Hygienic products were taken care of with them.

“I can summon my sword. I don’t need to carry anything.”

“Same.” Catra flashes her claws.

Bow slouches against the pillows and grumbles to himself, eyeing the dozens of different arrows of which he can only take a precious few. “Basic explosion or goo trap? No, I’ll need both. Should I make one that does both?”

“Can you make one that turns into something useful?” Catra asks.

“Catra!” he groans. “This is serious!”

“So am I.”

“Adora, make her stop.”

“I dunno, Bow. She’s kinda cute when she gets snarky.”

Catra lets that slide, but only because it was Adora. “I’m a badass,” she mumbles, blushing.

Adora hugs her from behind and lays her chin on Catra’s shoulder. “You’re my badass.” Catra growls and kisses her, lightly, little more than a peck on the lips. Adora tries to go for more, but Catra rolls out of her grip and scoots away. Adora is already on top of her and holds her shoulders against the wall, looming above her, silhouetted by the ceiling light. “Hey, Catra.”

“Meow.”

“Oh, I know!” Bow says with mock enthusiasm. “I’ll make a ‘Please focus on the life-threatening quest we’re about to go on and not kissing each other', arrow. I don’t know what I’d use it for, but I think I can come up with something.”

Adora laughs, but has a deeper blush on her face. She clears her throat and pulls Catra away from the wall, straightening a hanging tapestry disrupted by their movement.

“Cockblock,” Catra says to Bow.

“Not my fault they only gave us one room.”

“You could have slept on the ship.”

He sticks his tongue out.

She flips him off. She turns to Adora for backup but finds her holding the tapestry out of the way, running her fingers along an inscription carved into the wall.

“Look at this,” she says. “This isn’t First Ones’ writing. Well, it is, kind of. But it’s different.” She points to another above the door. “That’s just like everything else I’ve read, and it’s part of the stonework.” Bow scoots to the edge of the bed and Catra comes next to Adora’s shoulder. “This was carved later.” She holds the tapestry out. “They tried to cover it up.”

“Royal graffiti?” Catra asks. “What does it say?”

Adora points back at the door. “That’s just a number. This has words. I can’t really translate it, not accurately, but I think it’s a poem. ‘Happy be the smallest ones; who hold the later person.'”

“And that means... what?”

“I have no idea.”

“Maybe it’s, like, the poetic equivalent of abstract art,” Bow says. “You’re not supposed to get it.”

“Still.” Adora stares at the inscription like it actually says something coherent. “This is still based on First Ones writing. If the people who wrote it could understand that, then…”

She gets a look in her eyes, a glint that Catra recognizes despite how rarely it appears. “Remember what Light Hope told you? What Horde Prime said? The First Ones had an empire. A big one. These guys might be their descendants, but they’re probably not the only ones out there.”

“But they’re the only ones we’ve found so far. I’m not saying…” She looks down, then to Catra. “But there’s a chance, right?”

Adora’s eyes are wide, shining, and the richest blue. She looks at Catra with a desperate air that sends a piercing pang through her heart. She gulps. “Maybe.”

Adora’s face drops, and she sighs. “Or maybe not.”

From the corner of her eye, Catra can see Bow, waving her on, panicked.

“But hey!” Catra says with forced energy. “When I said ‘might be’ I meant, ‘probably definitely.’ So they’re basically your cousins.”

“How do you know that?” Adora asks.

“They all smell like you,” Catra says. She points a thumb over her shoulder toward the door. “Especially the guy that’s been standing outside our room for the last ten minutes.”

“Huh?” Adora, Bow, and a muffled voice ask at the same time.

Adora has her sword in hand and her arm in front of Catra. Bow springs up from the bed and across the room then shoulders the door, holding it shut.

“Why didn’t you say anything?” she whispers to Catra.

“I wanted to see how long it’d take him to knock.”

Bow looks at Adora.

She nods.

He throws the door open and shields himself with its bulk while Adora holds her sword out in a battle-ready stance.

Whoever stood in its frame first is instantly obscured by a white blur and the whooshing sound of a bo staff as a woman takes shape in front of him. Her hair is auburn and pulled back into a long ponytail. She wears a skirted white unitard armored in bronze and holds a snake-headed staff toward Adora, glaring with dark green eyes. They flick toward Catra, who stands passive, before moving back to Adora. “I told you they can’t be trusted,” she says to the one behind her. “Run. I’ll deal with them while you get the guards.”

“Or,” he says, “we could greet our guests with a little more hospitality.” He slips past her and, without looking, dodges her attempt to pull him back. “Sorry about that. This is Teela. She’s my bodyguard and takes her job very seriously.”

She holds the staff leveled at them as she slinks her way beside him.

Bow peaks his head around the door. “Prince Adam?” he asks.

“Yes,” he says with a smile. “Hello. Everyone.” He nods to each of them, even Melog, who sleeps uncaring in the far corner of the room. He tugs at the collar of his shirt and straightens out the pink vest he wears over it. “Hello.”

Adora drops her stance and her sword disappears. “You already said that.”

Teela raises her staff, holding it like a walking stick, but still eyes them, warily.

“Yes!” Adam says. He continues, moving his hands as he talks. “I did. I just came here to thank you for your very generous offer of, well I’m sure you already know, since you were there when it happened, but…” He scratches the back of his head. “Thank you! It’s very generous and kind. The royal family thanks you. Which I am a part of.”

“You’re welcome?” Bow asks.

Catra and Adora nod. “It’s what we do,” Adora says.

“But I didn’t just come here to thank you, which I do, I’d also like… You see, it’s… Well, it’s kind of, um…” He shuts his eyes and taps his foot against the ground. “It’s a little complicated, but I was just wondering, or inquiring, really, if…” He forces himself to swallow and his eyes dart around the room. They fall on the tapestry and carving behind it. “If you were enjoying the room! If it’s up to standards, that is.” Adam flashes a smile, almost blinding Catra with the pristine whiteness of his teeth.

Adora and Bow shrug, muttering confirmations of its quality.

“That’s it?” Catra asks. “That’s really what you came here to ask?”

“Of course. It’s very important.”

“Is it?”

“Why wouldn’t it be?” He walks to the tapestry and pulls it aside. “This was my old nursery, after all. I hope it’s as comfortable for you as it was for me. I assume it was, anyway. I was a baby. I don’t remember much of it.”

“Well,” Adora says. “It’s a good room.”

“Good! That’s good.”

He just stands there.

“While you’re here,” Bow says, “Do you mind reading what that says? We don’t exactly know… whatever language it is.”

“Well, it’s Eternian, obviously. So’s that,” he says, pointing to the number above the door. “Just a bit more archaic. This is just a little thing my father added to the room when I was born.” He holds a finger up and closes his eyes. “‘Blessed be our children; they who hold our future.’ It’s a proverb or something like that.”

“Why’d they cover it up?” Adora asks.

“Well, this isn’t a nursery anymore.”

“Oh, yeah. That’s true. That’s true.”

“It says children,” Catra says.

“And?” Adam asks.

“No one mentioned any other royal kids.”

“Oh, yes. I guess my parents thought they were going to have more.” He chuckles. “But I’m an only child. I was *the* only child in the palace until Teela showed up. Inseparable ever since.” He throws an arm around her shoulder and tries to pull her closer, but she stands stiff and Adam only pulls himself against her. “And not just because it’s her job.”

Her face is firm, but a slight tinge of red creeps into her cheeks.

"But I'd hate to overstay my welcome, and since I took care of the exact thing I came here to ask about, I'll leave you all to your… *Fwooshing."* Catra realizes he's imitating the sound of Adora summoning her sword. He gives a few swings to an imaginary one of his own.

He and Teela turn to leave, but Adam only gets a single foot through the door before Adora says, "It's *fw-shing."*

"Huh?"

"You said *fwooshing.* There's no *'oo'* sound. It's just…" She mimics swinging a sword. *"Fw-shing."*

"It sounded more like a," he pantomimes a sword strike, *"fwooshung* to me."

"Yeah, but you heard it through the door. That's gonna mess with the sound." She mimics a parry-strike. *"Fw-shing."*

He takes a sword-summoning stance. *"Fwooshang."*

She corrects his pronunciation.

He does it wrong again.

And then they keep going.

Catra can't bring herself to keep track of how long they swing fake swords at each other while making the strangest sounds she's ever heard. It would be funny if she didn't have to experience it firsthand. Bow seems more intrigued than anyone should be. Teela sighs into her hand. Catra just stares.

"Adora," she says, who stops mid-swing to look at her. "Why don't you just summon your sword?"

"That's a really good idea," Adam says.

Adora nods, then holds out her hand. In a brilliant burst of light and sharp ringing sound, the sword of She-Ra appears. “Oh, yeah,” she says. “That’s a *shwing.”*

“Definitely a *shwing.”*

“Mhmm,” Bow agrees.

“Glad we’re all on the same page,” Teela mumbles.

Adam looks as if he’s about to say something, but stops himself then asks Adora, “I thought your name was She-Ra?”

“I’m Adora,” she says, pointing to herself. “She-Ra is when I do the whole,” she holds her sword up and makes an explosion sound. “Y’know?”

“Oh. I thought it was permanent. Well, Cringer doesn’t like being left alone, so I’ll leave you to your *shwinging.* Good night.”

They exchange a round of pleasantries, and Adam leaves, Teela following him without a word.

Bow shuts the door behind them with a wave. “He’s nice,” he says.

“He’s an idiot,” Catra says.

“Right?” Adora puts her hands on her hips. “I know I got it wrong too, but *'fwooshing?'* Really?”

Catra smiles at Adora then wraps an arm around her shoulder and wonders how she survived all those years without her.

The sun is yet to rise. A chill wind sweeps through the hangar. Man-At-Arms straps down the last of his packs on the Wind Raider: a machine consisting of little more than a winged sled with a jet engine bolted to either side. Bow doesn't doubt the faith Man-At-Arms places in the vehicles, but when they were described to him as analog he hadn't taken that to mean antiquated.

"No computer systems to be detected, no delicate electronics to be disrupted, and they can fly low enough to avoid any eyes looking to the skies." Man-At-Arms pats the hood. "They're not the fastest, but they are reliable. This one will get us to Snake Mountain, so long as we find a boat to get it across the sea."

"They can't fly above water?" Bow asks. He peeks inside the turbine, idly analyzing its inner workings.

"They can, but the engines need time to cool after prolonged use, or we risk overheating them. Not a good situation to be in, one hundred miles from shore." He watches Bow inspect the vehicle. "Are you fond of machinery, Bow?"

"I'm something of an engineer."

"You'll have to tell me more about Etherian technology on the way, then. Especially those curious arrows you carry." He pulls at his mustache. "That is, if you don't mind."

"You want to know about my trick arrows?" he whispers, eyes wide.

"I may be Man-At-Arms, but I'm also the royal palace's chief engineer. Any chance to learn something new is not one I'm like to pass along."

"We're going to have *so much* to talk about."

"Oh, and feel free to call me Duncan."

Catra and Adora enter, the former still rubbing the sleep out of her eyes. “Did it really have to be so early?” she asks.

“We can’t risk being seen and we’ll need all the daylight we can get,” Duncan says. “Officially, we’re not leaving for another three days, and it will be as a diplomatic party coming from the Sands of Time. If all goes as planned, we’ll hit Keldor before he even knows we’ve left.”

“If.” Adora’s eyes are dark, and not, Bow thinks, from a lack of sleep.

“If,” Duncan agrees. “Is that everything you’ll be needing?” He nods his head toward the packs each of them has slung over their shoulders.

“Yep,” they say.

“I’ve brought more for when you change your mind.” He pulls himself into the Wind Raider and offers a hand to Bow, who takes the seat next to him. Catra and Adora take the two behind them and Catra throws her legs over Adora’s lap, nestling herself into the crook of the seat and door. Duncan flicks a series of switches along the dashboard and a low hum comes from beneath the hood, then the engines at their sides. He pushes a large red button and they rise from the hangar floor. The jets power up with a fiery scream. “Are we ready?”

Adora and Bow nod. Catra gives a thumbs up. Duncan angles the wheel forward, and with thunderous force they shoot out of the hangar toward the rolling fields of Eternos and the distant lands beyond.

Chapter End Notes

Alternate title: Bow Gets Another Dad

Old Stories and New Friends

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The night was warm, as nights in Brightmoon often were. Adora walked the halls alone, except for idle guards who strolled lazily from their posts and nodded as she passed. Their lack of caution was a mistake, she thought, but she could not bring herself to truly care. After all, what had they to watch for? What was there to fear? The war was over. Prime was defeated and Etheria was saved. Horde resistance had crumbled and even the old loyalists had long been dealt with. Any threats now were hypothetical. Potentials not yet accounted for—not yet proven to even exist. That potential was enough for Adora to worry, plan for, and prepare against, but she had learned already that many in Brightmoon, even its most elite guards, simply did not care enough to worry about what had been, for over a thousand years, nearly mythological: stars, the universe they inhabited, and what lay within.

But she knew better. Glimmer knew. Catra, as well. There were dangers out there, hidden amongst the stars. Secrets that had been unspoken for millennia, last whispered on dying lips and remembered only by a madman—dangers that even Horde Prime had not defeated. He knew more than Adora and all of Etheria could ever hope to learn, and despite the threat he posed and the relief she felt every time she remembered he was gone, most of that knowledge died with him.

Most.

The sounding of her boots against stone echoed through dimly lit halls, illuminated only by moonlight through curtained windows and scarce, faint lamps. She stopped in front of a door, as elaborate as any other in the castle, but the only one posted with guards. They stood silent, still as stone. Halberds were held in a

constant cross over the door and they did not look at Adora as she stared at them.

She stepped forward, and they cleared the way. The door was opened and closed without a sound, the only thing betraying her entrance to the darkened room being the fall of her foot, and—she knew he could hear—the quickened pace of her heart. A bed, uprooted and pushed to the side, sat against a wall. A holo-map of Etheria stood in the center of the floor. Its flickering display was obscured by the only other figure in the room. Between the two of them was a barrier born from magic that bisected the floor and reached up to the ceiling.

Her voice was quiet but firm, reverberating through the empty air. "Hordak."

He stood with his back turned to her, silhouetted by the map's soft purple glow.

Hordak turned. His eyes shone green, webbed with veins of red that circled their edges and crept toward the center. His lips were pulled back in a half-hearted snarl—his fangs, once white, were now stained with a reddish tint—that dropped the moment he saw her. "It's not often I receive visitors at this hour." His voice was quiet. Disinterested.

Fear was not the word to describe what Adora felt in Hordak's presence. Catra had beaten him alone when he was at his strongest, and She-Ra, despite what Catra might say to the contrary, was far stronger than her. Hordak now was a far cry from what he had once been. He had no troops to command, no armor to guard him, nor cannon to wield. He wore only a rudimentary exoskeleton designed to provide the bare minimum of support for his body and keep his nebulous defect at bay. What that illness entailed he confided only in Entrapta, who, despite efforts otherwise, kept such information to herself. Had he any of what he possessed before, the barrier still separated them, and Hordak, like his brother, never had a true answer to powers of magic.

She was not afraid of him, yet her heart beat quicker than before and every sense she possessed told her he remained a threat. He came to Etheria with nothing but a ruined hulk of a ship and nearly conquered the entire planet. Hordak was lessened now, but she would never consider him to be safe. Not for her friends, not for her family, not for all of Etheria. He was dangerous and would be for as long as he lived. But, despite the many, many, arguments otherwise, he was too useful to let die.

"You don't get visitors at all." She held up a finger. "Entrapta doesn't count."

He sneered. "What do you want?"

"Information."

"You'll have to be more specific than that, Adora."

A shiver ran down her spine. It was, in that moment as she could recall, the first time Hordak had ever spoken her name. Despite the conditional amnesty he had been granted, Hordak was, and in some ways remained, Adora's oldest enemy. To hear him speak to her in such a casual way, to even use her name, filled her with a kind of unease that bordered on revulsion. She gritted her teeth. "Horde Prime's enemies. The ones that outlived him. I need to know what Etheria is up against."

He flicked his hand. "I'll have a dossier prepared, though I hope you'll give it more attention than your queen did my proposal for the reconstruction of Salineas."

Adora scoffed. "What, did her ignoring it hurt your feelings?"

"I merely question the point of my imprisonment if you aren't using what I'm being kept here to create."

"Your job is to give us ways to fix your *mistakes.* We *decide if we'll use them."*

He bowed his head. "If you insist."

"No, you don't get to act all humble about this." She jabbed her finger each time she spoke. "You came here. You destroyed Etheria. You brought Horde Prime here. You hurt my friends. My family. You're the reason all *of this happened, and you still* lost. *This is failure, Hordak. Your failure."*

"Is there anything else you need?" he asked. The corner of his lip twitched.

She stared at him, wrathful eyes boring through the scant barrier between them.

"Very well," he said, turning back to his map.

She watched him as he pulled up a scan of the Fright Zone that shifted and warped into a castle she did not recognize. The only word she could make out from where she stood was 'Scorpia'. Hordak continued in silence. The holo-map crackled with ambient energy.

"You said you remembered me."

"I did."

She clenched her fists. "So you remember when you found me?"

"I do."

"Do you know where I came from?"

"No."

"Did you find my name with me?"

"No."

She shut her eyes. "Did you name me?"

"No."

She spoke through closed teeth. "Did Shadow Weaver?"

“Shouldn’t you ask her?”

Adora blinked. Her mouth hung open and her brows wrinkled. Didn’t he know? How could he not? "She’s dead.”

"Then her secrets died with her.”

Everything felt too light, as if she were seconds from losing her footing and floating into the sky with no way down. Her breath came in short, quiet bursts. “Why?”

“Why, what?” He asked, finally turning back to her. If the tone of his voice did not betray his emotion, then the look of petty contempt did.

“Why did you take me?”

“It would have been foolish to leave a potential asset to die.”

Her jaw clenched and her nose flared. “That’s not the only reason.”

“And what would you have me say? What is it you came here to learn?” He raised his eyebrows and looked down on her. “That I pitied you? That I was stricken by the horror of a child abandoned? Hmm?” His eyes widened. “Do you think I found you by that portal and saw something familiar? Another miserable wretch cast aside and abandoned on this backwater planet? Do you think you're anything like me?” His voice was level and calm, but his eyes had twisted into those of an animal enraged. Adora kept his gaze, steeling her look against his. He growled and turned away, then gripped the edges of his holo-map’s projector with crushing force. Streams of oil leaked between his fingers. He looked over his shoulder. “Is that what you wanted to hear?”

Something pulls at the base of her skull.

On instinct, she turns in its direction, toward a forest they fly westward along. It’s not a physical sensation, but a feeling. One that beckons her closer. Drawing her in.

She felt it first the night before, as they had all curled to sleep in the Eternian's palace. She dreamt a strange dream then, of a looming castle whose drawbridge opened like a jaw and compelled her to enter. She woke before she could.

That feeling had come again throughout the day since, though she could find no pattern in its coming nor reason for its happening.

Nerves, she told herself.

Catra stretches her legs out and Adora rests an arm over them. Melog shifts back into view on the floor of the Wind Raider. "I don't know why you bothered," Catra says. "You didn't even cloak us."

Melog chirps.

"Then why'd you do it?"

They make a low grumbling sound.

Catra laughs. "That thing was scared of *you.* How could you be afraid?"

"Friendship with the tiger not working out?" Adora asks.

"Doesn't look like it."

Adora pouts. "I was looking forward to the play-dates."

"See?" Catra holds a hand toward Adora. "You're breaking her heart."

Melog growls and turns invisible.

"Save that juice for later, you big softie. Not a lot of magic going around out here."

Or none at all, Adora thought. As far as they had learned, Melog drew power from ambient magic and was capable of storing it

when such wells fell dry. The distant reaches of space harbored less and less magic as they traveled, and it became more and more difficult to anchor new planets to Etheria's magical source. For the last month, it had been impossible. She-Ra was intrinsically bound to Etheria's magic and harbored a connection to the unchained planet that allowed Adora to transform, even now. That link could bind magicless planets to Etheria and restore the natural order taken from them by the First Ones and Mara's sacrifice. But something, be it distance or another force, prevented this restoration in recent systems. It was an issue with no apparent solution, and with the remnants of the Horde still active, it was an issue that would have to wait. The universe survived a thousand years without magic. Adora reasons that it can survive a few more.

The fields of Eternos stretch from horizon to horizon, filled with tall grass, gently rolling hills, and sparse groupings of trees that become denser the further they go. Dome-skulled, tusked bovine beasts as tall as the trees travel in small herds. Man-At-Arms keeps the Wind Raider at the level of their heads, weaving between the groups and minding a healthy distance. Still, the younger and more brazen animals run alongside them, bleating out low calls and peering into the vehicle.

"Unilopes," Man-At-Arms says above the sound of the engines. "They're mostly docile, but sensitive to foul smells. These ones are just curious."

A unilope, smaller than the rest, cranes its neck, bringing its eye level with Adora's. It puffs through its nose and makes a sound like a very, very large goat. Adora reaches out to gently scratch its snout. The unilope bleats again and leans into her touch, then trots away to a pair of ones far larger than it.

"They're kind of adorable," Bow says as the last of the animals quickly lose interest.

"You want one?" Catra asks, nudging Adora's shoulder. "I bet it'd be a better 'noble steed' than Swiftwind."

“Don’t say that about Swifty! He’s a great steed.”

“You didn’t even bring him.”

“He doesn’t like the ship.”

“Can’t you guys breathe in space?”

“There’s no way he’d be able to keep up.”

“So, like, build a pen for him and chain it to the back of the ship. Easy.”

“How would you feel if I said that about Melog?”

“I’d call you stupid because Melog is perfect and deserves the universe.” The magic space cat purrs into her hand as Catra talks.

Adora lets her head fall back and watches the clouds as the wind tugs at her ponytail. Man-At-Arms and Bow talk about his tracker-pad and something about its power system.

“I’d love to crack it open and show you how it works, but you’re driving and I don’t want to break it and risk not being able to talk to Glimmer.”

“You send field reports directly to your queen?” Man-At-Arms asks.

“Well, kind of. Usually, she’d be out here with us, but she couldn’t come on this trip.”

“You Etherians have a very hands-on monarchy.”

“She’s pretty amazing.” There’s a wistfulness to his voice. Through a side-long mirror, Adora can see Man-At-Arms’ very thick eyebrow raise.

“You’re in love,” he says.

“Huh?! Well, I mean, yeah, but is it that obvious?”

“Yeah,” Adora says.

“Definitely,” Catra agrees.

Man-At-Arms nods. “These missions, then. Are they an attempt to win her favor?”

“No, not really. But also, kind of? We’re already, like, a thing. We kinda were unofficially for a while, but now we’re, y’know, and it’d be cool to impress her, I guess.”

Catra and Adora share a grin at his awkward expense.

“You’re her paramour,” Man-At-Arms says.

“Eh?” Bow asks.

Catra starts laughing into her hand.

“You’re her paramour,” he says matter-of-factly. “She didn’t introduce you as royalty, and I presume you’re not engaged?”

“That’s kind of a big thing you need to talk about first.”

“Then until you’re wed, you are the queen’s paramour. Of course, this is assuming Etherian royal courts function like that of Eternos. Am I correct?”

Bow tries to say something, but Catra is quick to place a hand on his shoulder and says, “No, no that’s definitely right. Isn’t it, Mister Paramour of Brightmoon?”

“That’s not a real title,” he squeaks.

“No,” Man-At-Arms says, “but when you are wed—”

“If.”

“If, then you would be the Prince Consort. A very real title.”

“Micah was married to Angella, but they still call him a king,” Adora says.

“He is,” Bow says. “Or, was. I know Angella was calling all the shots in the court, and she was *definitely* queen.”

“King Consort, then,” Man-At-Arms says. “Functionally the same, if not as commonly used. A matter of ego, if you want my opinion.”

“What do you think, future Prince or King Consort?” Catra asks.

“Possible future Prince or King Consort,” Bow says behind a blush.

“You just admitted you’re thinking about it!”

“No I didn’t!”

“You totally did!”

“I did not!”

“Adora, back me up here.”

“You kinda did,” she says.

“I’m keeping my options open!”

The camp consists of three tents, each facing a small fire centered in a small semi-circle of sparse trees. The Wind Raider is parked against the open side, its exposed half-covered with fallen branches. It's poor concealment, Adora knows, but it is, hopefully,

enough to stop them from blundering around with a target on their backs.

The sun is close to set and Adora places the last of the camouflage against the Winder Raider's flank.

Bow and Catra sit opposite Man-At-Arms around the fire; Adora takes the empty spot between them. "I hope I didn't miss anything important," she says.

Man-At-Arms shakes his head. "Bow was just explaining what you know about the Horde here."

It's a single ship, but one of the largest in their fleet. The official Horde designation for it was a series of numbers and letters that most found too difficult to remember, so rebel forces had taken to calling them Transporters. Their function is to transport smaller vessels incapable of long-distance travel and provide general support for ships with specialized roles. They're lucky the Horde here does not have access to a Destroyer: ships that, as Catra had told them, were capable of reducing entire continents to ash. A small fleet could level a planet.

If the Horde's attack on Eternos was anything to go by, they didn't have access to or did not utilize the smaller ships a Transporter typically operates with. Adora considers the second option more likely, if only to keep herself from being caught off guard later.

"He tells me that you have a standardized way of dealing with them?"

Adora hums an agreement. "The Horde has two weaknesses: magic and inflexibility. They don't have any way of detecting magic, so we use Melog to cloak ourselves and sneak close to their ships. Horde Prime was obsessed with structure and uniformity, so their systems are almost identical ship-to-ship. Bow managed to crack their security codes and they haven't been able to change them fast enough since." She pats Bow on the shoulder, who tries to hide how proud of himself he feels. "Once we're close

enough, he teleports us onboard. Melog keeps Bow and Catra cloaked while they sabotage the ship. That's when I bring out She-Ra."

"A warrior of pure magic," Man-At-Arms says. "Rather troublesome for them, I'd guess."

"She can wreck an entire ship by herself, " Catra says. "I think she lets us come so we don't get bored."

"*And* the Best Friends Squad always works best when we're together," Bow says. "Mostly together, at least."

"It is a lot easier when Glimmer's around," Adora admits.

"Your Queen fights with you?" Man-At-Arms asks.

"Yours doesn't?" Catra asks.

"The King and Queen have always believed words to be more powerful than swords. It's a noble idea, but hollow. Eternos has not been attacked since the Prince was a baby."

"What happened then?" Bow asks.

"Assassins tried to kill Adam. It's nothing important to us now," Man-At-Arms says. "You said the Horde has never had an answer to your magic?" he asks Adora.

"It's different now," she agrees, already knowing what he means to say. "We have to assume that Keldor will be at least as strong as She-Ra."

A gust of wind blows from the south. Catra's nose twitches.

"Rescuing the King will take priority over disabling the ship. Keldor must be eliminated before he learns of what we're doing. With that taken into account, how does your plan change?"

Adora holds her chin and Bow stares into the fire, losing himself in thought.

"I'm sure Teela and Adam will be able to help," Catra says.

They all look at her. She watches the fire reflect off her claws, feigning nonchalance.

"I'm sure they would," Man-At-Arms says slowly. "But, they're not with us."

"You sure about that?"

Man-At-Arms grimaces. "He wouldn't."

"I did," Adam says, standing up from the inside of a bush. Man-At-Arms holds his head in his hands and sighs. "Hello again." Adam waves, then straightens out his vest and steps forward, his ankle briefly caught on a branch.

"Teela," Man-At-Arms says without looking up. She steps out from behind a tree, pointedly looking everywhere except her superior. "You were supposed to guard him."

"I am," she says, stiffly.

"In the *palace."*

"I tried."

"I'm very difficult to keep a hold of," Adam says.

"I know." Man-At-Arms rubs his temples.

"Hey Adam," Bow says with a short wave.

"Hey, Bow," he says, smiling. "Adora. Catra. Melog, wherever they are." He nods as he looks at each of them, still smiling. "Duncan."

He glowers.

Adora clears her throat. “I think we’re all a little surprised by your decision to come here, Adam.” She holds her hands together. “Do you think you could elaborate on that?”

“Oh, yes. Well, it’s actually pretty simple. You see…” He stops, then looks up, closing his mouth. He opens it, but closes it again, then looks down. He breathes out through his nose. He holds his hands out, gesticulating as if speaking without saying any words. He touches his cheek, then points to Adora. She angles her head forward, waiting for him to start, but he huffs, then puts his hands on his hips. He looks remarkably confident for someone who has said so little.

Adora looks at Bow.

Bow shrugs.

She looks at Catra.

Catra shrugs.

“He wants to help,” Teela says. She steps forward and puts a hand on Adam’s shoulder. “So do I.”

“Absolutely not,” Man-At-Arms says.

“Duncan," Adam says, "I—”

“No. I won’t risk it.”

“You don’t have a choice.” Adam tries to stand taller.

Man-At-Arms narrows his eyes—a silent question.

“I’m the Prince,” Adam continues. “You’re the Man-At-Arms, sworn to the Royal Family. I’m part of that family. I’m going to help you.”

“This isn’t my mission to join, Adam.” He holds a hand toward Adora. “You’ll have to convince her.”

“Oh boy,” she says under her breath.

Adam holds his hands together and nods. “Ms. She-Ra, ma’am.” His eyes dart between her and Catra. “Mrs.?”

“Just Adora.”

“Right. Can I join your secret mission?”

Behind Adam, Man-At-Arms shakes his head.

“What makes you think you’d be a good fit?” she asks. Her hope is to get the prince to admit and then realize his lack of preparation for something like this; he’d be safer in the palace and a hindrance out here. A part of her already knows it won’t work.

“I want to help.”

“Okay. I think we can all agree that’s a wonderful sentiment to have,” she makes sure that Bow and Catra are nodding with her, “but have you ever been on a mission like this?”

“He’s never been on a mission at all,” Man-At-Arms says.

“Because no one would let me come,” Adam retorts.

“With good reason.”

“So you’ve never done anything like this?” Adora asks.

“No.”

“Have you ever fought before?”

“No,” he says, quieter this time.

“Do you know how to fight?”

He purses his lips. “I’m willing to learn?”

Adora taps her knee as Adam withers under Man-At-Arms stern look.

“How did you even find us?” Bow asks.

“We didn’t have to,” Teela says. “We followed you. We left just after you did.”

Man-At-Arms grumbles something into his hand. “Then news has already spread that the Prince is gone. Adora, if we take the time to return Adam, then that news may reach the Horde before we do.”

“They’d know something is wrong and we’d lose any advantage we might have now.” She stands. “Adam, if we have Teela take you back, you’d just sneak out again, right?”

He scratches his arm and doesn’t look at her. “Probably.”

“Teela, can you keep him safe while we do this?”

“I’ll protect him with my life.”

“No,” Man-At-Arms says, “If it gets to that point, you take him and run. I won’t risk losing both of you to a mission you never should have been on.”

“You don’t have to treat me like a child,” she says with a flushed face.

Man-At-Arms walks to her. “I do, and I will because you’re *my* child. You mean more than the world to me, Teela.” He puts a hand on her and Adam’s shoulders. “Both of you. Etherians, once more the decision is yours. Though I think they won’t take no for an answer.” He sounds annoyed, but Adora hears the slightest undercurrents of pride.

Adam and Teela watch them with expectant eyes.

Adora, Catra, and Bow huddle up.

“He’s her daughter and they’re in the royal guard together. That’s so sweet,” Bow says.

“Doesn’t change that they’ll probably just get in the way,” Catra mumbles.

Adora doesn’t disagree. “I don’t think we’ll be able to get rid of them.”

“As long as we keep prince Adam out of danger, then it should be fine, right?” Bow asks.

“That might be harder than it sounds,” Catra says.

“They could be fun to have around.”

“Well I’m not letting someone we just met into the Best Friends Squad, so don’t get any ideas.”

Bow gasps. “Then you admit you’re a part of it?”

“Yes! I have! Multiple times! When are you to stop making fun of me for it?”

“I’m not,” he says, wiping a tear away. “But I am proud.”

“Guys, focus,” Adora says. “How are we handling this?”

“He’s already got a bodyguard,” Catra says. “We just make sure she does her job.”

“Didn’t you just say it wouldn’t be that easy?” Adora asks.

“Well, I just remembered that other part, so shut up.”

“So we’re doing it, then?”

“I guess so,” Bow says.

“Yep,” Catra agrees.

“Okay then.” They stand and turn back to the Eternians. “Welcome to the mission.”

Adam punches the air and shakes Teela's shoulder. She smiles in what Adora guesses are a combination of relief and satisfaction.

"But you're not allowed to do any fighting, and you have to make sure he doesn't."

Adam deflates, but Teela nods. "I've gotten pretty good at that."

"Alright. Are we all okay with this?" No one speaks out, so Adora nods. "Whatever plan we decide on, we just have to make sure a couple more make it out safe."

"Wait," Adam says. "I didn't just come here to be a burden. I saw what Keldor's staff could do and all of us know what the Horde is capable of. I don't know how strong She-Ra is, but how would you feel about getting a little power boost?" He pulls out a weathered scroll and beckons everyone closer. They close in around him as he unfurls it.

It's a map of Eternia—old, by how faded the ink is and the larger geographic inaccuracies Adora can recognize from her brief view of the planet.

"I… don't really get out much," Adam says, "so I've had to look to legends for my adventures. Some of them talk about a king, one of Eternia's greatest, who fought the Horde in ancient times. When he died, he was buried here." He points to a marked spot on the map showing a stone castle with a great chasm surrounding it. "They say that a great power was buried with him. Whoever is worthy can gain access to the castle and the secrets within. So far, no one ever has, so it was forgotten." He looks at Adora with a sparkle in his eyes and a barely contained smile. "But who would be more worthy than you? She-Ra, the legendary warrior who killed the Old Enemy! You beat Horde Prime, did what he couldn't," he jabs a finger against the castle, "It has to be you!"

Adora steps back, the heat of expectation growing under her collar. She starts to mumble something, but the words die on her

lips.

“Adam, it’s only a legend,” Man-At-Arms says. “You don’t even know if it exists.”

“She-Ra was only a legend until she showed up on our doorstep. Why should this be different?”

Catra says, “Isn’t the element of surprise the only advantage we have right now? I don’t think it’s a good idea to waste time on an old story.”

“It’s not a waste of time, and it’s right by where we’d pass anyway. Look, it wouldn’t take more than half a day.”

From the path he draws with his finger, only the small arm of a larger forest lies between them and the castle. He points to the horizon, where the faintest beginnings of a deeper green can be seen.

Adora stares. Something keeps her from looking away. There, again. That feeling. Something pulling her closer. Beckoning her forward. Begging. Like a whisper, she can hear a voice on the winds.

“Adora.”

She knows magic when she feels it. Magic that shouldn’t exist here. Magic that, despite its familiarity, is distinct from that of Etheria in some way she can’t describe.

Memories of Light Hope and promised destinies flash through her mind, and all the struggles she faced to live beyond them. It would be dangerous, undoubtedly. A risk, as always. But not just for her, if she were to leave this new stone unturned.

Without taking her eyes from the horizon and the presence she can feel watching her back, she asks Adam, “This place. What’s it called?”

“Castle Grayskull.”

Chapter End Notes

You should all consider yourselves lucky because I was very close to expanding that Hordak segment into an entire fic in the middle of writing this one. I would not have survived without finding a way to write him into this story.

Also, He-Man has a new Netflix show (no, not the Kevin Smith one) and it's actually good. Like, good good. Maybe not season 5 She-Ra good (and it doesn't have The Gay Stuff, if that's why you like it), but it's honestly on par with season 1. If you've never seen a He-Man show (I'd have to ask why you're here, honestly) then it's a pretty fun introduction and probably the "objectively" best one ever. Nothing will ever beat Filmation's 4th wall breaking moral lessons, but Ram Ma'am makes for pretty good competition.

The Wrath of Stinkor

Chapter Notes

> If you know, you know. If you don't, just promise to bear with me, okay? The end notes will explain.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Wait, you guys have Grayskull, too?” Adora asks.

“Why wouldn’t we? Wait, you know who Grayskull is?”

“Wait, Grayskull is a person?”

“Why wouldn’t he be?”

“You just said it was a castle.”

“Named after the king.”

“Why didn’t you say his name when you were talking about him?”

“No one asked.”

Catra nudges Bow and whispers, “So, I’m not the only one who sees it, right?”

“Sees what?”

“Adora and Adam.”

“What about them?”

“Like… They look the same.”

“Catra!” he whisper-shouts.

“What?”

"You can't just say that because they're both First Ones!"

"Wha—?! Are you calling me *racist?"*

"It was a little out of line," Melog says, materializing beside her.

"You aren't a part of this conversation," Catra growls. "And stop wasting your magic."

"Adora will let me borrow hers."

Catra grumbles, knowing they're right. She says to Bow, "You don't even know if they're First Ones."

"They use First Ones' tech. They live in First Ones' ruins. They write like First Ones. They smell like them, and that's according to *you.* It's kind of obvious."

"Yeah, but you don't *know."*

He clicks his tongue. "One way to find out."

"But that's how I become She-Ra," Adora says. "'For the Honor of you-know-who!' Mara's rebels had a Squad Grayskull. Why would things so important be named after some guy?"

"He's not just *some guy,"* Adam scoffs. "He's one of the greatest kings Eternia has ever had!"

Adora mumbles, "Yeah, well, I've never heard of him, so…"

"Hey, Adam!" Bow interrupts.

"What is it?"

"Are you guys First Ones?"

"I don't know what that means."

"Huh, never mind," he says to Catra.

“What are you guys talking about?” Adora asks.

“Nothing important. But I’m right and Bow isn’t,” Catra says.

Adam says, "Well, I’m right and Adora isn’t.”

“Well, maybe I should kick you off the mission,” Adora says.

He rolls his eyes. “If you knew how powerful the secret power in the castle was you’d agree with me.”

“Yeah? How powerful is it?”

“Well." He folds his arms. "I don’t actually know.”

“Then I guess there’s only one way to find out.”

“Then you’re agreeing to go to the castle?”

“I’m not *not* agreeing.”

“Is that a yes?”

“It isn’t a no.”

“It’s been a very long day,” Man-At-Arms says. “Perhaps we’d all benefit from a good night’s sleep?”

“That sounds fantastic.” Catra stretches her arms above her head and uses it as an excuse to hook one around Adora’s shoulders. “Wanna share a tent?” she asks in a low voice.

“Really?” Adora asks. “In front of the royalty?”

Adam grimaces. “Ooh, tents.” He looks at Teela. “Did we bring those?” Before she can answer, he turns back. “Were we supposed to bring those?”

“Did you bring anything?” Bow asks.

“My map. And Cringer. Oh, Cringer! You can come out now.” The tiger slinks out of the same bush Adam hid in and sits behind his legs, then looks at Melog, who hides behind Catra.

“You baby,” she whispers at them.

“I guess he kind of followed me, actually. Like Teela.”

“I brought my staff,” she says, holding it up.

Man-At-Arms shakes his head. “Use mine. I’ll take first watch and sleep in the Wind Raider.”

“I hope that techno-armor has good back support,” Catra says.

The Wind Raiders race over the dense canopy of trees. They’re going faster than before, Man-At-Arms hoping to finish the trip before the morning is out despite Adam’s promise it would already be done before noon.

Adora fumbles with the headband communicator Man-At-Arms gave her. The small microphone sits too close to her mouth and the speaker is uncomfortable against her ear. He had described them as antiquated technology. She considers them junk. Speaking through static, she asks, “So, is there a password or something? Or do I just have to walk up to the door?”

Adam flies a Wind Raider of his own a few dozen feet away. His flying is shakier than Man-At-Arms’ and Teela sits rigid in the seat next to him while Cringer hides on the floor behind. A harsh gale hits them; Man-At-Arms navigates it with ease, while Adam almost

loses control. He jerks the Raider back onto a steady path, then says, “I’m not sure.” His voice is garbled and thick with interference. “Maybe try She-Ra’s catchphrase?”

“What’s stopping us from just breaking into the castle?” she asks.

“It would be rude, for one. Magic being the second, unless that voice you said you heard is just because you’re crazy. Though, the castle is royal property. Would it be a break-in if I gave you permission?”

“Something would definitely get broken.”

“We’ll have to try and avoid that.”

Far ahead, something glints against the sky.

“There’s something up there,” Teela says. “Multiple. They’re traveling together.”

The closer they get, the more Adora can see. The objects are moving perpendicular to the Raiders, are about the size of a person, and have glowing green—

“Horde drones!” she shouts. “Dive!”

Man-At-Arms slams the steering wheel forward. It throws the Raider down and almost sends everyone flying out. Adora holds Catra against her seat. Melog yowls, their claws latched firmly to the floor. Bow screams. They crash through the canopy, a blur of green striking them. Leaves, branches, and even a bird fly past, with many whipping against their skin. Adora tries to cover her face, but already, a myriad of cuts line her body. In the time it takes for her to blink, the ground is unseen, then only feet away. Man-At-Arms already has the wheel pulled against his chest and even still, the bottom of the Wind Raider slams into the earth with a terrible crunch. They skid against the ground, desperately weaving between trees and boulders until friction and the reversed engines drag them to a grinding halt.

Adam's Raider slides in front of them. A cloud of dirt trails behind it, and it skids to a stop, knocking against a tree. A large blue fruit falls from its branches and hits Teela's head. "Ow," she says, unflinching and as wide-eyed as Adam beside her. He holds the wheel with white knuckles and breathes in slow, shaking gasps. Cringer, still unseen, lets out a long, quiet, and pitiful meow.

They're not much better. Adora's entire body is rigid, her legs splayed and arm locked across Catra's torso like an iron bar. Catra is starfished and clutching the seat. Every hair on her body stands on end and her tail is puffed out to the width of a leg. Melog panic-cloaked and Bow is shaking. Man-At-Arms takes his helmet off with stiff precision and wipes a stray hair out of his face. "That could have been worse," he says.

"Is everyone alright?" Bow asks.

"I think Cringer peed."

"Shut the engines off. They're too loud," Adora says.

The rockets, miraculously still functioning, power down with a low drone.

"Did they see us?" Teela asks.

Drones fly overhead, unseen through the trees, but heard from the high-pitched whining of their flight. Everyone stops. They don't move again until the sound has faded completely.

"I don't think so," Adora says. "Or they were ordered not to engage. We can't risk drawing their attention."

"What, so we're just stuck here now?" Catra asks.

The forest stretches on in every direction. The trees are sparse but have long branches and many leaves that obscure much of the sun.

Man-At-Arms shakes his head. “The Wind Raiders use a rudimentary anti-gravity system to fly. The rockets are mostly for horizontal propulsion. We’ll be able to keep going, but it’ll be slow.” He flicks a few switches and the Raider silently rises above the earth. A panel falls loose. Something in the engine pops. Man-At-Arms flinches but inches the wheel forward. The Wind Raider moves about as fast. “Very slow.”

“I prefer walking, anyway,” Teela says. She stumbles out of her seat as Adam follows beside them. Adora and Catra walk between the two vehicles while Melog takes their former spot, watching them from the side. “Why is the Horde out here?” She sounds calm but holds her staff at chest height and Adora can see a faint twitch in her fingers.

“They’re probably looking for people like us who are trying to do exactly what we are,” Bow says.

“But we aren’t headed toward Snake Mountain,” Man-At-Arms says. “And this is not a path traveled by those who are.”

Catra’s ears still point in the direction the drones went. “Maybe they’re looking for the super-secret magic power, too. You said that clone wanted Eternia’s magic, right?”

“I did. But King Grayskull fell in battle on another world and I’ve never heard any legends about his burial place, let alone it being here. How would the Horde have learned of such a story?”

Adam stares forward, unmoving.

Adora says, “It doesn’t matter. We have to assume that they’re looking for it too. If they think it’s important enough to look for, then we have to find it first.” The conviction in her voice dies as she asks, “How far away from the castle are we, exactly?”

Adam tilts his head. “At the rate we’re going, we should get there sometime in the next week.”

“Cool,” she says. “Cool.”

Whenever the sounds of drones overhead are heard, they stop, waiting in complete stillness for them to pass. Eventually, they find a dirt road, overgrown and littered with rocks, and follow it out of the undergrowth and toward Grayskull. The sun slowly rises through the trees, its light catching on the sparkling remnants of morning dew. The forest here feels young. The trees are thin and the undergrowth forgiving, at least, compared to the ancient and twisted bulk of the Whispering Woods. It's almost serene, and anyone else would be able to lose themselves in the gentle air and forget the dangers above.

Catra's lip curls back and her nose twitches.

"Are you alright?" Adora asks her, quiet enough so that no one else hears.

"I think something died," she says. "Or the plants here just stink."

"I don't smell anything."

"Consider yourself lucky."

Cringer paces back and forth, making a low rumbling sound, though Adora would put no stock in his reaction except for the fact that Melog seems disturbed as well.

Ahead, a tree is sheared of most of its bark, with deep gauging marks running along its trunk. "I wonder what did that?" Adam asks. Sap seeps from the deepest cuts and he reaches over to tap it. His nail clicks against the already hardened liquid, but a stronger push breaks through the shell and leaves his fingertip coated with the stuff. "Oh, that's sticky. Tastes good though," he says with his finger already in his mouth.

"Adam!" Man-At-Arms and Teela say together.

A strong wind blows from ahead and Adora catches the first whiff of a truly rancid funk. "Oh, wow. You weren't kidding." She holds her arm against her nose.

Teela holds back a cough.

More trees bear the same slash marks and some of the sap still runs freely, weeping from their wounds. Plants along the side of the road are withered and leaves, still green, have fallen from the trees and litter the road. The ever-present sounds of the forest, unnoticed in their presence, have gone, the silence deafening in their absence.

The longer they walk, the stronger the smell becomes. Adora blinks away tears and only breathes through the arm of her jacket. It does little to help.

"Is this something we can go around, or—?" Bow is cut off by his own coughs.

Catra retches and holds a hand against her throat. She falls to her knees and before Adora can move to support her, the stench hits her like a cannon shot.

She doubles over, coughing before she can breathe and tears fall freely before she can blink. The very air stings her eyes. It turns hazy under the power of the unholy aroma.

Teela leans on her staff just to stay on her knees. Adam falls from the Raider. Man-At-Arms hacks into his arm. Bow holds his head in his hands. "What… is that?" he asks through choked wheezes.

"What… or who?" someone else asks. Their voice is high and grating. They speak as if telling an obscene joke. A creature steps out from behind a tree, dragging its claws along the trunk and shredding its bark. It's tall, gangly, and wretched in every regard. Dark, matted fur covers its body, and stripes of white against black make its form difficult to distinguish as it seems to shift and warp with the shimmering air. Long arms fall past its knees and flitting ears jerk to the sounds of their coughs and sputtering as wide, bulging eyes take in the sight before it. A smile plays on its thin lips showing needle teeth and a slavering tongue. "Poor, poor travelers walked right into Odiphus' trap," they say.

“How is it a trap… if you didn’t,” Catra coughs, “even do anything?”

“But all of this is Odiphus’ doing,” the creature says proudly, splaying its arms and unleashing another wave of stench. “Odiphus did not wish to be given this power, but Odiphus will use it when he must.” He strides forward with sickening confidence, smiling as they fall further from his terrible odor. “Plants wither when Odiphus is near, so he cannot eat them. Animals flee, so Odiphus cannot hunt. People hate Odiphus, so they give him no food.” He lays a hand on Adam’s Wind Raider and the prince drags himself away toward the treeline. Teela tries to get between them, but the creature pushes her to the ground with paltry effort. “Even Odiphus’ own tribe will not help him. They pushed Odiphus out because of his power.” He rummages through the bags strapped to the back. Cringer shakes silently, pushing himself against the front seats to get as far away as he can. “If people will not give, then Odiphus must take.”

Adora rises to one knee. She holds a hand up toward a ray of sunlight and summons her sword. She takes a breath to speak, but the air is acrid on her tongue and searing in her throat. The stench stains the insides of her mouth and she gags, falling onto her arms. Her sword dissipates before it hits the ground.

“Don’t fight, traveler. Odiphus only takes what he needs. But Odiphus is hungry, and he needs so, so much.” Two bags are slung over his shoulder and half a ration bar falls from his mouth as he talks. Already, he moves to the next Raider, stepping over Catra’s prone body. Melog yowls, then leaps at the creature. He catches them by the throat and throws them to the ground, then snarls when Melog tries to stand.

He has a third, then fourth bag in his arms when something strikes the back of his head. Odiphus yelps, then howls in rage, turning on his heel. A small stone lands in the dirt.

“Hey!” a nasal voice shouts. “Thad one has my sbare vests!” Adam stands on the hood of his Wind Raider, holding a collection of

rocks at his waist. His eyes are red and leak tears but a golden slime covers his nose and drips down along his face. “A blugged nose means no sdink!” He coughs. “Mosdly. Nod so dough withoud it, huh Stinkor? Stinger. Stink-Kor.” He groans and his shoulders sag. “I’m drying to say you smell bad.” With a cocksure smile, he takes another rock and tosses it in his hand, then whips his wrist and sends it soaring directly into Odiphus’ chest. It bounces off with a quiet thud and falls harmlessly to the ground.

“Odiphus doesn’t like being called names.” The creature drops the bags and advances on Adam with a dangerous glint in his eyes.

“Oh shid.”

After he decided to borrow a Wind Raider and follow She-Ra on her quest, Prince Adam of Eternos had three simple goals: save his family, prove to them and everyone else that he was a capable prince and great hero, and find ways to impress Teela along the way. Dying at the hands of a man-sized skunk monster is a goal notably absent on that list, yet he can’t help but feel it may be the only thing he accomplishes.

Rather unfortunate, that.

He throws one stone, then another, and a third, and more until he has no more; each one hits its mark but does nothing to slow the creature. The final stone strikes just above his saucer-eye, but Odiphus only blinks. He snarls and steps onto the hood of the Wind Raider, only feet away from Adam, who stands paralyzed by the overwhelming aura of the monster. The sap that clogs his

nose shields him from the worst of the stench, but the very air around Odiphus seems to bite and stings his skin and forces his eyes to narrow. Teela takes a wild swing at Odiphus' leg but her form falters and she puts little power into her strike. It hits him with all the force of a drunken fly.

No one else can stand. They writhe in the agony of the unrelenting stink. Teela crumbles to her knees. Duncan holds his throat, his face nearly blue. Bow tries to nock an arrow but his bow slips from his fingers. Catra buries her face in the dirt, a pitiful whine having replaced her previous retching. She-Ra is gone; a trail in the dirt leads to the trees and Adam realizes that she must have run. He should have run. The creature takes another step forward. Its shadow blocks the sun and it looms over him, staring down with hungering eyes. Every inch of Adam's body trembles and he knows that he is alone. The creature reaches out and locks his bony fingers around Adam's throat.

"It's been so long since Odiphus has had fresh meat."

He starts to squeeze.

"Bor the Honor of Gwaysgull!" A brilliant light bursts into existence, sounded by the ringing of steel and the force of a thunderstrike.

Odiphus shrieks. He drops Adam and stumbles back then falls from the Raider and scrambles in the dirt. Adam hits the hood with an "Oof!" as the wind is knocked from his lungs.

She-Ra wastes no time. She lunges at Odiphus and crouches at his feet. Just as he stands she throws a punch directly at his jaw that sends him flying into the air and into a bush dozens of feet away. "Bow!" she shouts. Her voice is loud, but muddled under the thick layer of sap that covers the entire lower half of her face. "Goo arrows!"

"R-right!" With some distance from Odiphus, he manages to reach into his quiver and takes three arrows, then fires them off in such

quick succession that Adam barely sees his arm move. He didn't even need to be accurate. The arrows explode on impact, flinging green goo all over the monster and the bush he groans in.

All that can be seen is Odiphus' head and the silhouette of his body as he struggles in vain against his sticky prison.

"Do you have any air freshener arrows?" Catra asks, her face still in the dirt.

"The goo should block most of the smell." Still, Bow holds back the contents of his stomach.

Adam picks the drying sap from his nose and slides onto the ground next to Teela. Her head shoots up when he lands and her hands lock onto his shoulders. She darts her eyes over his entire body and they land on his neck. He tries to speak but only coughs, more a symptom of the residual stink than what happened, but Teela's face warps into a visage of raw fury. He grabs her arm as she reaches for her staff then shakes his head.

"You guys okay?" She-Ra asks, turning back. She wipes the sap from her face and helps them up.

"Thanks," Adam says.

"Don't mention it. And good idea, with all this," she holds her hand up, showing off the amber liquid. "Gonna be smelling it for weeks, though. Probably better than that," she cocks her head toward Odiphus. He growls. She-Ra pulls Catra up from the dirt and hoists her into her arms. "Smell's gone now."

"Easy for you to say." Catra keeps her nose plugged.

She-Ra checks on the others and Adam dusts himself off. Cringer mewls behind him and Adam reaches back to scratch the tiger's jaw. "Sorry, buddy. I'm sure Grayskull will be nicer."

"Adam, are you alright?" Duncan's hand is heavy on his shoulder.

“A little sore, but yeah.”

His brows furrow. “You almost *died.* That thing was going to *eat* you.”

He holds up a finger and forces a smile. “But I didn’t, and he never got the chance. So it basically didn’t even happen.”

Duncan sighs. “Your father is going to have my head when he finds out about this.”

“Then he won’t.” Adam pats Duncan’s arm. “Besides, we don’t even do executions anymore.”

“On principle. The legal precedent remains,” Teela says.

“I don’t want to know why you know that.”

“I suggest we use that precedent on him,” she points her staff to Odiphus.

“Wait, what?” Bow asks, looking up from his arrows.

“How about we don’t?” Adam asks as he holds his hands up and walks backward toward the captured creature. “Just look at him. And you heard what he said.” She-Ra, now Adora, and her friends listen to him talk. “He’s probably starving. Besides, he didn’t even try to hurt us until I threw a rock at him. Isn’t that right, Stinky?”

“Odiphus will pick the flesh from your bones if you ever call him that again.”

“So are we going back to Stinkor? Because you’re not helping my point.”

Odiphus grumbles and looks away, sinking his head deeper into the goo.

“Bow, toss me that bag."

He throws it with practiced ease.

Adam fumbles the catch. He pulls one of the ration bars out and rips it free from the paper wrapping. “I’ll make a deal with you, Odiphus.” Adam crouches down and holds the bar out. “You stop with the highway robbery, and I give you this,” he wiggles the bar, “and these,” he says, holding up the bag. “When you get out of this goo—It dissolves, right Bow? Great—head down Eternos and tell them Prince Adam sent you. We’ve got some pretty good scientists who can get that little stink thing figured out. Deal?”

Odiphus pulls his lip back and narrows his eyes.

“The alternative is dealing with her.”

Teela strikes the ground with her staff.

“Odiphus agrees with your terms.”

“Cool. How long does this stuff take to go away?” Adam asks Bow.

“About three hours.”

“Open up, Odie.”

“Eh?”

Adam sticks the ration bar in his mouth before it can close. “Since your hands are a little… well.” Odiphus wiggles the exposed tips of his fingers in the green goop. “And it’ll help with the breath,” Adam says as he waves the air in front of his face clear.

“You sure that’s a good idea?” Adora asks when Adam returns to the group.

“It’s not like we can just let him starve to death.”

“That’s a very noble thing you’ve done, Adam,” Duncan says. Something in Adam’s chest swells at hearing those words. He raises his eyebrows and makes sure that Teela heard. She rolls her eyes. “Even if it was a rather degrading way of doing it.” The thing pops like a balloon. “But selflessness and forgiveness are

important traits to have as a ruler. Just don't forget to exercise caution when in the face of a life-ending danger."

Adam laughs. "Do you think he was going to burp me to death?"

"Based on what we saw he was capable of? It was a legitimate possibility."

"Okay, well I think I'm done talking about the skunk monster, so if everyone else is too, then…?"

He's met with a chorus of agreements and nods. "I think I'm already over today," Bow says. Adam watches that handsome bit of scruff on his chin and wonders what Bow would look like with a mustache.

"Then who wants some good news?" Catra asks. Adam realizes she's still being held in Adora's arms.

They're not a very subtle thing, he thinks to himself.

"I might have been face-first in the dirt for most of that, but you know what I noticed?"

"What?" Duncan asks.

"I guess 'didn't notice' might be more accurate."

"What?" Duncan asks, slightly slower.

"Horde drones!" Adora says, her face lighting up. Catra smirks, seemingly finding the reaction she was looking for. "Melog, can you climb the trees and tell us what you see?"

The glowing space cat chirps something and dashes into the trees. They scale one as fast as Adam's eyes can follow. Leaves rustle and twigs snap and then they're left in a sudden silence that's quickly interrupted by quiet chewing behind them. They turn to Odiphus. Half the bar is left and a mess of crumbs litter the fur on his lower face and the goo beneath his chin. His jaw

stops working the instant they look at him and his eyes get even wider than before.

“Shush!” Bow says with a finger against his lips.

The quiet lasts for almost a minute.

Melog drops down from the canopy and deftly lands between Adam and Adora in a sudden appearance that did not startle the prince in the slightest. They chirp and mewl and Catra nods her head; a genuine smile spreads across her face. “We’re clear,” she says.

They let out a collective sigh.

“Hear that, Cringer? We get to fly again.” Cringer meows, low and mournful.

The bags are quickly thrown back onto the Wind Raiders and their passengers soon follow. They rise from the ground and up to the treetops, but before they leave the forest, Adam drops the promised bag of food at Odiphus’ goo-trapped feet. “There you go, Odie. Play nice while we’re gone.”

He swallows the last of his bar. “Odiphus would rather be called Stinkor than anything like that.”

“Be careful what you wish for!” Adam shouts as they disappear behind the leaves.

Unhindered by the threat of discovery by hostile alien forces, the need to make up lost time, and the simple desire to make the cool flying machine go really fast, Adam races ahead of Duncan’s Raider and whoops as the air whips past his face and pulls at his hair.

Adora picks at a spot of crusted sap that managed to get into her ponytail. She throws the sparkling remnants into the wind with a sigh only to groan when she finds another patch.

"You could just cut the whole thing off," Catra says. "Worked for me."

Adora smiles at her joke, despite the circumstances it references. It's a subject she lets Catra bring up and one that she prods no further than Catra has already gone. "I like my ponytail," she says.

"It's the same one you've had since we were kids! I can't even get away from it with She-Ra now. What happened to the flowing locks? They were pretty."

"You must be really bored if we're already arguing about this again."

"Just trying to keep my mind off Stinkor." She snickers. "Stinkor, Adora. *Stinkor.* Did I ever tell you about Tung Lashor?"

"You did."

She shrugs and closes her eyes, flashing that smile that always seems to catch the light on her fangs and almost makes her look like the renegade she says she is. "I'm just saying, they should form a team, or something."

"Or a support group."

They both laugh, but stop when Bow says, "Woah."

The forest ends abruptly. Where once verdant green shrouded the earth, there is now only dark, jagged stone and low, cloying streams of mist that weave between boulders and shallow ravines

like the veins of a spider's web. Even the sky is darker and the clouds take on a purplish hue.

It's not exactly what she had in mind. She presses a button on her communicator. "Are we on the right track, Adam?"

"Should be there any moment," he says. Even from dozens of feet away, she can see the nervousness on his face.

"I think it's closer than that," Man-At-Arms says.

On the horizon and growing in size is a mass of green stone and looming parapets. A chasm surrounds the entire structure which sits on a pillar of rock that extends into the depths below. Had Adora not already known of the king, she'd have thought the castle was named for its face: a terrible fanged skull adorns the its front, the drawbridge built in the facsimile of a lower jaw. Its eyes are empty and black; no light pierces beyond them and the castle itself seems to follow their approach. "Okay. How did the Horde miss *this?"* Bow asks.

"Magic," Adora says. She looks to Melog, who stares at Grayskull with something that borders on reverence. "It's faint, but it's there."

"And that's why we're here," Adam says.

They bring the Wind Raiders down and shut them off. Everyone leaves the vehicles with tentative, measured movements. Adora is the first to touch the ground, and even she has to force out a breath before taking the first step. The earth there is like the dust of a barren moon and porous rocks crunch beneath her boots.

She rolls her shoulders and they walk the length of a bridge that extends over the moat. Sections of dirt fall from its side into the chasm below. She keeps herself from looking over the edge.

The castle lords over them as they near, its visage dominating their view as if they stand beneath the skull of a great titan, felled in eons past. A shrill wind howls, blasting out of the darkling void

surrounding them. On the precipice, Adora looks into the eyes of Castle Grayskull. Something inside watches her back.

“Here goes nothing.”

Chapter End Notes

Admittedly, this chapter is a little self-indulgent, and yes, Stinkor is a real character from MotU. His entire gimmick is that he smells bad. That's all he does. Even the plastic in the toy was infused with scented oil to make it stink.
The people who designed him got laughed out of the studio when they tried to pitch his character to the team responsible for the original show. They made a pact swearing that they'd never include Stinkor in the cartoon.
How could I not include him here?

Also, in case I didn't mention it before, I'm imagining the Best Friends Squad has their flash-forward designs from the finale, except Adora still has the same hairstyle.

The Secrets of Grayskull

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora widens her stance and holds her sword aloft. “For the Honor of Grayskull!” Power surges from within and She-Ra bursts forth, triumphant in the face of the fortress. Grayskull looms and Adora wills it open. Her command is silent. She points her sword at the castle gate. Beside it, a sparking flash etches a slot in the stone. Adora feels the pull again, and in a moment of blind faith, she lets go. Her sword flies forward with striking speed, embedding itself in the stone, scraping against ancient brick until it’s sheathed to the hilt.

A deep rumbling sounds from the castle. The ground shakes and clumps of dirt fall from the earthen bridge. They hold one another as all but Adora struggles to stand. She leans forward and squints her eyes, holding an arm in front of the group, ready for the slightest hint of further danger.

Tiny bursts of dust explode around the rim of the drawbridge. Heavy chains rattle and crash against one another as it begins to lower; slow, at first, until it crosses the halfway mark and gravity pulls it down. It slams against the all-too-fragile bridge and kicks up a cloud of purplish dirt.

A quiet gust of wind clears the air and Grayskull, its maw wide and fangs sharp, waits for them to enter.

Adora flicks her wrist and resummons her sword. With a thought, the blade begins to glow, though it barely pierces the blackness of the castle’s entrance. “Stay behind me,” she says, her voice firm.

They step onto the drawbridge, past a row of stone teeth, with measured movements and bated breath. As they pass the threshold of the castle gate, all sound from outside seems dulled to the point of silence. It’s dark inside. Darker than it should be.

Faint rays of light fall from thin windows, but they illuminate no more than what they touch.

The inside of Castle Grayskull is much like that of Eternos' palace: heavy tapestries line the walls and thick rugs blanket its floors, yet its torches are unlit and what crystals cover the ceiling do not shine.

"Look at that!" Adam says. He dashes forward, beneath Adora's arm, faster than she can stop him.

"Adam!" Teela whisper-shouts, following him, just as evasive.

He stops by one of the tapestries and reaches out as if to touch it, but stops himself short. Teela tries to pull him back, and when he does not budge, she instead takes a guarding stance beside him; but the castle seems empty, without even a spider's web to call it home.

Bow asks Adam, "What is it?"

"King Grayskull." His voice is hushed—reverent with awe. The tapestry shows a man—and hardly that—standing above a crowd. They're dressed in nothing but rags and he holds a closed fist above his head. "His name was D'Vann. He was so charming and handsome that the entire planet agreed to follow him." Adam snaps his fingers. "Just like that. And look!" He runs to another and holds his arms out. "This is when he fought Granamyr! He beat a *dragon* by wrestling it. With his bare hands!" To Adora, it looks more like they're talking. "And here! This is when he fought the Horde. Alone! Well, She-Ra was there, but I'm sure he did most of the heavy lifting. They called him the most powerful man in the universe for a reason." Adam flexes his arm. Teela pushes it down. "Do you remember it?" he asks Adora.

"How could I?"

His smile is awfully condescending for someone who's said something so strange. "Because you're She-Ra?"

"Yeah, but I'm *Adora* She-Ra. Not… whoever that was." She looks at the tapestry closer. Indeed, an ancient She-Ra and Grayskull fight side-by-side against a flood of terrible machines and the towering figure of Horde Prime. She-Ra has shining blonde hair and a suit of white and gold. Her eyes are green—her skin is freckled. And her sword… It's not the one Adora found—the one left by Mara. It's of a different design from the sword Adora uses now, but it burns with the same magic—raw and unchained. What was her name? Did she have a family? How much did she have to lose?

"He's got a fancy sword, too," Catra says.

"Magic sword." Adam nods. "Everybody loves them."

Indeed, it shines with the same radiance as She-Ra's and he holds it above his head, just as she. There's writing beneath the picture.

"This is how he died," Adora says.

"Oh. Yeah. Well… They built the castle for a reason." He tries to chuckle.

Man-At-Arms puts a hand on his shoulder. "I suggest we move on."

Further in the castle, more tapestries line the walls, also adorned with weapons, armor, and trophies of what must have been a life worthy of legend. Adam tries to stop at almost everything they pass, but he himself—and sometimes Teela—pulls him forward.

One tapestry shows Grayskull shaking hands with a bee-man, standing over the corpse of a gargantuan, multi-headed snake. Another shows him with a strange staff, battling a skeleton wreathed in shadow with a halberd of dark iron. Most curiously, Adora thinks, is one with Grayskull in rags, fighting against what must be Eternian soldiers.

Through open doors and winding halls, past empty rooms and ones filled with forgotten stories, they wander the halls of Castle

Grayskull, guided only by instinct and the quiet voice that pulls at the back of Adora's mind.

They come across a door, larger than the rest, made from heavy, dark wood.

"Think we finally found it?" Bow asks.

With a raised hand, Adora motions the others to stay back. Then, she holds it against the wood.

"Adora," the voice whispers.

She steps back. "Be ready for anything."

Catra readies her claws. Bow nocks an arrow. Melog bares their teeth. Teela raises her staff and Man-At-Arms shoulders a large rectangular rifle. Adam stands behind them. Cringer stands behind him.

Adora holds her sword close and lunges forward. She slams into the door and rips it from the frame. The wood splinters and it flies forward, thudding against the floor.

They each take point in a semi-circle around the door frame. Nervous eyes flit across an empty room.

"Is that it?" Catra asks.

Tentatively, Bow says, "Maybe the power is a metaphor."

"I assure you, Bow of Etheria, the power within Grayskull is quite real." The voice comes from everywhere and speaks in a soft tone that still sends them jumping. The torches that line the walls burst to flaming life. Above the ruined door, the air shines. A cascade of sparkling light falls and the glowing outline of a woman shifts into being. A cape shaped as the wings of a bird flows behind her and a crown emblazoned with a hawk's head adorns her own. She hovers, unmoving, looking down at them. "And I have waited a very long time to share it with another."

The first thought that crosses Adora's mind is that the woman is very pretty. The second is that Light Hope—in her creepy, hologram way—was too. She would prefer to avoid another Light Hope. "Well that's great, but I do have a couple questions."

The woman bows her head.

"Who are you?"

"In my time I was known as Eldress, and that is what you may call me now."

"Is the magic power here used to unlock a universe-destroying super-weapon?"

"No."

"Are you lying?"

"You speak of the Heart of Etheria."

"You know about that?"

Eldress waves her hand and the broken door rises into the air, fixing itself in a glowing fog. She flexes her fingers and sends it back into the frame. "Perhaps it would be best if I explained more." She lowers herself until she floats mere inches off the ground. "I died more than a thousand years ago. What you see now is an illusion: a construct cast in my image and given my memories to serve as a guardian of this castle."

"Like an AI?" Bow asks.

"Of sorts," she says. "Born from magic rather than technology. For all intents and purposes, a ghost."

"Why does the castle need a guardian?" Catra asks. "There's nothing here."

“Nothing that you can see,” Eldress says. “But your companions recognize it already.”

“Magic,” Adora says.

“Yes. The last on Eternia. The ancient Eternians had an empire that spanned the stars, but to fuel it we consumed magic in unsustainable quantities. Our machines stripped Eternia of its native power and almost all life with it. I was blind to the damage we caused, but in the last days of my life I led a resistance that saved what magic we could and hid it here.”

She holds out her arms and the center of the floor begins to glow. The bricks shift and fold impossibly on themselves and pull back until only a hole is left. From it rises a pyramid of stone. Angled designs and the sharp inscriptions of the First Ones line its surface. The top splits and opens, revealing a shimmering blue orb that seems to hold an entire universe within.

They all stand transfixed, caught in the majesty of what lies before them. Adora tries to focus on the orb, yet the longer she looks the more it seems to change—its surface as still as a boiling sea, the depths of space and a million, million stars shimmering beneath.

Caught in its spell, only two step forward: Melog, licking their lips and stopped by Catra's foot, and Adam, Teela's hand already locked on his collar. "What is that?" he asks, whispering.

“This is the core that contains the surviving magic of Eternia. She-Ra… Adora. This is why I have called you here. The power within is fading, and I have long been dormant to preserve it. Your coming here awakened me and it is why I must ask a great task of you.”

“What?” she asks. Already, she prepares herself for the worst.

“Etheria and Eternia are inextricably linked. Together, they act as conduits for magic to exist in the wider universe. Etheria has been returned to this universe, and its magic with it, but without

Eternia's restoration, magic cannot survive and Etheria's return will mean nothing."

"So you want me to take the orb and bring back magic?"

"No. She-Ra is born from Etheria and channels its magic alone. You cannot save Eternia. I need you to find someone who can."

"Okay. How do I… do that?"

Eldress turns her hand. A split appears on the top of the orb and a bright light spills forth. From that light comes a pommeled handle wrapped in dark leather, then a curved cross-guard, and half of a sharp, shining blade that reflects the room around it with perfect clarity. Powerful magic radiates from the sword and Melog mews.

It's the same one Grayskull held.

"The Sword of Power. Eternia never had a protector like She-Ra. My apprentice fashioned this sword so that whoever wields it might channel Eternia's magic as you channel Etheria's. Adora, I trust it with you and the task of finding one worthy of its power. Grant it to them so that they might save Eternia and all the universe."

The orb rotates until the handle points toward her. She reaches out but stops short of grabbing it. Eldress tilts her head. "Why me?" Adora asks.

"I have looked into your heart and know it to be good. You are cunning, wise, and above all else, kind. I know what you have done for others and I know that I can trust you with this task."

"If you can do that then why don't you pick someone yourself? Adora's done enough to fix the First Ones' messes," Catra says too bluntly, though Adora harbors similar sentiments.

If Eldress' face was not glowing, a shadow would be cast over it. "Do you know why this castle is called Grayskull?" she asks.

“It’s his castle,” Adam says. “He’s buried here.”

She shakes her head. “It was named in his honor. But after he died, there was nothing left to bury. Grayskull was born into a dying civilization, long-suffering the consequences of its hubris. I watched him rise from a simple commoner to a mighty champion: one who fought for those who could not fight for themselves. I saw in him the potential to restore what we had ruined. Not to return to what we were, but to become what we always should have been.

“I called him here and gave him the sword, charging him with the task. But it was not meant to be. The Horde, long battling the outskirts of Eternia’s empire, sensed our weakness and began an invasion. Grayskull would not stand by as his people were killed and went to face them. He stood with the She-Ra of his time and believed the power of the sword would turn the tide, but the Horde was mighty, and Grayskull fell. In secret, She-Ra returned the sword to me, but the Eternian’s saw its power and sought it for themselves. They created a sword of their own—one that would shackle She-Ra to their will and began work on a weapon that could defeat the Horde.”

Adora sees her reflection in the sword. “The Heart of Etheria.”

Eldress nods. “My past is not without misdeeds. I am not innocent. I tried to make Grayskull a hero; instead, I killed him. This universe is no longer my own, and I would leave its fate in the hands of those who live in it.”

Her hands, Adora thinks. The fate of the universe within them once more.

Eldress smiles, but there is only sadness in her eyes. “You have proven yourself time and again. There is no other I would trust more. But I would not ask this of you without giving something in return.” Her image flickers and reappears in front of Adora. She flinches but quickly composes herself. “I have looked into your mind and found much. I must ask that you forgive my intrusion,

but it was not without merit. I know of the question that haunts you and may be able to provide answers. Twenty years ago a great burst of magical energy appeared on Eternia. I cannot tell you where, as I was not awakened fully to know, but its power was great, and I know of only one thing that could have caused it."

"A portal," Adora says, breathless. "*My* portal? Here?" She smiles, but it wavers under her own disbelief. "I came from Eternia?"

"I cannot say with certainty, but I know you are of our blood."

"What's this about portals, now?" Man-At-Arms whispers to Bow.

"She got stolen through one as a baby. We've never known where she really came from."

"Oh," he says, sympathetically.

"I understand that you have little time," Eldress says, "But before you go, I have one last thing to show you. I cannot return memories lost, but I can find ones long hidden away. Consider this a parting gift." She touches a finger to Adora's forehead.

Her vision flashes white and a dull sound roars in her ears.

She was on her back. A blanket was wrapped tight around her and the room was too bright. Distantly, someone sang. Hands, large and strong, took her in the air and held her out. Her vision was blurred behind lidded eyes, but set against a stubbled jaw she saw a smile she'd known all her life but never remembered until now. "Adora. My sweet Adora."

She returns with a gasp.

"Adora!" Catra says. "Hey, Adora! Are you alright?" She shakes her shoulders. "What did you do to her?" Catra snaps.

"I'm alright," Adora says. "It's fine. I'm alright."

“But you’re crying,” Bow says.

She touches her cheek and her fingers come back wet. “They’re good tears. I think I saw my dad.”

“Oh, that’s great!” Bow says. “What did he look like?”

“I don’t know.”

“You just said you saw him,” Catra says.

“Yeah, but I was a baby! It wasn’t exactly a holo-projection.”

“It’ll be pretty hard to find him without anything to go on. Are you sure you can’t tell us anything else?” Bow asks Eldress.

“I’m afraid that’s the only memory of her infancy that has survived. As I said, I only know that the portal was opened on this planet.”

“That’s still more than what we had before,” Catra says.

Adora wipes her face with the back of her hand. Compared to the entirety of the universe, one planet seems like a very small place to look.

“All I can offer the rest of you is a warning,” Eldress says. “Adora’s mind is not the only one I have seen.” She turns to Man-At-Arms. “Duncan, what Keldor wields is a Havoc Staff, a terrible weapon that we created in our darkest days. She-Ra, the magic it wields is not its own: it drains it from other sources.”

“Sources like me.”

“It is highly unstable and, if overloaded, incredibly volatile. I can only caution you against direct confrontation.”

“We have other methods of dealing with Keldor,” Man-At-Arms says as he pats his rifle then points it toward Teela, Catra, and

Bow. Adam’s brow twitches and his lips purse, though he flattens his expression when he sees Adora watching him.

She looks back at the sword. Eldress nods, but it’s not until she sees the reassuring faces of Catra and Bow that she steps forward and grips the handle tight. When she draws it, Adora fights to keep the sword from releasing itself as the burning force of the orb’s energy follows the blade. The sparking slot closes itself in time with the release of the tip and Adora holds the sword with both hands. It quivers and shakes—the very air warping under its presence. It's as if she can see the power diffuse around it and soon the sword goes still.

Bow taps her shoulder and hands her a piece of tied rope as he breaks an arrow off at one end. She fastens it over her shoulder and holsters the sword on her back.

“When you have found the one worthy, give them the sword and tell them to summon its strength by the power of Grayskull. They will be transformed, and only then can they channel its magic and save this universe. Go now, champions, and know that the future of Eternia travels with you.” Eldress raises her hands, and in a flash of light, they find themselves at the base of the drawbridge staring out at the Wind Raiders and lands beyond.

“Guess she doesn’t like guests,” Catra mumbles.

The rest of the day’s journey is quiet, shadowed by the sword slung over Adora’s shoulder. It’s strange, feeling a weight there again. Ancient swords and promised destinies. Strange women in old ruins. The fate of the universe in the hands of a child, granted by the will of a planet and the magic that flows through it. Only, now the choice is hers. The responsibility of finding one worthy and the weight of burdening them with it.

She sighs.

A problem for another time. And someone else, another part of her says.

“What’s wrong?” Catra asks.

Adora watches the clouds pass. Slight gusts of wind catch her hair. “I wish we never had to leave Etheria.”

Catra pulls Adora’s head onto her shoulder and kisses the top of her head.

In the lull of the conversation, all that can be heard is the quiet crackle of the fire. Bow tinkers with one of his arrows as Man-At-Arms wipes down a greave and Catra finds a way to lean even closer into Adora’s side. The night is clear and the stars are bright. Adora looks at them, wondering if she’s ever seen this sky before.

“Where’s Adam?” Teela is standing before she finishes speaking. The campsite erupts into a flurry of motion as they leap from their seats and scan the area. Nothing can be seen in the tall grass and sparse trees. “Where is he? He was just here!” Her voice starts to waver.

“It’s alright, Teela! We’ll find him,” Man-At-Arms says. “Catra, can you track him?”

“It’s nothing but Stinkor up here,” she says as she pokes her nose. “But Cringer’s gone, too.” Melog chirps at her and throws their head about.

“Spread out and search,” Adora says. “Everyone on your own—we’ll cover more ground. Stay within sight of the fire and call if you see anything. We handle it as a group.”

They nod and fan out, everyone except Adora calling Adam's name. Already, a suspicion forms in her mind, and rather than search among the trees, she looks to their tops.

There. In the tallest among them, not even a dozen yards from the camp. She stalks forward, as quiet as she can be. The bark is rough against her hands but sturdy beneath her boots and she climbs the tree with practiced precision. She stops only a few branches away. "Y'know, Catra used to do something like this when we were kids. It was never in a tree, though."

Adam sits cross-legged and looks at the sky. Tears line the edges of his eyes. Cringer watches her, beside him.

She pulls herself up to the branch next to him and lets one leg hang down. "Teela's pretty worried. You don't seem like the kind of guy who'd want to make her feel like that."

"You can't kill him," he mumbles.

Her voice catches in her throat, caught off guard by his response.

"That's what I've been trying to say. That's all I've been trying to say. You can't kill him."

At first, she thinks he's saying they're not strong enough to defeat Keldor. It doesn't take long for her to realize what he really means. "What makes you think we were going to do that?"

His laugh is short but biting. "'Take care of?' 'Deal with?' 'Eliminate?' I know Duncan never got along with Uncle, but it's like everyone just wanted an excuse to get rid of him!"

"I don't know everything that happened, but Man-At-Arms said people died in—"

"I know! But he's my uncle, Adora. I can't just—I don't—" He buries his face in his hands and pulls at his hair. "It's my fault all this happened."

"That can't be true," she says. She knows it's pointless to try and reason with someone in such a state of mind—one she's all too familiar with—but she can't let him spiral further.

He shakes his head. "I was almost killed as a baby. My parents were always so protective after that. They thought if I learned about heroes I'd try to be one and get myself hurt. But Uncle showed me things they wouldn't let me see. He told me stories I wasn't allowed to hear. He always believed in me. When I got older we studied old legends and stories about magic together. Finding Castle Grayskull was one of his life's dreams. But I found the map, hidden in the castle's archives. I was going to show him when the Horde appeared."

"That doesn't mean you're responsible for what he did."

"I'm the one who told him to go."

She waits for him to continue.

"Mother and Father didn't want to risk a war, but I'd heard so much about what the Horde could do… I told Uncle that he was the only one on Eternia who knew enough to beat them. Then he came back, and—" His voice cuts off and he screws his eyes shut. "I know they didn't get along, but Uncle would never do that! He wouldn't hurt people, Adora!"

"Adam, it's alright—"

"The Horde can control people. I know about the chips. Duncan said he didn't have one, but— But— What if it's something different? What if the staff is controlling him, too?"

She grabs his shoulder with a firm hand, to steady both his body and mind. "Hey, look at me. I promise you that I was never, *never* planning to kill him. Even if it is all him, that's not how we do things." She sighs through her nose. "I can't promise that everything is going to work out or that we'll all make it back safe, but you have my word that I'll do everything I can to make sure that no one else gets hurt. That includes Keldor. And I'm swearing

that as She-Ra, too. On the honor of Grayskull." She smiles, and Adam does too, despite his watery eyes. His mouth flattens, then he looks back at the sky.

"Let me talk to him. When we get to Keldor, let me talk to him first. I need to know if he's being controlled or if he really—I have to try and save him. I have to save them both."

"Alright. We can do that."

Adam tries to look at her. His lips move like he wants to speak, but nothing comes out. He forces a breath, then looks her in the eyes. "I'll help you find them."

"You don't have to do that."

He shakes his head. "Even if all you did was beat Horde Prime, it's the least Eternia could do to repay you. But for that?" He points to the sword. "And what you're doing now? When this is done, you'll have the backing of all Eternos to find your family, wherever they are. I swear it on my honor *as* a Grayskull."

Adora pats him on the back. "Come on. Bow's probably terrified he won't be able to show you any of his arrows and I don't think Man-At-Arms will be happy if you're gone any longer."

"I'm more scared of Teela right now," he says under his breath.

They return to the camp in time with the others and Adam's fears are not entirely unfounded: after a brief bout of scolding, Teela exudes a quiet anger that Adora can feel even as they retire to their tents and ready themselves for the night.

Catra shirks her clothes and slips into a loose-fitting shirt that Adora dimly remembers once being hers. "So do you think they're, like, a thing?" Catra asks.

"I try not to assume."

"C'mon. You have to see *something* there."

“Have you seen the way he looks at Bow?”

“Oof. Are you gonna tell him he’s taken? Might break his heart.”

“We can save that for after.”

“Actually, I bet Glimmer wouldn’t mind. I think she’d like it.”

“I don’t want to think about that, shut up!” Adora laughs and throws a pillow.

“Make me,” Catra says before lunging at her.

They devolve into a fit of giggling and hold one another all throughout the night.

Chapter End Notes

To clear up some potentially confusing things: Eldress is this universe's version of the Sorceress, if you're familiar with the Filmation continuity. I was just going to call her the Sorceress, but then I watched the new CGI show and found out they had the same idea as me for making her a hologram ghost, so I decided to throw that new name in for fun.

And here's a condensed timeline for the backstory I have for this fic
-First Ones conquer a lot of the universe and take too much magic
-Eldress realized that colonialism and environmental destruction are Bad, Actually and hid the last of Eternia’s magic
-her apprentice (this universe's version of He-Ro: the guy who makes the Sword of Power in most continuities) created a sword to wield it based on the legends of She-Ra
-The Horde grew in power and came into conflict with the First Ones
-D'Vann Grayskull sees the state of the Eternian civilization and leads a movement to fix Society™ but is heavily resisted by the standing government

-He led the fight against the Horde, but couldn’t win; he was called by Eldress’ spirit and given the Sword of Power but died fighting Horde Prime
-The sword was returned and the castle got its name
-Grayskull was pretty popular by that point so the Eternian leadership co-opted and whitewashed his movement but couldn't find his sword, so they created the Sword of Protection to steal the power of She-Ra and started the HoE project
-Mara’s rebellion eventually happened and the First Ones fell
-Eldress goes into her slumber as the ambient magic of the universe wasn’t enough to sustain her anymore
By Mara's time, Grayskull is considered an Eternian hero in a similar way to how Americans view the Founding Fathers: respected by most, but also used as empty mouthpieces for whatever beliefs people are trying to support (this is essentially my mental justification for how his name can be used by the Eternian government as She-Ra's catchphrase, but still be respected enough by Mara to also have as a name for one of her rebel squads)

Also, I'm imagining Grayskull in his Revelation design because WOOF

Lord Keldor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

White and green. Sterile white and sickly, glowing green. A dull, droning buzz sounds, unending, broken only by the footfalls of the ship's occupants—either the metallic *clang* of robotic warriors or the soft and steady step of their organic masters. The walls are angled and everything is built to a mathematical perfection that can be enjoyed only by a machine, and would be—*must* be repulsive to any creature with a soul.

He sits in the central-most chair in its control deck, though the seat is one of many and indistinguishable from any other, for here, no occupant may mark themself above the rest, for among them there was only one being who could claim the title of commander, and his throne was greater, and his ship was mightier, and he saw fit to claim instead the title of God.

And now, he is dead.

News travels fast among the stars and even a planet that has fallen so far as Eternia had quickly heard of the Old Enemy's destruction. Rebellions rage like wildfires across the universe and the crippled Horde falls further each day. The universe is in a state of havoc where chaos lords as the new order. A firm hand is needed—one that can set things to rights. Old Eternia had been that hand, once. It could be again. If only its king had the will to see it through.

"Forty-five years, Randor. Forty-five years where all you had to do was die." So says Lord Keldor of the House Grayskull, eldest son of King Miro of Eternos: a half-breed and bastard-born, third in line to the throne behind the princeling Adam and his own brother —*younger* brother—Randor. King Randor. The very same who granted him the only recognized title to his name. His grip

tightens on the staff that sits across his lap. “Eternia languished in the dregs of this universe, and you saw fit to let her rot. Our mythic foe descended from the stars and you let them defile her. At last, we had the chance to rise again and what do you do?”

Randor stands motionless before him. His bearded face is locked in a quiet grimace and his eyes spark and crackle with the purple energy of the Havoc Staff. Keldor stands and levels the ram-headed weapon at him. Its jaw hinges down and a festering glow appears in its eyes.

He could kill him.

Eternos would never accept him as king, but with the staff in hand and this ship under his command, they would have no choice.

It would be so *easy.*

A black smog pours from the staff’s gaping mouth. It pools on the ground then pulls behind him out of sight. Keldor holds his breath. A phantom touch, searing cold on his shoulder, forces a gasp from his lips.

“Is it compassion that stays your hand?” Its voice is rasping and quiet but thrums with low power that echoes in his mind. The air in front of Keldor flickers and a shadow appears. Yet he knows it is not a shadow, for a shadow can be *seen*. What stands before him is not just an absence of light, but an absence of sight. There is no shadow, for there is nothing there. There is nothing there, yet he cannot see what should be behind it. There is nothing there, yet he cannot bear to look upon it and when he wrenches his eyes shut and pulls his gaze away, all that remains is the flickering half-image of a ghastly skull leering at him with a terrible, rictus grin. “Or fear?”

Karak Nul. The Scareglow. A boogeyman of Eternian myth and, to Keldor’s surprise, an unwitting inhabitant of the staff he now holds.

Light seems dimmer, even where Scareglow is not. Even the colorless walls of this dread ship seem to lose their luster. “Why do you trouble me?”

“I see your mind, Keldor. I see all that you fear.”

“So you’ve told me before.”

“Your brother’s body may be here, but his mind is not. Your plan has not yet borne fruit, yet you have all of Eternos turned against you. Not even the prince is beside you now. You are utterly al—”

“Silence, you sorry excuse for a spectre!” He slams the foot of the staff against the floor. Scareglow says nothing. Keldor snarls as he feels the waves of satisfaction roll off him. “What do you want?”

His formless mass gravitates to Randor. A patch of hoarfrost spreads across his shoulder. “Need I remind you of our bargain?”

“Not him,” Keldor snaps. “I have delivered you your prey already.”

“Yet within the staff I remain.”

“We will have power enough, soon.”

“Grayskull still eludes you.”

“And a new opportunity presents itself. You may see into my mind, but you understand so little of what I perceive.”

“Remember who controls the power of that staff, Keldor.”

He relishes in the quiet seething that radiates from Scareglow. “I have not forgotten, my friend. But there are more pieces at play than anyone but I can see. Soon, we will—”

His monologue is cut short by a sharp pounding against the chamber door. “If I get called ‘beloved’ by one of those freaks one more time I’m taking this entire ship down, and you’re coming with me!” Keldor sighs through his nose. “And that was a warning

knock, I'm letting myself in." True to his word, the door slides open and into the room sulks Kronis. Bald and riddled with scars, he wears nothing but armored leather pants and a harness across his chest strapped with an excessive amount of guns. He slumps into a chair a dozen feet too close and says, "Don't act surprised, I guessed your password." He holds up a white, clawed hand that still drips blood from the stump that was once its wrist. "Not very secure."

"Your presence is not invited, Kronis." Keldor's eyes dart to the void where Scareglow was, but the room is brighter, and the being's presence is not felt. For how extravagant his entrances can be, Keldor hates even more how quietly he can disappear.

"Yeah, well, I got bored and you're the only halfway normal bloke in this freak show. Figured you could use some company." Beneath the veneer of sarcasm, Keldor hears in his voice far too much familiarity. Even worse, he finds in Kronis' face that which he had only seen in mirrors: elfin ears and blue skin; angled features and golden eyes. Kronis is of the Gar—a people reviled by all Eternos and exiled to a prison of an island that Keldor swore he would never again set foot upon. Kronis is Gar, and so too was Keldor's mother.

"I did not free you for your wit, you bullet-brained buffoon. What do you *want?"*

"To know what I'm working for."

"I made myself quite clear when we first spoke."

"Ancient empires, new kings, yeah, yeah. I get it. I'm talking more… immediate plans. Like, 'Who do I have to kill?' 'Where do I find them?' 'How dead do you want them to be?' You said you needed muscle, but all I've done since I got here is beat the snot out of those alien nerds and their stupid little robots."

Keldor fights the urge to incinerate him. There is a purpose for Kronis beyond annoying him. Scareglow made that abundantly

clear. Keldor will try to keep things simple. “The Horde came here searching for an ancient power that stood against it in times past. I seek that same power to secure my place as Eternia’s new king. *You* are here to make sure that anyone who tries to get in my way does not exist as a recognizable life-form once you’re done with them. When I have need of your services, I will call on you. For now…” He waves his hand toward the door. “See to it that I am not disturbed by anyone. Including you.”

The bite Keldor puts in his words seems to roll off Kronis’ skin like a gentle breeze. He rolls his eyes and himself off the chair, then swaggers back out the door. Before it shuts behind him he waves to Keldor with the dismembered hand.

It won’t be long before that half-wit is nothing but a flesh host for Scareglow to inhabit, and then Keldor will never half to deal with Kronis again. He would dread the thought of Scareglow being a permanent resident of the physical world, but Keldor reasons that once he’s in a body, he can die. Two birds. One stone conjured from the black magic of an ancient staff that will finally be *his* to fully command.

He revels in the thought and chuckles. There have been setbacks. Some that lasted for decades. One, most of his life. But now everything seems as if it’s finally falling into place. Soon, Eternos, and all of Eternia with it, will be his, and then—only then—will they finally be safe.

He waves his hand and a holographic feed materializes before him. Recorded drone footage plays in a flickering loop, zoomed onto the horizon. Two Wind Raiders fly westward toward the sea. Of note is the one furthest from the drone—in it sits a girl, blonde-haired with a shining silver sword strapped on her back. Across from her…

“Oh, Adam. You’ve always been so predictable.”

Chapter End Notes

It's very important that you read Kronis as heaving a very heavy Australian accent. It is vital to the plot of this fic. It is essential to the story. It is the key to everything. He went to the University of Space Melbourne on Space Australia with Jeice before he joined the Ginyu Force.

Also, imagine Keldor as his CGI show version, except without the skeleton hand and translated to the SPoP artsyle. For those familiar with his general backstory, I'm not doing the half-Gar thing. He's completely human, just a bastard (by both definitions of the word).*

And I'm kinda surprised by how short this ended up being, but I didn't want to bloat it out just to reach an arbitrary word count. It'll probably work better as a quick aside once more is out.

*EDIT 18/02/24: Obviously, this has changed. Imagine Keldor in his MotU Revolution design (but his clothes are purple) because, I forget which chapter I mentioned D'Vann's design, WOOF. Also, if you're re-reading this and noticing some stuff is different, it's because I'm doing a minor editing pass to remove redundancies in the prose (stuff like, "She turned," "They looked," etc.) and fix minor plot stuff I ultimately didn't like, such as Keldor not being half-gar. Nothing drastic enough to warrant changing the last time the fic was updated (I don't want it to seem like I'm fishing for more hits or disappoint people by making them think there's more actual content) but enough to warrant some kind of explanation.

The Ocean of Gnarl

Chapter Notes

HEY!

Just needed to get your attention for a quick content warning! It's nothing too graphic, but I'd like to remind everyone that the Major Character Injury tag is there for a reason. This is only the second fic I've ever published and the first to include this kind of content so I'm not actually sure how to effectively warn people about it, but it is here and will be a bit more frequent as the story progresses. Darker second acts, and all that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were fighting again. Adam listened through the closed door, his ear pressed against the wood as muffled words seeped through.

"This isn't the first time it's happened, Randor," his uncle said. "These are not isolated incidents. How many more of our people have to die to satiate your relentless lust for pacifism?"

"We have no proof. Already, the Mer-King tells us they are accidents. Vessels lost to storms. We cannot act so rashly before —"

"They're using it as cover, oaf! Every single attack has been within aquatican hunting grounds. How can you not see what's happening here?"

"I will not risk open war! Keldor, can you not hear yourself? What you propose is a violation of the treaty our own father signed. You know what the court will say if they hear such a proposition from you."

A pause. Dreadfully long. "What will they say, Randor?"

"Brother, I—"

He kept talking, but Adam could not hear him—a hand touched his shoulder and another voice whispered, "You're not supposed to be here!"

Teela pulled at his arm and tried to drag him away, but he slipped through her grip and said, "I want to listen. It's important."

"You'll get us both in trouble." Despite her hushed words, Teela's voice still echoed through the dark halls, where not even the royal guards were permitted to walk. They were stationed only at the entrances to this quarter of the palace, but Adam had learned ways of sneaking past. Teela, begrudgingly, had let him teach her how.

"You don't have to be here," Adam said.

"*Yes, I* do." *Her voice raised only a fraction, yet it was enough. Behind the door, there was silence. Teela was the first to recognize what it meant. She held back a whine and tried to pull Adam away, but he stood his ground. Not by will, but an icy cold that crept into his limbs and locked them in place. The door handle turned.*

"Uh oh."

Uncle Keldor stepped out. He scanned the halls and held a dagger sheathed on his hip. He looked down a smirk played at his lips. "Ah, Adam. Ever the eavesdropper. I hope you were paying attention. Your father and I were just about to agree on the next course of action."

His father pushed past and massaged his temple. He had tired eyes and his lips pursed so tightly that his beard creased with them. "Adam. You're up very late." He raised his eyebrow at Teela. Somehow, she stood even straighter. Adam held back a pout when he realized she was as tall as him, now. "At least one of you knows what they should be doing. Adam, go to bed."

“I want to help you.”

“And I want a son who won’t fall asleep during our next presentation. Bed, now.”

“I can help!”

Randor shook his head. “You’re too young to be worrying about such things. Don’t let our disagreements trouble you. Your uncle and I both want what’s best for Eternos, even if we don’t always agree on what that is. Isn’t that right?” He turned an accusing eye to his brother.

“Oh, yes, of course. Like right now. I believe that Eternos would be better suited with a prince allowed to perform his duties. Have some faith in the boy, Randor. He won’t be a child forever.” Adam nodded his head. He wondered why his father never saw in him what Uncle Keldor did.

Randor tugged at his beard. “I am well aware. Teela. Would you escort Lord Keldor back to the main halls? See him through and wait at the doors. Adam and I will be with you shortly.”

She saluted and led Keldor away in rigid lockstep.

“Does your father let you use any weapons besides that staff?” he asked her. “Knives, perhaps?”

“No,” she said, curtly.

“Would you like one?”

They passed a corner and their voices faded. Already, Adam missed the weight of Teela’s presence beside him. Randor put a hand on his shoulder. He smiled, but his eyes looked the same. “How much did you hear?”

Adam looked down. He ground his heel against the floor. “Is something bad going to happen?”

"Not if I am king."

"What about when you're not?"

Randor's eyes hardened but soon softened with concern. "Well. That's not something you'll have to worry about for a long, long time."

"Uncle says we should always be thinking about the future."

He sighed through a tight smile. "Your uncle is a very smart man who sometimes forgets how to exist outside his own paranoia. There's no point in troubling yourself over things you can't control. And what you can control, you guide with a loving hand. Just like I," he scooped Adam off the ground and held him in the crook of his arm, "am guiding you to bed." Adam laughed and tried to escape, but Randor held him tight.

He pressed himself against his father's shoulder as he carried him through quiet halls, lit by dim torches and the soft glow of distant moons. "One day you will be king," he said as he stared forward. "And I hope you will be a great one. But right now, I do not need you to be a king. I do not need you to be a hero, or even a prince. I only need you to be my son." He looked at Adam and smiled. "I only need you to be safe."

Adam runs his thumb along the arrow's shaft. In lieu of a traditional arrowhead, like many of Bow's other trick arrows it has a unique, strange-looking tip. In this case, a short tube with a conical cap. "What does this one do?" he asks.

Bow is in the Wind Raider's front seat beside Duncan, but sits on his knees and wraps his arms around the headrest, facing Adam, and Adora next to him. "That one explodes mid-flight. It shoots another, *smaller* arrow out of the tip."

"Oh, cool," Adam says, pointing it directly at his eye.

"Wait, is there something there? I wanna see," Adora says.

“Maybe that’s enough with the arrows,” Bow says with baffled concern. Slowly, he pushes it away from Adora’s face, takes it from them, and slides it back into his quiver.

“If we’re done with the arrows, then why not bust out that magic sword?” Adam asks.

“What’s there to see?” Adora asks.

“You’re carrying around a thousand-year-old magic sword that was wielded by the coolest person ever. What *isn’t* there to see?”

“The last magic sword I had was the key to blowing up a planet, and this one hasn’t done anything except chafe my shoulder. But go ahead, I guess.” She unsheathes the Power Sword and holds it out. The blade almost glows from how perfectly it reflects the blue sky above. For a moment, Adam is transfixed. He has to force his hand to move, and though it hovers around the handle, he cannot bring his fingers to close around it.

Adam stares at his reflection in the blade.

This is the sword of a great man.

The sword of a hero.

His brows crease.

Great men don’t let their families fall apart.

Heroes don’t flinch in the face of monsters.

“Adam?” Bow asks.

He leans back into his chair. “There’s writing on it,” he says dismissively. “Something on the guard.”

Adora holds the sword up and turns it about. “Huh, I didn’t notice that.” Her eyes narrow as she reads it out. “‘By the Power of Grayskull.’”

“That’s what Eldress said, right?” Bow taps a finger against his chin. “Must be the password.”

“I like mine more,” Adora says.

Adam lets his head fall to the side and watches the other Wind Raider. Melog and Cringer sit across from each other in the back seats, each staring at the other. The only parts of their bodies that move are their tails, slowly waving in the air in careful, measured movements. Teela pilots, watching the horizon while Catra lounges in the seat next to her.

He hopes they’re enjoying themselves more than he is.

Catra picks at the same spot on the Raider’s seat until the slight scratch is a hole that spills out the coarse padding within.

For the entirety of the ride, Teela has not said a word.

To be fair, neither has she.

If the others can effortlessly get along with everyone they meet, then Catra can, too. Or, she can make a fool out of herself. Kinda like someone who offers to ride along with a near stranger and then doesn’t say anything for an hour.

How do you talk to people you don’t know?

How many times has someone tried to tell her?

Glimmer and Bow's advice is useless. This doesn't come naturally to her.

Adora is as bad at putting thoughts into words as Catra herself.

Scorpia just hugs people and hopes for the best. Catra wishes it were that simple for her.

What had Perfuma said? Catra never thought she'd miss their talks, yet right now she'd give anything for the slightest nugget of advice that flower girl could offer. It was something about seeds, right? Planting relationships that blossom into flowers? Flowers that bloom into relationships? It's always about flowers with her.

You're supposed to ask about *them,* she remembers. People like excuses to talk about themselves. Give her an opening, then watch that awkward silence fall like the Horde.

"What's your deal?" she spits out.

"Eh?"

It didn't work. What do you do if it doesn't work?

Catra fights a rising wave of panic and tries to look nonchalant. "Like… Who are you?"

"We've been introduced already."

"I know your name, Teela. I mean, like…" She waves her hands around. "Everything else? Who *are* you?"

"Adam's bodyguard."

"Besides your job."

She takes a moment longer to respond. "Adam's friend."

"Even if I were into men, I still wouldn't know what you see in him."

Her face flushes a deep crimson and she barely manages to sputter out, "I don't—! That isn't what I said!"

"And what *I'm* trying to say is, who are you outside of your connection to someone else? And don't say anything about Man-At-Arms. I want to know about you, not your dad."

Teela breathes through her nose and brushes a strand of hair out of her face. "He's not… He *is* my father, but he's not the family I was born into. But me? I'm… I'm a soldier." Her voice grows more confident as she speaks. "I protect people. Not just Adam, either. One day I'm going to be the Man-At-Arms and help keep all of Eternia safe."

"Aren't you a little young to be a soldier?"

"We're the same age."

"But it must have taken a while to reach 'royal bodyguard,' right?"

"I've been doing it for almost as long as I can remember."

"That just makes it worse."

"It's what I want to do."

She's heard that before. "That doesn't matter if you never had a chance to do something different."

"But I did." Caught off guard, Catra lets her continue. "Duncan never wanted me to join the guard. He said it was too dangerous. But I petitioned the King myself. He was so impressed by my conviction that he assigned me the role of Adam's chief guard on the spot." She smiles at the memory. "I'm not stupid. I know he just wanted both of us to have a friend, but that doesn't mean I take my role any less seriously, and I've proved myself enough so that the King and Queen don't either. I've passed every test and surpassed every challenge so far. Even if I joined today, I'd still be the youngest ever to hold my title."

Catra can see in her eyes a fiery determination that makes her wonder if Teela is short-selling the king's original confidence. Still, there's something she doesn't understand. "But why? Why the guard? Why Adam, specifically? There are other ways to help people."

"It's what my parents did before they died."

Catra holds back a gasp and quietly hisses through her teeth. She screws her eyes shut and wonders how she manages to mess things up so fast. "I'm sorry, If I knew—"

"It's alright. I don't remember them. But they were royal guards, too—part of the squad assigned to Adam the night he was attacked. They died protecting him. Duncan was a part of their unit. That's why he took me in." She says it all so matter-of-factly that a stab of pain lances through Catra's chest. Whether it's from bitter self-reflection, genuine empathy, or a combination of the two, she can't tell.

"I'm sorry," she says.

"But you didn't do anything?"

"I'm sorry you have to live with that."

"Oh." Teela turns to her with a strange expression. It's not a look of annoyance, but curiosity. "Why are you asking me all this?"

Catra's hands fidget and she can't look Teela in the eyes. Her cheeks grow warm. "I don't know a lot of people. I have even less friends. All of them are only because Adora knew them first. I guess I was just trying to prove to myself that I could make one on my own." Catra keeps to herself the familiarity she feels when she looks at the other woman.

"Adam is the only friend I've ever had."

"Do you… wanna change that?" she asks.

Teela's lips quirk up and a smile slowly spreads. "That sounds nice."

The Wind Raiders land with a keening whine as their engines wind down. Bow makes a note on his tracker-pad to ask for schematics when they're back at Eternos. The muffled roar of the sea fills the air and the smell of salt teases at his nostrils. As each of them drops from the Raiders, they kick up small clouds of sandy dirt that blow away in the ocean wind. Bow stretches his legs as the others come up beside him.

Ahead is a moderately large settlement of buildings carved from white stone and roofed with dark shingles. "A cute little seaside city," he says. "I wonder what it's called?"

Duncan points to a stone signpost. It reads, *Welcome to Seaside.*

"That tracks."

Adam holds his hands against the back of his head. "Officially, this is the first time I've ever been outside Eternos. The city, that is."

"Officially?" Adora asks.

Adam only smiles. A bundle of cloth strikes his face and he yelps.

"*Officially* that has not changed," Duncan says. "I took the liberty of packing disguises for the four of us. For you two, consider yourselves lucky I brought extra." From one of the bags latched to the Wind Raider, he pulls several more roughly sewn robes and ponchos. They're more comfortable than they look and easily fit

over their outfits. “We can't risk the Winder Raiders overheating on the water. If something happens out there, we’ll be stranded.”

Adora hits her fist against an open palm. “We need a boat,” she says with that signature plan-making determination.

“Shame Seahawk isn’t here,” Bow says. A dozen memories of seaborne fires and ashy water flash at once in his mind. “No, never mind. It’s great that Seahawk isn’t here.”

“What’s wrong with Seahawk?” Teela asks.

Catra mimics a boat with her hand, then makes a *fwooshing* sound and pantomimes an explosion.

“I see.”

“There’s no time to waste,” Duncan says. “We should move.”

“Hold on.” Bow looks at Adam. Something about him is still too… princely. Royal. Elegant, and almost unapproachable. The kind of appearance that makes you wonder how someone can exist so beautifully without seeming to put any effort in at all. Like Glimmer, he thinks with a smile. Bow sticks his tongue out and ruffles Adam’s hair. It’s all frazzled like he just woke up and never bothered to fix it. A strand falls against his nose. He blows it out of the way, but it keeps falling back. Adorable *and* effective. “All right, let’s go.”

It doesn’t take long for Duncan to find a boat, but no captains are willing to offer their services. Duncan cites his experience with vehicles of every kind and elects to pilot one himself, and begins the long, long process of haggling a price. The discussion turns into a debate, so the others slip away. They wander through the crowded streets into a sprawling marketplace, bustling with vendors and merchants of every kind. Adam promises to pay for anything they find. He does not let them say no. For Glimmer, Bow finds a pearl necklace. Then, he decides she’d like a coral dagger more. Catra and Adora accidentally buy the other identical ruby hair clasps. Adam gets Teela golden bangles for her arms

and a scabbard for the sword. He pays for everything with solid gold coins. This alone draws the attention of the crowd, but when he starts paying for complete strangers, it's only through Melog's magic that they escape without any real incident.

For all her history with the sea, Catra reasons she should find it less calming than she does. Yet, as the waves lap against the boat's sun-faded hull and the breeze carries its salty tang through the air, she can't help but feel at peace. Maybe it's the weather. Perhaps it's the sense of open freedom. It could be the simple joy of watching Adora knock Adam onto the deck. Again. She doesn't have anything against the guy. But it is pretty funny.

She stands on the upper deck and leans against the railing next to Man-At-Arms—Duncan, she reminds herself he wants to be called—who helms the wheel of the boat they bought. For all his talk of discretion and low profiles, he was very quick to use his royal paycheck to purchase the most expensive one they could find. An assurance of quality, he said. It guaranteed safety, he told them. It was the only one with an onboard shower system, she knew.

Teela pulls Adam up and dusts his vest off; she points at Adora's stance and Adam tries to replicate it.

"Think he's got it this time?" Catra asks.

Duncan frowns. "Have you tried not letting her hit you?" he asks Adam over the sounds of the engine.

"I'll try that."

He does not do a very good job of it.

Teela pulls him up again. He rolls his shoulders and takes a stance. At least he's determined, Catra thinks.

Everything about Adora's style is subdued. She makes fewer attacks, hits slower whenever she does, and leaves wide openings that someone with enough skill could take easy advantage of. But Adam seems to have too little, and the most he does is delay the inevitable long enough to end up against the wall beneath Catra's feet. Adora parries the one strike he makes and ends the mock duel with the end of her staff pressed against his throat.

"You're pretty good at this," he says, panting.

"I've had a lot of practice." She backs off and tosses her staff to Bow. Adam leans on his and rubs his neck with a sheepish smile.

"No offense," Catra says to Duncan quietly, "but is that really the best you've managed to train him?" She knows that most people aren't proficient in multiple forms of close-quarters combat and weapons training by the time they hit puberty—and those who aren't are better off for it—but she did expect… more than what she's seen so far.

"I haven't trained him at all. The King forbade it. In fact, I was given explicit orders to prevent him from participating in combat training of any sort."

Catra looks between Duncan and Adam, who is already losing another match. "Then what do you call that?"

His expression doesn't change, but a glint appears in his eyes. "Roughhousing."

Something hits the boat.

It strikes the hull with a dull thud that reverberates through the deck and sends the entire vessel lurching to the side—Adam stumbles and catches himself on the railing, just in time to stop himself from falling overboard. He stares at the lapping waves as sickening vertigo washes over him.

Under the water, a pair of eyes watch him back.

The sea's surface explodes in a frothing mess of foam and the light of the sun is obscured by dark shadows that race overhead. Behind him are the sounds of wet, heavy smacks and cries of alarm from his companions. Adam flips around.

Everyone stands completely still. Bow is on the stairs to the upper deck, an arrow notched in his bow and two others held with it. Duncan shoulders his heavy, square rifle. Catra and Adora stand back to back, sword and claws ready. Teela is in front of him—her staff leveled at their new guests.

There are a dozen of them, at least. Each one is a head taller than even Duncan and covered in dripping, glistening scales. Multicolored frills line the sides of their wide faces and large, unblinking eyes dart between each of them as they hold bronze spears and tridents out.

Aquaticans: the amphibious denizens of Eternia's oceans. They stand in a circle that parts where it's closest to Adam. From the gap walks one marked by brilliant pearlescent armor and a coral sword at his hip. He holds his head high and hands behind his back. When he stops, he looks each of them in the eyes then holds his fist in front of his mouth and clears his throat. "Disgusting land-dwellers—you are horrible to look upon and your presence sickens me. Your deaths will be a mercy. For me, that is." He turns on his heel and waves his hand. His retinue readies their weapons and begins a slow advance.

“I appreciate the honesty,” Catra says.

Adora chuckles and raises her sword. Bow draws his arrow back and Duncan’s rifle begins to whir.

“Wait!” Adam shouts. He pushes himself in front of Teela and holds a hand in front of the approaching aquaticans. “I am Prince Adam of Eternos, royal heir to the throne. These are my companions in arms. What you’re doing could incite a war between our people!”

“What are *you* doing?” Teela whispers through gritted teeth.

He tries to look more confident than he feels and gives her a reassuring smile.

The armored aquatican looks over his shoulder with a glaring eye. “I’d say the same of your trespassing. Would you not?”

“King Miro’s treaty entailed free travel between our nations, so… no.”

“King Miro’s treaty?” He scoffs and holds a clenched fist in the air. “That was an offense to the very idea of a treaty. I, Mer-Man of the Crystal Sea, decry it! It did nothing but strangle the growth of our great empire and allow your nefarious machines to disturb our waters.”

Adam holds his hands together beneath his chin. “That’s not entirely true. And even if it were, I think murder is still a bit of an overreaction.” He nods, and the others slowly nod with him. Even one of the aquaticans does until Mer-Man smacks him upside the head.

“And you have a better idea?”

Now would be the time to say that better idea, Adam thinks. Supposing he has one. He looks at his friends. Teela, Bow, and Duncan each eye the aquaticans with tense, nervous faces. Catra

almost looks excited. Adam turns to Adora and raises his eyebrows in a silent plea. Her lips flatten and she shrugs.

He does have a better idea, doesn't he?

He musters all the royal charisma he can and with as disarming and charming a smile he can manage, says, "You could try… letting us go?"

Mer-Man stares at him. His eyes narrow. "Deal with the others," he says to the aquaticans. He draws his sword. "I'm going to kill this one myself."

The aquaticans lunge at them with savage, killing blows that are barely blocked in time for the next strike to fall. Duncan and Bow are overset and forced into melee, desperately trying to find the distance needed for their weapons. Catra and Adora fight back to back while Melog yowls at any of the aquaticans who come near Cringer, who cowers against the wall.

Teela shoves her way in front of Adam. She barely fends off two aquaticans. Each hit she blocks pushes her back and the sharp clash of their weapons rings in Adam's mind. An aquatican grabs her shoulder and throws her to the side, but she rights herself almost as soon as she hits the deck. Still, the two aquaticans stand now between them. The dozen others, between Adam and everyone else.

Everyone except Mer-Man.

His pearlescent armor glitters in the sun and he holds his coral sword out, parallel with the deck—an aquatican salute, he recognizes. One signifying the beginning of a duel.

Adam unhooks the telescoping staff from his belt and with a shaking hand flicks it to life. He tries to steady his breathing and lowers himself into the stance Adora showed him.

Legs wide.

Feet firm.

Keep yourself loose, but ready.

Mer-Man opens with an overhead strike. He's fast. Adam blocks it almost on instinct alone—his conscious mind only registers the blow when the strike sends a bone-shaking reverberation through his body that rattles his teeth and breaks his stance. Further back only leads to the railing, and beyond it, the sea. To each of his sides are the aquaticans, and ahead, Mer-Man.

There's always an opening, Adora had said. If you can't find one, make one.

Mer-Man thrusts at him. Adam twists his torso to dodge and almost falls, but he uses the momentum to spin around behind him. He swings at his back, but Mer-Man turns faster and parries the blow with the flick of his wrist.

Mer-Man swings at Adam with careless, lazy attacks. Even then, Adam can't match his skill and only keeps the wounds he suffers from being mortal. A cut on the cheek. A glancing blow against the arm. A deeper slash on his leg puts him on one knee. Every hit pulls a cry of pain from his throat and tears brim at the edges of his eyes. "Is this the best Eternos can offer?" Mer-Man asks. "I expected little from you, but *this?* I'm doing your family a service. Maybe their next child will be more competent."

"Adam!" someone cries.

Each cut burns with the blistering heat of the sun and stings like the icy bite of winter. A salty tang stains the back of his throat and seeps into his mouth.

The violent crash of the conflict around him seems quiet now. Distantly, as if he were watching from some other place, a bright light flashes amidst the aquaticans and sends them sprawling back. Something whirs and an explosion sounds to his side.

"Teela!" Catra says.

He can’t tell who’s losing. He doesn’t know if his friends are winning. But it doesn’t matter. They’re not close to him. Not as close as Mer-Man.

I’m going to die, he thinks. His friends are still fighting, and he will die.

He failed his family, he couldn’t help his friends, and he is going to die.

“Don’t hurt them,” he chokes out.

Mer-Man raises his foot and kicks Adam’s face—with a wet squelch, his nose crumples under Mer-Man’s heel and everything goes black.

Mer-Man sneers at the twitching body of the land dwellers’ prince. The little lordling groans and clutches at the ruin of his face as blood pours between his fingers and pools on the deck. He did him a favor, Mer-Man thinks. Their noses are so large. So… protrusive. At least he’ll live his last moments slightly less ugly than he’s been for the entirety of his life.

The sounds of battle rage behind, but Mer-Man pays them little mind. His retinue is elite. The mightiest warriors of a mighty people. He’ll kill this one, they’ll kill the rest, and they’ll all be back at the palace in time for supper. It’s to be vent-broiled Kraken tonight. He indulges in dinner-time fantasies as he raises his coral sword above his head and lines the blade with the prince’s own.

What did he say his name was?

Aaron?

Andrew?

Mer-Man wonders if he can get away without including it in the missive he'll send to Eternos' king. Maybe the death of his son will finally get the old wretch off his throne.

There's only one way to find out.

Mer-Man takes a final breath of dry air and readies the killing blow. Then, he hears the strangest sound. Not the clang of metal around him or the sloshing of waves below, but a whining, pitiful thing like the land dweller's infants he's been unlucky enough to come into contact with before. It's not the prince—the most that comes out of his mouth is a low moan—but something beside him. Slinking across the deck in slow, jittering movements is a… What are they called?

Tigers?

Yes. A tiger. A little green tiger the size of the boy it crawls toward. Its ears are pulled tight against its head and its tail is held close against its body. Its fangs are bared in a threat, but Mer-Man can recognize fear, even in its animal eyes. It must be trying to roar. Or growl, at the very least. The last screams of a pet, loyal to the end to its doomed master. But it seems so very afraid, shaking like a sputtering mer-child who's first tasted the bitter chill of arctic waters. It can't even bring itself to come between them. It pulls its paws back each time it tries to take a step and the simple act of looking at it makes the tiger shrink back in cowering fear.

"Are you trying to protect him?" Mer-Man asks the beast. He knows it can't understand him. He doesn't particularly care. "Well, if that's the best you can do then you'll just have to watch him die."

Mer-Man swings his sword for a decapitating strike and the tiger yowls in hopeless anguish.

His blade strikes something hard.

Something metal.

The edge digs into the shaft of a snake-headed staff and the sharp ring of its impact echoes in Mer-Man's mind. The staff flicks up, carrying his sword with it and almost out of his grip. Mer-Man swings about and faces his new challenger, both already in stance.

"Blood in the water," she says. "Don't you know that attracts sharks?" It's the furry one. That cat-faced humanoid who still wears that insufferably smug expression on her face. She smirks, her fangs gleaming in the sunlight, and rests her staff across the back of her shoulders. The other beast, larger than the green one and with a mane of blue fire, stalks around her legs and growls with an unnatural ferocity. The woman's head hangs low and a dangerous air shines in her eyes and follows her words. "Or in this case, the tigers."

Chapter End Notes

> Y'know, I didn't go into this chapter with "Mer-Man tries to start a race war" in my notes, but sometimes that's just how it goes. Actually, I was planning on basing his personality around the LoP design from the Origins line, where he just looks like a real swell guy (just compare it to his vintage face....), but then nothing would have happened so I made him a douchebag and things got a little out of hand. Good thing Catra's here. Let's hope she can pull this off.
>
> Wait I just fucking realized that I've never seen a ship name for Adam and Bow. I know there's only like... two pieces of art from it made by one dude, but you'd think SOMEONE would have done it by now. Adow? Bowdam? Adabow? Fuck, this is hard.
> I haven't seen one for Teela and Adam either and people

have had 40 years to work on that. Well, maybe not. I doubt the 40+ MotU crowd deals with this shit. There aren't exactly a lot of new fans to do it either... Teedam? Adala? Adeela? This isn't even touching on the multiship name. Or how that dynamic would work. Bow and Glimmer, then Adam and Teela, with Bow and Teela sharing Adam on alternating weekends? Big quadruple?
Damn good thing I said there wouldn't be any serious ships outside Catradora, otherwise the whole thing would have been derailed by this.

Closer Than You Think

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The copper tang of blood fills the air and the beat of Catra's heart echoes in her ears. She flexes her hands and shifts her weight onto the fronts of her feet. Melog growls.

"You bested my warriors," Mer-Man says.

"Wasn't very hard."

He narrows his saucer eyes. "I think you'll find I'm a more challenging prospect."

"Doubt it."

He sneers and raises his sword, holding it parallel to the deck.

Slowly, they start to circle each other. Melog weaves between her legs and she deftly steps around them—it's not a hindrance for either, as owed to their bond and experience with the other. It's a useful distraction, providing one more thing for an opponent to focus on as well as hiding Catra's intent that they might discern through her footing. She waits until the hot sun beats on her back and Adam is safely behind her. She glances at him, trusting Melog to cover her. He still holds his bloodied face and groans through the pain, but he's pulled himself against the railing and stymies the flow that comes from his leg.

He'll be fine, she tells herself. The scars will be something he can brag about.

The others fight behind Mer-Man: She-Ra and Teela battle together as they work their way to the stairs, held alone by Duncan with an electrified mace as Bow looses arrows from the

upper deck. They four stand against a dozen rest. Catra only has to deal with one.

The second that Mer-Man blinks from the sun, Melog strikes. They leap forward with bared fangs and a screeching yowl. Mer-Man brings his sword up to block them, but it was a feint: Melog disappears mid-air and never makes contact. Catra lunges and swings the staff low. He's faster than she expects. Mer-Man twists his wrist and blocks with a parry-strike that would have taken a chunk out of her shoulder if she hadn't already been twisting around to get behind him. She jabs at his back but glances off the shimmering armor and he faces her before she can recover.

Every attack they make is parried, blocked, or dodged and swiftly followed by a counter similarly avoided.

"For a glorified sea-food dish, you're not half-bad," Catra says.

"I've heard it's tradition for you land-dwellers to turn an animal's pelt into a rug. You'll make a fine funerary gift for the prince." Mer-Man's hand shoots out and locks tight around her throat. Scaled, clammy fingers start to squeeze and he brings his sword up for a killing strike, but Catra bests the panic in her heart. She tenses her body. Melog comes from behind. They latch onto his shoulders and bite into the back of his head. Brackish blue blood sprays around their fangs. Mer-Man screams. His grip loosens only a fraction, but it's all the opportunity Catra needs—she drives one heel into the deck and kicks his knee. Something cracks. She pulls herself free and readies for a strike to his face, but he throws his shoulder forward, hurtling Melog at her. They collide with a grunt. Melog knocks her off her feet and the wind from her lungs, and they fall sprawling to the deck.

Melog is the first back up. Catra twists into a low crouch. She steadies herself against the deck and holds the staff behind her. She breathes deep the salty air and chastises herself for the excitement thrumming in her chest.

Mer-Man touches the back of his head and brings back a bloodied hand. He rubs his fingers together. “I’d almost forgotten what this was like. Is it wrong of me to enjoy it?”

“As long as we’re all having fun.”

Melog’s mane flares up, and with a wet growl they disappear.

“That’s a wonderful trick,” Mer-Man says.

“Then you’re gonna love this.” Catra stands to her full height, then vanishes.

Mer-Man barks out an astonished laugh, but worry creeps in, unmistakable, as he scans the deck. He flicks his eyes and stays light on his feet, holding his sword close and ready. But she’s already behind him.

The first hit is to the back of his leg, already weakened. He falls to one knee and tries to swing at her but Catra needs no effort to dodge such wild, aimless blows.

The next lands on the shoulder of his sword arm. He doesn’t drop it as she hoped, but even though he knows where she was his attacks are too slow to follow where she is now.

The third is an upward strike to his lower jaw. He reels back.

Melog bites his heel. By the time he kicks at where they were, they’ve already returned to Catra’s side.

Catra brings the staff overhead for a decisive attack, but Mer-Man closes his eyes. The slightest instant of hesitation betrays her and he whips around to block the blow. Their weapons meet with a thud and a shock runs along Catra’s arms.

Mer-Man smiles.

In the Horde, Catra learned through many harsh lessons that everything, everywhere could—and would—be used as a weapon.

She taught herself that the most dangerous ones would be those you don't expect: if someone corners you in the cafeteria, they'll grab a tray. In the halls of the Fright Zone, they'll tear a pipe off the wall. They'll find a brick to throw. Even a shard of glass that cuts their own hand. If you knock away their gun, watch for a knife. And if they have nothing, keep an eye on their fists.

Catra doesn't see Mer-Man's until it already fills her vision—she hears the crack of its impact before she knows what she's looking at. Her lip splits open and everything goes white.

A sharp ringing fills her ears and spills into her mind. She opens her eyes to the sight of blurred blue and white. Damp wood presses against her back and Teela's staff is a world away. She grits her teeth and holds back a groan. Melog licks at her cheek. Slowly, she manages to pull herself up, just in time to see Mer-Man bring his sword down and split the deck between her feet.

What delirium she feels is drowned by a surge of adrenaline that carries her onto her feet and away from the encroaching attacker.

"I must have hit you harder than I thought," he says. "I would have sworn your head would be there." His eyes are open now, but he doesn't try to look for her. Catra glances down and sees she's still invisible.

She shakes her head clear and unsheathes her claws.

Her attacks are wild, uncoordinated, and filled with savage energy. She was too predictable before, Catra reasons. He saw through the technique of a soldier, so she would face him as a beast.

Yet, what attacks do land are blocked by pearlescent armor and the flat of his sword. His own make little contact—the closest blows shaving single hairs off her coat, but he grows more accurate and more sure of his strikes as each second passes.

Even Melog can do little to help. Mer-Man seems to know where they're coming from the moment they move. Melog tries to latch on his shoulders again, but Mer-Man slams into them as they leap,

sending them crashing into the railing and almost into the waters beyond.

Catra stops herself mid-strike when Mer-Man turns and nearly looks her in the eye.

“I can hear you. Smell you. Taste your blood in the air. Yes, this air is thin, but it carries the ripples of your movement as would any water. Did you think I could not best what I could not see? When I have fought where the sun has never shone?”

From Adam’s side, a streaking blur of white and red dashes across the deck.

Catra lets Melog’s magic fade and cocks her head as she comes back into view. “Maybe it’s just my ego talking, but I’m pretty sure I could still beat some oversized salmon.”

“Remarkable confidence for one on the verge of death.”

“Bad habit.”

“Then I shall put it to rest.”

She shrugs. “As long as you don’t get distracted again.”

His form falters. Mer-Man must sense something in the air because his eyes go wide and he jerks his head around.

Behind him, lunging forward and swinging her snake-headed staff is Teela, who wears a snarling visage with wild eyes. She slams her staff into his chest, cracking his armor and wrenching a cry from him as he stumbles back. Catra takes a single step forward and elbows his head as he passes. Teela keeps on him with brutal blows that he can only just block. Catra leaps after them and she and Teela fall into a rhythm, each warrior striking after the last, hitting wherever Mer-Man cannot defend. It’s obvious to Catra that Teela isn’t used to fighting alongside another—her fury at the wounding of her friend helps little in that regard—but Catra is

nimble and weaves between Teela’s attacks as easily as Melog could her own.

They force Mer-Man back. He's helpless against their assault. The few attacks he manages only leave him more open and he suffers devastating hits and slashes from staff and claw. Teela kicks him in the stomach and Mer-Man crashes into the railing. His sword slips from his grip and falls with a splash into the lapping waves below.

Each warrior stands still, their breaths ragged and heavy. Catra wipes her face with the back of her arm. Mer-Man can barely hold himself upright. Teela raises her staff above her head and aims the bottom toward the crack in Mer-Man’s armor.

Catra realizes how sharp it is.

She grabs Teela’s wrist. “Wait.”

“I’m not letting him get away with this,” she growls, never taking her eyes off him.

“I didn’t say we would.” Catra points to her lip then balls her hand into a fist.

Teela breathes through her nose, as forcefully as a raging bull, but collapses her staff and holsters it on her back. In unison, the two widen their stances and bring mirrored fists back.

Mer-Man’s face goes flat. “Oh.”

Catra and Teela punch him in the face—a fist for each eye. Over the railing he falls, and with a wet plop, Mer-Man returns to the sea.

What few aquaticans remain standing are frozen in shock. They look amongst themselves, then the other warriors, and make a silent decision. Their escape is a bit louder.

Adora breathes a sigh as the last standing aquaticans jump overboard and drag their fallen compatriots with them. She looks to Catra, who nods, affirming her and Melog's safety. With the way finally clear, she runs across the deck to Adam. Teela kneels beside him and bandages his leg. Her eyes are wide and she mutters hushed, worried things that Adora cannot hear. She pulls a knot and Adam groans.

"Too much blood," she manages to whisper. "Too much."

Adora kneels beside her and places a hand on her shoulder. "Breathe, Teela. It's alright."

"No it's not!" Her voice is quiet but steeped in growing panic.

"Hey." She squeezes her shoulder. Teela's head jerks toward her. "I can heal him," Adora says with what she hopes is a reassuring smile.

"Heal him?"

"Magic."

She nods. "Right. Right." She makes room for Adora, who holds her hands out above Adam's chest. His breaths come in shaking wheezes and though his eyes are open they flit about unable to focus on anything. Behind Adora, Man-At-Arms gasps.

Adora forces a breath out and opens herself to She-Ra's magic. It starts near her heart—a blooming warmth that spreads through her chest and runs down her arms. A tingling follows that raises

the hair on her body and settles in her fingers. She starts to glow. Light shoots from her fingertips and suffuses Adam's body, blanketing him in a gentle heat. He takes a deep, shaking breath and his entire body goes still. When he exhales, it is slow and calm, and a coiled tenseness leaves him.

Teela grabs his hand with both of her own. "Adam, look at me."

He turns to her with lidded eyes. "Did I beat him?"

Teela's face takes on a stoic stillness.

"No," Adora answers for her.

"Didn't think so."

"Get up," Teela says as she pulls him to his feet. He stumbles and has to hold her shoulder to stand.

"Oh, right," Adora says. "I can't really heal 'no blood' so you'll have to take it easy for a bit."

"He'll be 'taking it easy' for the rest of this mission," Duncan says with folded arms. "And before I hear any quips out of you, that means you won't be *participating* in the rest of this mission."

"Duncan—" Adam tries to say.

"No. Not a word. I can't send you back, but I can keep you out of harm's way. When we reach the Dark Continent we'll take you far enough inland to keep our new friends from following us, but you'll be going nowhere near the Horde."

"I can help—"

Man-At-Arms' stern glare silences him. The surety of his look is enough to make Adora feel as if she's done something wrong, too.

"Teela will continue acting as your guard. The rest of us will deal with Keldor."

An uncomfortable silence falls. Adam glares at the deck and clenches his jaw.

“Get yourself cleaned up,” Man-At-Arms says in a softer voice. “You look like the walking dead.”

Teela leads him below deck. Bow pats his shoulder as he passes. They disappear behind the ship’s door.

“Speaking of our fishy friends,” Bow says. “Does anyone want to explain what the heck all that was about?”

“It was a little out of left-field,” Catra says as she slinks alongside Adora. “Or ocean. Sea. Whatever.”

“Aquatican insurgents,” Man-At-Arms says. “A terrorist cell led by the shiny one you and Teela disposed of. They started sinking our ships to provoke counter-attacks in a bid to reinstate expansionist policies curtailed by King Miro’s treaty.” He shakes his head. “But they’ve been inactive for over a decade. King Randor’s peace summits saw their support plummet and our intelligence said they disbanded.”

“And now King Randor is a hostage half a world away from his own people,” Adora says. “Eternos is on the brink and they sensed an opportunity.”

“Blood in the water,” Catra says.

“There are others who would seize this chance. Eternos has few enemies but those it does are older and more dangerous than the aquaticans. We must act quickly if we are to keep Keldor’s hubris from igniting an open war.”

Adora says, “Unless this boat goes any faster we’ll have to take some time to rest up and get ready. I’ve got a bad feeling this isn’t going to get any easier.”

Man-At-Arms nods. “I’ll get us back on course.” He returns to the ship’s wheel.

Something drips against the deck. Blood falls from Catra's chin, leaking from a split in her lip. "You're hurt," Adora says.

"It's nothing."

Adora rolls her eyes and lifts Catra's chin with a finger.

"Hey—"

She cuts her off with a kiss and pours the last of She-Ra's magic into healing her lip and the bruises no doubt hiding beneath her fur. Her body shrinks with the outpouring of energy and a slight ache settles in—the consequences of the preternatural strain on a mortal body. Their lips part with a sigh and Catra tries not to smile.

"Bow was watching that," she says behind a blush.

"Well I've already got, like, three different plans for your guys' wedding, so you'll have to get used to it."

"As if I'd have *you* plan it."

"Do you have someone else in mind?"

"Well, I didn't mean it like that," she says, casting worried looks between Adora and Bow as her face burns crimson. Adora nervously laughs and looks away to spare her some embarrassment.

Bow leans forward. A terrible grin spreads across his face. "But that proves you've been thinking about it."

"Shut up!"

The salt-water shower runs beside him as steam fills the air and fogs the mirror. Adam stands in front of it, most of his clothes piled on the floor, and runs a finger where Mer-Man's sword bit into his shoulder.

There isn't even a scar. Mer-Man is gone. His wounds are healed and Teela is just outside. He's safe. So why is he still shaking?

He's supposed to be a hero: the future king of Eternos, descended from Grayskull himself and son to the greatest king they have seen since. His mother is an explorer from beyond the stars. Teela is the greatest warrior he's ever seen. His new friends are legends. He was supposed to prove that he's a hero, too.

Bony claws steeped in matted fur wrap tight around his throat as a coral blade holds high above his head. Disparaging eyes watch from beyond the fog. They are his mother's eyes, then his father's —Duncan's, and Teela's. Even the Etherians look down on him with nothing but shame.

"What are you doing?" he had asked.

"Adam, stay back!" his father shouted.

Keldor stood, surrounded by terrible machines. He raised his staff and its eyes ignited with sickly, green fire. He knew his father was in danger. He could do something. He had to do something. Why hadn't he done anything?

Teela—and he knew it was her even though he could not see—pulled him away.

He should have done something.

He could have done something.

Couldn’t he?

Purring.

Cringer is purring. He rubs his head against Adam’s leg and purrs louder when he notices him. Adam lets out a quiet breath and feels wetness near his eyes that he tries to blame on the humid air. Still, he kneels and scratches behind Cringer’s ear. The tiger almost seems to smile but looks at Adam with peering eyes that betray a deeper intelligence that only he seems to see.

“I know, buddy.” He runs a hand down his back. “And don’t think I forgot about what you did earlier.” He scrunches the cat’s face up and says in a cutesy voice, “You’re getting *extra* treats when we get back.” Cringer grumbles and pulls free from Adam’s hands but starts rubbing his head against his arm immediately after. “Maybe we can get you a title, huh? Sir Cringer the Brave? Chief of Feline Palace Guard? War Tiger?”

“Adam?” Teela’s voice is quiet, almost unheard through the door and sputtering of the shower.

He scratches beneath Cringer’s chin and stands. “Yeah?”

“You’re taking longer than usual.”

“Do you always keep track of how long I shower?” His voice lacks the typical confidence he has when he teases her. Still, the drawn-out silence means he got the flustered rise he was hoping for.

“Are you alright?” she finally asks.

“You saw the light show.” He flexes his leg and feels nothing of the deep gash that tore through it. “She healed me.” He frowns. “I’m fine.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah.” At this moment, he wants nothing more than to throw open the door and… He’s not sure what he’d do after. Just seeing

her there would be enough, he supposes. But he wears little and his skin is still stained red. “I’ll be out in a minute.”

Silence. But he knows she’s still there.

“Hey, Teela?”

“Yeah?”

“Thanks for, y’know. Saving my life and stuff. I appreciate it.”

He doesn’t have to see her to know she’s holding back a smile. “It’s my job.”

“It’s just… weird. Knowing they’re here. On *this* planet.” Adora's head falls back. They all sit in a loose circle on the deck and the sun dips toward the horizon but has not begun to set. “I spent so long wondering where they were that I never even thought about what I’d do when I found them. Course, ‘so long’ has only been since we started going to space and I realized I *could* find them, but…” she trails off with a chuckle.

“We’ll have plenty of time to figure it out,” Bow says. “And we’ll be with you every step of the way.” He puts a hand on her shoulder. “That’s what the Best Friends Squad is for.”

Catra nods and wraps an arm around Adora’s.

“Aw, guys,” she says.

If they’re a squad, Adam wonders if that makes him and Teela a Best Friends Duo. Or trio, depending on how Cringer fits in. It feels rude to leave him out. “We can make fliers,” he says to Adora. “Hold a party. See if they come to you instead.”

“Sounds like a great way to get some fakers,” Catra says.

“I hadn’t even thought of that,” Adora says. “How am I supposed to know when we’ve found them? Do I get, like, a feeling?” She wiggles her fingers. “A magic family finder sense?”

“One time one of my brothers pretended to be a Horde soldier to scare me,” Bow says. “I didn’t even realize until my dads made him stop. He… wasn’t even wearing a disguise. So probably not.”

“I guess we can start with the portal,” Adam says. “That should narrow it down. If anywhere would have records of something like that, it would be the Royal Archive.”

“We’ll worry about the rest when we get that figured out. All our best plans are improv, anyway,” Catra says.

“Too late for that,” Adora says. “I don’t even know what I’d do when we find them. Just walk up and say, ‘Hey! It’s me! Your kid who disappeared twenty years ago. Wanna get lunch?’”

“It would be a good idea to start small,” Bow says.

“I just have so many questions! Like, do I have any siblings? Cousins? Does mom do singing as a career or just a hobby? Why Adora?” She holds her chin and an expression that Adam first thought was wistful imagination quickly turns to a determined analysis that he hasn’t seen since watching Duncan try to repair his more violently failed experiments.

Bow motions Catra forward. She leans in and he says something into her ear.

She pulls back, clearly unimpressed. “I’m not saying that out loud.”

“You want to, though.”

“No, I don’t.”

Adora nudges her. “Come on, just tell me.”

“*He* can.”

“She’s not *my* girlfriend.”

Catra groans. She breathes out through her nose, and without looking at Adora grumbles, “It’s probably because you’re so… Adorable.”

Adam chuckles into his hand. Bow looks very pleased with himself.

Adora snorts. “That’s it?”

Teela leans toward Catra and whispers, “Does he always flirt for you?”

She scoffs. “I came up with that years ago. I thought it was too dumb to actually use.”

“So you do think I’m adorable?”

“Yeah, obviously. Otherwise, I wouldn’t have stuck around so long.”

“Hey!”

“You asked.”

They laugh and shove at each other until Adora, with Catra’s hand pressed against her face, says, “Oh! I almost forgot.” She de-tangles herself from Catra, then unsheathes the Power Sword. “I figured since I’m going to have to search an entire planet for someone to use this thing we might as well start here. I don’t

think Eldress said you have to be Eternian, so you're all good for tryouts." She flips it around and holds the handle out. "Any volunteers?"

"I've been wondering if I could pull off being blonde," Catra says. She takes the sword and twists it around, testing the balance. With a satisfactory smirk, she raises it above her head, opens her mouth to speak, and says, "So what am I supposed to say?"

"'By the Power of Grayskull,'" Bow replies in a jokingly deep voice.

"At least, we think," Adora adds.

"That's not as cool as yours," Catra says.

"That's what *I* said!"

"Come on! I wanna see blonde Catra." Bow says.

"Alright, okay." She clears her throat and straightens her arm. With the Sword of Power aloft and the sun shining bright along its blade, she says, "By the power of Grayskull!"

"...Absolutely nothing happens," Bow says. "Interesting."

"You try it."

Bow stands and takes the Power Sword. He holds it at the level of his waist, an open palm resting on the blade. "By the power of Grayskull!"

"Woah, woah! Look at that!" Catra says.

"What? What is it?" Bow asks.

"Oh, never mind. Must have been the wind."

"Funny. That's funny. Anyone else want to try?"

Adam nudges Teela.

She pushes herself up and Bow hands it to her. She grips it tight and holds the blade in front of her face—her reflection stares back from it. “By the power of Grayskull!” Gentle waves lap against the hull and a seabird cries in the distance. Teela relaxes. “I prefer my staff, anyway.”

Adora says, “That just leaves—”

“Duncan,” Adam finishes for her. “He hasn’t tried yet.”

“Oh. I guess so.” She looks up at him. “You wanna try the magic sword?”

“I’d hate to interrupt.”

“C’mon,” Catra says. “The boat can steer itself for a bit.”

“If anyone here could use it, it would be you,” Teela says.

Duncan shakes his head but Adam can see the tell-tale signs of a smile in the crinkle of his mustache. He steps down from the upper deck and takes the sword when Teela holds it out for him. He runs his hand along the flat of the blade. “And I just…?” He looks to the others for instruction.

“You can have it wherever. I hold mine up because it looks cool,” Adora says. “Then you just say the words.”

“And there’s a dance to it,” Adam says. “Just a little… y’know.”

“Oh yeah,” Adora says. “That’s the most important part. Can’t forget it.”

“I’m sure,” Duncan says. He holds it in a casual dueling stance. “By the power of Grayskull,” he says, unenthusiastically.

“C’mon!” Teela groans.

“You have to *mean* it,” Bow says.

He shakes his head, but says again in a deeper, more authoritative voice, “By the power of Grayskull!”

The deck starts to shake. A great rumbling sounds from below and the sky grows dark.

The ship’s engine stabilizes and the cloud passes.

“I believe that leaves you, Prince Adam.”

“What? You kick me out of the mission to keep me safe then start handing me magic weapons for fun?” He hopes the humor comes through more than the selfish bitterness he pretends he doesn’t feel.

“If what we’ve heard about this is true and from what I’ve seen of her,” he nods toward Adora, “then once you have this you won’t need someone else to keep you safe.” Duncan holds the Sword of Power out for him. Adam realizes he’s being serious.

The handle is dark, wrapped in fine leather. Its guard is beautifully shaped and inlaid with the gilded writing of Ancient Eternos. The blade is so perfectly reflective that Adam can see his own conflict on it.

Everyone else can see it on him.

The weight of their gazes sets a fire on his face. “We all saw what happened the last time I used a weapon. Probably not a good idea.” He tries to hide his embarrassment with a laugh. They just look more concerned.

“Well, what were the odds it was going to be someone here?” Adora says. She drapes her arms around Bow and Catra’s shoulders. “Couldn’t be that easy. Never is. But we’ll have plenty of time to look.”

“We can buddy it up with your family search,” Bow says.

“Imagine if you find both at the same time,” Catra says. “That’d be convenient.”

“Oh! You could be sword-siblings!” Bow says.

“You think I have a sister?” Adora asks.

“Or brother!”

Adam tunes them out and stands. He wobbles—Duncan and Teela both move to support him. “It’s fine,” he says. “I’m just turning in.”

“It’s a little early for that,” Duncan says.

“‘Take it easy,’ remember?” Adam grins.

Duncan shakes his head and laughs breathlessly. “Yes, I think you’ve earned a few extra hours of sleep.”

Adam walks to the door and Teela starts to follow, but he waves her away.

“Are you sure?” she asks.

He doesn’t *not* want her to follow, but with how she was smiling with everyone else…

“Don’t let me get in the way of your fun. Just tell me about it later, okay?”

She smiles, but her brows crease in a hint of concern. “Alright. Goodnight, Adam.”

“Goodnight, Teela.”

“Aw, where’re you going?” Bow asks.

“I’ll see you in the morning,” Adam says.

Catra says, “He needs his beauty sleep, Bow. Twelve hours. Remember?”

Adora just watches him. She’s holding something back.

“Wake me up when we’re on dry land,” Adam says as he closes the door behind himself.

Chapter End Notes

Alternative title: Catra v Mer-Man: Dawn of Bad One-Liners

And that's the end of Racist Mer-Man, at least in this fic. If he, Stinkor, and a few other plotlines, later on, seem a little out of place or left hanging, it's because I'm trying to write this as if it's an actual set-up for a proper series. So it's working as a stand-alone sequel while also laying the groundwork for a hypothetical show that will never exist, if that makes sense.

And I do hope that Adam's moping doesn't come off as excessive. I want to show how out of his depth he is but I'm kinda worried it'll be annoying

Hunter and Prey

Chapter Notes

Teeny tiny chapter
Entrapta would be proud

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kronis hates this ship. He hates how quiet it is. He hates how bright the lights are. He hates the stark whiteness of the walls, the awful green running along them, the brain-dead bots always stomping about, and he hates the *actual* brain-dead clones who control them. They don't even *see* him, he thinks. Oh, they *look* at him. They watch him when he passes. They turn from their little jobs and panels and whatever else it is they do to follow him around the room with their empty, glowing eyes, but they don't *see* him.

He shoulders past one clone standing in a narrow doorway. It doesn't grunt, it doesn't complain, it doesn't even push back. It takes his shove then keeps standing there as if it never happened. It never stops watching him.

It's enough to make him miss prison. At least the guards there beat him when he acted up. The other prisoners fought back. But here, even when he breaks a limb or blows off a head, the clones just stand there. They just watch.

As Kronis nears the ship's bridge, the air goes from chilled to freezing. His breath clouds the instant it passes his lips and prickling goosebumps grow along his arms. For the first time since he became a killer-for-hire, he regrets not wearing a shirt. He stands before the white—always white—door to the bridge. The access panel is green. He sighs, then bangs on the door. "Right, you wanted to see me this time, so don't make me find one of your blokes to—"

It opens with a scraping hiss.

"Oh."

Keldor—*Lord* Keldor, he reminds himself of what he's being paid to call him—sits in the central command chair. He's faced toward the view-port which makes up the entirety of the front-most wall and stares out at the sky. His hands are laced under his chin and that ram-skull staff lays across his lap. Kronis stands at his side. Keldor watches the sky.

"In a mood, then?"

"What do you want?" Keldor asks, still staring off.

"That's what I was gonna ask you. Seeing as you're the one who called me here."

Keldor looks at him, only turning his eyes. Deep bags have settled under them and the skin of his face is paler. He looks down into the ram skull's empty eyes and for a moment, he just stares. "Of course I did," he says as he stands. "You wanted an assignment, yes? Well now you have one: She-Ra is instrumental in the success of this endeavor, just as she holds the potential to end it. She has within her the means of my victory, and now she holds the Power of Grayskull. This I need if I am to unite Eternia under my banner. Once Marlena agrees to exile and I have Randor forge the documents assigning my ascension, the legal path will be secured. But it is only with Grayskull's sword that the *people* will support my rule. Do you understand?"

"Oh, yeah, of course." It's a hair-brained plan that could, and has already started to, fail in a thousand different ways and would likely end with 'Lord' Keldor exiled, ashamed, and even more reviled by the people he seeks to command. That being the best-case scenario. But if there is even the slightest chance it can succeed, then the rewards Keldor promises will be well worth the trouble. A full pardon, his pick of the royal treasury, and, what he looks forward to most: a chance to put that Man-At-Arms in the ground for putting *him* behind bars. Oh, Kronis has plans for him.

Like, cutting his arms off and calling him ‘Man-Not-At-Arms’ before he bleeds out. Or, ‘Man-Without-Arms.’

‘Man-No-Arms.’

‘No-Arms-Man.’

He has plenty of time to figure it out.

What matters now is that he’ll play along. Keldor can play at being the mastermind, and Kronis will reap all the rewards promised (and a little more when no one’s looking), and if it all goes belly up, he’ll steal this ship, leave Eternia behind and find work somewhere else. In a galaxy like this, someone’s always hiring.

“I nab the blonde, you do… whatever it is you’re planning, and we kill anyone who gets in our way. Easy.”

“No,” Keldor snaps.

“Huh?”

“Adam lives. If I find any harm has come to the boy then you can discuss future employment with the former captain of this vessel.” The oddly man-sized scorch mark on the floor punctuates his message well enough.

“Right. Fair. The kid lives. But we could just wait for She-Ra and her merry little band to come to us. Seeing as that’s what they’re already doing.”

The room grows even colder. The lights do not dim, yet the world seems to darken, as if the color in this colorless space has gone faint.

“I know,” Keldor says, not looking at Kronis. He grits his teeth.

“Wanna expand on that?”

“You don’t understand!” Keldor barks. He stares, wide-eyed over Kronis’ shoulder. There’s nothing there.

And no, Kronis *doesn’t* understand. It’s a recurring issue with Keldor. It was strange enough when he saw another gar wearing the gaudy clothing of Eternian royalty, even stranger when he heard him speaking in their accent, so much so that the magic staff he held and army of alien robots he was using to attack the city seemed normal. But all his behavior since made Kronis wonder if Keldor was even more mad than the insane situation he had put them both in. “Right, message received. Just… kidnap the most powerful being in the known universe and bring her here with half-a-dozen bloodthirsty warriors at my back.”

Slowly, Keldor’s eyes fall on him. “Do you doubt your own abilities, Kronis?” Keldor sneers, and Kronis knows it’s an attack on his pride. He knows he’s being goaded.

“She-Ra, eh? Won’t be a problem at all.”

Kronis turns to leave. As he walks through the bridge’s door, he can feel Keldor watching his every step. What unnerves him, however, and leaves him with a feeling of true unease, is that somehow, for some reason he cannot understand, he feels the presence of another in that room watching him too.

Chapter End Notes

> You guys have no idea how much shitty, incorrectly used Aussie slang was in the first draft
> Also the second season of the CGI reboot was confirmed, so that's pretty poggers

The Dark Continent

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You won't be slaying any dragons with footwork like that," Keldor had said, not looking up from faded papers.

"Neither will you, if all you do is read about it." The sword Adam held was blunt—a training weapon Teela had smuggled from the armory. He kept it in Keldor's office to use when the mental fatigue of pouring over old books and manuscripts set in. The only cure for that kind of exhaustion was to exhaust oneself physically. He swung it about and imagined himself facing the Evil Horde of old legends, fighting alongside King Grayskull himself. Somehow, it was a more realistic fantasy than his father allowing him to use the training yard.

"Empty air makes for a poor sparring partner, Adam."

"Do I have a better one?"

"Well, your old uncle might not be the man he used to, but I'm no stranger to handling a blade." Keldor pushed his chair back and walked to the fireplace, opposite the bookshelf where he kept so many old tomes. The fire within was only smoldering, and most light came from the softly glowing crystals that hung from the ceiling. From the mantle, he took an old blade that was said to be one of the many used by Grayskull before he found his legendary sword. This was, by Keldor's own admission, not at all true, with the original having been long lost to history. But, he had also said, pretending it was real made for a better story. He held it out, pointing the tip of the narrow blade at Adam's chest. "Would you like a real lesson?"

"From the royal bookworm?" Adam asked. It was a nickname given to Keldor by Randor, and one Adam knew always riled him into entertaining moods. "I'll be teaching you, old man."

Keldor chuckled. It was a warm sound, one that reminded him of his father. "Then have at me, hero."

Adora brings her staff down almost faster than Adam can react. He manages a parry—and only just—that forces her staff wide and leaves her side exposed. He swings sideways to strike it, but she's already lunged forward into his gut, her open shoulder now a battering ram, sending him sprawling on the deck.

From his upside-down vantage, the distant shore of the Dark Continent creeps ever closer.

"That was good form," Adora says, holding out a hand. She pulls him up. "And trying to get that opening was the right move."

"Then what did I do wrong?"

She smiles—a carefree look that almost hides the smugness in her eyes. "Nothing. I'm just faster."

"Then I guess it's time I stop going easy on you."

"Oh, I'm *scared."* She crouches low, and Adam matches her stance. They hold the staves as swords, the majority of their length hidden in the telescoping handles. Adora had offered him the Power Sword to spar against her own summoned blade, but Adam said it was in poor taste to use a historical artifact as a tool for training. Duncan overheard and quickly barred the use of any sort of bladed weapons.

Adam does his best to mimic her footwork, but there is a fluidity to Adora's movements that speaks of her lifelong experience as a fighter. An involuntary life, he reminds himself. Neither she nor Catra says much in the way of their experiences in the Horde, but the stilted, short answers and sideways glances tell him enough. He resolves again to show them all the beauty of Eternia and the luxuries of royal living once this is over—it's the least he can offer in return. But first, he'll show Adora that he's a quick learner.

She leads with a sidelong strike. Adam turns his staff down to block it—they impact with a sharp *clack* that turns to an arrhythmic beat as she bears down, forcing him into a backfoot. She's not as aggressive as before but leaves no room for retaliation. "You're being forced back, and behind you is certain death," Adora says. The ship's railing edges closer with every step. "What do you do?"

She jabs at Adam's chest. He puts his weight behind a parry and forces her staff aside. She ducks and brings her shoulder forward, aiming for his gut. Adora kicks off the deck, but Adam leans aside and turns on his heel. Already bringing his staff down for a blow across her back, he says, "Get behind them!"

But he never makes contact.

Adora had to have known his plan before he even started to move: without looking, she held her staff over her shoulder in a diagonal guard. Whether Adam struck overhead or sideways, it didn't matter. He never would have hit her. He can't see her face, but he knows she's smiling. "Very good. However—" She twists around in a low crouch and—their staves never losing contact—twirls her wrist, wresting Adam's staff from his hand and sending it flying across the deck. She holds the point of hers beneath his chin. "You've been disarmed and they have a blade at your throat. You're out of moves and can't run. Now what?"

"Wait for Catra to save me." He looks over his shoulder. Catra, Teela, and Bow watch the exercise with varying levels of amusement.

"Not this time, pal," she says.

"Bow?" Adam asks.

"I think that defeats the point of the exercise."

Before he can even ask, Teela is already shaking her head.

"None of them are here to help you," Adora says.

“But She-Ra is.”

“She-Ra is evil and she’s out for blood.”

Adam shrugs. “Sorry, I don’t have a lot right now.”

She rolls her eyes and lets the point fall. In the second she turns away, Adam snatches the staff and leaps back, then holds it between her eyes. He stands with the swaggering confidence of a pirate lord and says, “I distract them long enough to seize an opportunity.”

Adora nods. “But you forgot something.”

“What?”

“If that was a sword, you just lost all your fingers.”

“Aw, what? Not fair.”

“This is training, not a game.”

“It’s only hypothetical.”

“Hypothetically, you just lost a hand.”

“Well, hypothetically, you…” Having no retort, Adam cries out. “Bow, look!” he says. “She’s right, I’m bleeding out! Again!”

Bow runs toward him and slides the rest of the distance on his knees. With a gasp, he takes Adam’s hand. Adam drops the weapon of his undoing and falls, holding the ruined stump toward Adora.

“Adora, you have to help him!”

She starts packing the staves away.

Adam groans as his life force leaves him and he slumps into Bow’s arms. “I don’t think I’m… making it out of this one…”

“Adam, just hold on,” Bow says, choking up. “We’re gonna get you home.”

Adam coughs. “Not this time. Looks like I’ve reached… the end… of the line…” His head rolls back and his eyes flutter shut.

Bow holds him close and touches his forehead to his own. “No…” he whispers.

There’s nothing else that can be done.

“Maybe when this is all over you guys can start a theater troupe,” Catra says.

Teela pulls Adam up by the back of his collar. “The lead could use some work.”

“That performance came from experience, Teela.”

Adora claps him on the back. “Keep up the training and hopefully you won’t get any more.”

“That was good, then?”

“You’re definitely getting better.”

Adam knows it’s a half-hearted compliment, but he still waggles his eyebrows at Teela.

She just rolls her eyes, but it’s enough to push aside the memories of Mer-Man.

“Ready your things!” Duncan shouts from the wheel. “We’ll make landfall within the hour.”

“Adam!” Keldor shouted. He threw his sword to the ground and held Adam’s hand, studying the wound. A thin gash crossed the back, already bruising around the edges.

They would blame it later on the jagged stones of Keldor’s mantelpiece—stones that had cruelly struck at the crown prince

after he tripped on an old volume detailing the dangers of a sedentary lifestyle.

"Is there nowhere in this castle where my son is safe?" his father bemoaned.

Mother had only laughed.

Adam shrugs his bag into an empty seat as Duncan and Bow guide the Wind Raiders out of the ship's hull. The entire front of the vessel opened as a single door, like the drawbridge of a castle.

"Shame to just leave this here," Bow says.

"We'll have someone get it once this is all over," Adam replies.

"Or we can leave the keys for the first person who finds it."

"I don't think anyone would want to deal with the mess on the deck," Adam says with a wry grin. They had only managed to clean some of the blood from his little altercation with the aquaticans. The rest, they covered with a blanket.

But Bow isn't smiling. "Yeah… I know you're fine, but are you *fine?* That was kind of a lot to be joking about so soon. You doing okay?"

"Yeah, no, I'm good." He rubs his leg where the coral blade cut deepest. "Just trying to lighten the mood, y'know?"

He nods. "Well, if you ever want to talk about anything, we're all here for you."

"Even Catra?"

Bow laughs. "I promise she doesn't hate you. But she said you look like Adora—it probably weirds her out."

"Seriously? What, because we're both blond?"

“That’s pretty much what I said!” He brings the Wind Raider next to Duncan’s, then jumps out of the seat. “It’s like, you’re both Eternians, but that doesn’t *mean* anything.”

“Who knows? Maybe we’re cousins.”

Bow shakes his head. “I don’t see it.”

The Wind Raiders race across barren lands and shattered stones. The air here feels thinner and even the sky seems a more muted shade of blue. Adora shifts so that the Power Sword doesn’t bite into her shoulder. She turns her attention to more immediate concerns.

On the horizon, a range of mountains rises up like jagged fangs. Man-At-Arms flicks a series of switches and dials and says through his communicator, “We’ll stop here.” He brings them down and Adam lands his Raider beside them. They each disembark. Adora holds Catra’s hand as she does, knowing she doesn’t actually need the help.

“I’m sorry,” is the only thing she hears from Man-At-Arms’ talk with Adam. He can’t be any more enthusiastic about being left behind now, but he says nothing in defiance of the decision. Teela stands next to him and Man-At-Arms clasps them both on the shoulders before moving aside. Catra nods. Bow grabs them both in a hug.

Adora says, “Thank you. Both of you. If you hadn’t come with us then I truly don’t think we would have made it this far. But Man-At-Arms is right, and I think this is for the best.” Teela looks a little

prouder and despite Adam's obvious disappointment, she can tell her words have lessened the blow. "But if it's not too much to ask, I was hoping I could talk to Adam before we leave." She looks at both Teela and Man-At-Arms and only continues with their silent approval. "You mind walking for a bit?" she asks him.

Clearly confused, he follows her. Cringer sneaks alongside him, but Adam stops and says, "Go say bye to Melog before they're gone, okay bud?" The tiger hesitates, but licks his hand and turns away.

The ground here is more gravel than dirt and crunches loudly with each step. Adora waits until they pass a large boulder and are out of sight before speaking, but Adam says first, "What's this about?"

Adora watches a wispy cloud drift across the sky. "When I became She-Ra, I accidentally gave a horse wings and the ability to talk."

"Okay?"

"He called himself Swiftwind, and he said he was my 'Noble Steed.' I didn't have a clue about what to do with him. He was loud, brash, and always found a way to make himself the center of attention. When he tried to help… things didn't always go the way he intended."

Adam's jaw tightens and he looks at the ground.

"But it never stopped him from trying, and he ended up saving my life and helped protect all of Etheria, too. There were times when he doubted himself, and I'm sure he wondered if he was ever worthy of the power that found him. Even if Swiftwind didn't beat Horde Prime, I never would have without him."

Adam sighs. "You're saying I need to understand how much I've already helped and let you guys handle the rest. Right?"

"You don't have to prove anything, Adam. We've all seen how brave you are."

“Bravery doesn’t help much when you get whooped in a sword fight,” he says with disarming sarcasm.

“No, but that’s what friends are for.” Adora folds her arms. “And don’t try to hide how you feel with jokes. That’s as bad as lying about them.”

The annoyance on his face quickly gives way. “Zoar, you guys just read me like a book, don’t you?”

“We learned all this the hard way.”

“Well, you’re good at teaching more than just sword fighting.” He puts a hand on his hip and purses his lips. He scratches his chin. “But, uh, thanks for the pep talk. It helped, really.” He smiles. “You probably give a lot, huh?”

“No, not really.” Her own smile is slightly embarrassed. “I’m usually more of the…” She mimics punching something. “Y’know?”

“You grew up a soldier. I’ve had one person my age to talk to my entire life. I’m surprised we can hold a conversation at all.”

They both laugh. The weight of being a moral teacher lifts from Adora’s shoulders. For a moment, she’s it's like she's just talking with a friend. Then, she feels a different weight. “There’s something else, though.”

“What?”

She draws the Sword of Power and rests the flat of the blade against her palm. Staring at her reflection, she says, “Every time you’ve had the chance to take this sword, you haven’t.” She looks at him. “Why?”

“Why would I?” Her silence is a question, and Adam continues. “I know it’s not like you were ever asking me to be the champion of Grayskull, or anything, but…” He shrugs. “I’m his descendant, it’s…” He grinds a heel into the ground. He shakes his head. “I guess there’s no point in lying, huh? That sword is everything I’ve

ever wanted. The power, the legacy, the respect it commands. All my life I've wanted to prove to my family that I'm more than just a child who needs to be protected. I know they love me, but I want them to *respect* me. To see me as an equal who can stand *next* to them instead of behind a shield they're holding."

He sits on a small rock and Adora crouches next to him.

"When I heard Eldress say that you needed to find a champion on Eternia, my first thought was that it should be me. Just… who else could it be? I'm the prince, the descendant of Grayskull, off to rescue my father from a treacherous uncle and save the world. It's straight out of a fairy tale. Like the legends I always wanted to live." The longer he speaks, the more loathing creeps into his voice. "But then I remembered Odiphus. How I just… froze. I remembered how I got there. What kind of hero has to sneak into their own story? What kind of warrior freezes up the moment they're in danger?"

"The only reason we beat Odiphus was because of you."

"Maybe. Who's to say one of you wouldn't have thought of the same trick? How long is She-Ra going to be kept out of the fight by an overgrown skunk?" He shakes his head. "After that—hearing more about what you've all done, what I couldn't…" He clutches his leg. "I realized holding that sword is the last thing I want."

"Why?"

"Because if I take it… If I say those words and nothing happens, then everything my father has said, everything I've been afraid of… It's all true. I'm not a warrior, I'm not a hero, I'm just…" He holds a hand out and clenches his fist. It falls to his side. "You don't have to say anything. I know it's stupid. It's selfish."

Adora nods. "If you're not a hero, then who are you? There's a voice in your head telling you it's the only thing that matters. More than you. More than your own life. If you're not the hero, then

you’re nothing. If you can’t be one, then everyone you care about dies.”

Adam listens, rapt in attention.

“I never wanted to be She-Ra. I never wanted to be a 'hero'. But that’s what everyone said I should be, and eventually, I started to believe them. It nearly killed me. Like, really often.”

He chuckles. It's a tepid sound.

“And I wish it never happened to me. And *that’s* selfish, and I know there’s so much about my life now I’d never give up that never would have *happened* if I wasn’t She-Ra, but… If I could give it up? If I could give this power to someone else and leave it all behind?” She shakes her head despite the life such thoughts provide. “I couldn’t. Because I’d never want someone else to go through what I have.” She holds the Sword of Power between them. “But I have to do it anyway. And what no one tells you about being a hero is that all the glory, the fame, all the noble deeds and acts of legend… None of it is ever worth how much it hurts. Everything about my life that I love? That was Adora who fought for it. Not She-Ra.”

After a pause, Adam says, “I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to say that—”

“No, no I’m not saying that you can’t—” She groans into her hand. “I don’t even know what I’m trying to say. Did any of that make sense?”

He mulls over her words. “Yeah, I think I get what you mean.” He nudges her shoulder. “You’re not half bad at this speech thing, y’know.”

“I could be a lot better.”

“And I could be better at not getting beat up by fish people. We all have our faults.”

“What did I *just* say about jokes?”

Adam holds his hands out. “Fair enough. It was scary, and I’m working through it. Judging by the locale,” he casts a wide arm over the desolate landscape, “there won’t be anything to do *but* work through it.”

“It won’t be the only thing.”

“What do you mean?”

With a sad smile, Adora shifts her grip on the Power Sword and holds the handle out.

“But—”

“I’m not asking you to be Grayskull’s champion. I’m not even asking you to use it. But if this is something Keldor wants then we can’t risk bringing it to him. I need to know it’s somewhere safe.” She looks into his eyes. “With someone I can trust.”

Adam looks between her and the sword. He forces himself to swallow. He reaches out. But he doesn’t take it.

She places the handle in his palm and wraps his fingers around it. “I’m sorry. But it’s only until we come back.”

Slowly, they stand. Adora gives him the scabbard and he sheathes the sword over his shoulder. He fiddles with the strap until it seems to sit comfortably. “It’s heavy,” he says.

“I know.”

The walk back is a quiet one, punctuated by the crunch of gravel and pitched winds. For the first time, Adora notices an acrid, sulfuric tinge in the air. When she looks to the horizon, a part of her expects to see the twisted silhouette of the Fright Zone. “I haven’t forgotten what I promised you,” she says. “I don’t know your uncle, but if you think he’s someone worth saving, then I’m going to try.”

For several long seconds, there is only quiet between them. Finally, he says, “Thank you.” He kicks a rock. “But don’t think you’re getting out of *my* promise.”

“What do you mean?”

“I’m using everything to help you. Official broadcasts, town criers, royal decrees. We’re gonna martial the guard.”

“Adam—”

“No talking. While you and your girlfriend are getting the royal spa treatment, *Eternia* is going to find your family. We’ll have a parade, a nice little dinner, the whole works.”

“That’s really not necessary.” As grateful as she is for the offer, Adora’s mind is flooded with memories of her first meeting with Perfuma and the early days in Brightmoon.

“No, it’s not necessary at all. But you’ve earned it.”

She shakes her head and lets him detail the rest of his plan.

Teela leans against a Wind Raider, parked on the ground, while the others sit in Duncan’s, waiting to leave. Noticing Adam’s acquisition, Teela raises an eyebrow.

“We’re babysitting the magic sword,” he says.

She nods.

Adora slides into the corner of her seat and rests a shoulder over the edge.

Duncan flicks a switch and the Raider rises with a thrum. The engines scream as they power on.

“Hey,” Adam says, with a hand cupped around his mouth. “Good luck.”

They wave each other off, and soon Adam, Teela, and Cringer are nothing but specks in the rear-view mirror.

The crooked mountains ahead grow larger by the minute. From the tallest, a plume of smoke rises like an infected scar splitting the pale blue sky. Beneath its peak is a weeping flow of molten rock, blazing and orange even from miles away. It pours out of a gargantuan snake's maw, carved from the dark basalt of the mountainside. Above it, floating still and silhouetted by the smoke, is a white ship.

Adora’s face tightens. Her eyes are grim.

“Hey.” Catra holds her arm. “We’ve done this a hundred times. It’s routine.”

Adora forces a breath through her nose. “I know. Never feels any easier.”

She shrugs. “If Mr. Man-At-Arms here knows how to use half the guns he’s got on him then this should be a cakewalk.”

Catra is always so obvious when she's trying to cheer her up. Adora appreciates it anyway.

“I’ll try to keep up with you kids,” he says.

Bow twirls one of his trick arrows. “We’ll just have to see how all those fancy toys stand up against the classics.”

“And what does that one do?”

“Shoots another arrow.”

“How devastating.”

They compare arsenals: Bow’s explosive arrows argued against his grenades, a bolas arrow versus a net launcher, and a regular arrow that flies farther or a wrist-mounted laser beam.

Bow concedes the last item.

Melog chirps and climbs into the space between Catra and Adora.

“You ready?” Catra asks them.

They meow.

“Can they cover us that long?” Adora asks.

“They’re pretty confident.”

Adora stills the worriedness in her heart. Melog can cloak themself for hours at a time. A ship the size of Darla, minutes. A Wind Raider and four passengers? It should be easy.

Should be.

Adora speaks up and says, “If we’re cloaking we’re doing it now. Everyone ready?” They nod. Melog’s mane flares up as they channel their magic. Adora, Bow, and Man-At-Arms fasten their seat-belts. “Catra,” Adora says, looking at hers.

“What? It’s uncomfortable.”

“It’s safe.”

“And I’ll just land on my feet, remember?”

Adora rolls her eyes—her gaze lands on a blue-skinned rifleman who kneels atop a boulder and aims at her.

Teela sits cross-legged on the ground and rubs Cringer's chest. He purrs as loudly as a Sky Sled's engine and bats at her hand whenever she slows. The air is chill, yet the earth is warm. It's a result of volcanic activity, Adam told her. It warms the ground and results in the cracks within that seep out a toxic combination of steam and sulfuric gasses. It's the reason the ancient Snake Men founded their empire here, he said. But his fascination with the vents lasted hardly a minute and now he wanders in a circle before her trying to balance the Power Sword on two fingers.

"You're going to cut yourself," she says.

"I'm bored."

"And I don't want to explain why the crown prince is missing a nose when Duncan gets back."

"Adora would heal me."

"And what if I tell her not to?"

He stops and flips his hair. "Would you really let this face be ruined forever?" He grins in that way he always does—the kind he *has* to know leaves her face burning with embarrassment from the shame of being seen near it.

It's the kind of joke he makes when he's hiding something.

Almost imperceptibly, her face furrows. *You're nervous*, she says without speaking.

In an instant, his facade falls. He scoffs and tries to wave her off but chews on his lip then, deflated, sits in front of her. He scratches Cringer's chin. He frowns, but his eyes betray his worry. It's a question. *Aren't you?*

"Of course I am." But she doesn't need to remind him that Duncan travels with the single most powerful being in the universe and that with them are—despite Adam's constant reminders of her own skill—two warriors even he would have to

admit outclass her. This is a danger the Etherians are more familiar with than anyone in the galaxy. With Duncan at their side? She almost pities Keldor. The Horde, less so.

“We came with them to help.”

She curls an eyebrow. *You snuck after them. I had to follow you*, the gesture says.

“That doesn’t change what we promised them.”

“We’ve helped them already.”

“How?”

“Right now, by staying out of the way.”

He breathes in and folds his arms. She’s made a point he knows is right and has no argument against. She feels the slightest bit of satisfaction and her face twitches in the ghost of a smile.

“Then you admit that we’re just a liability.”

“It’s what I told you before we left.” *Am* I *the one admitting that?* she leaves unsaid.

"Yeah, whatever." He puts the Power Sword across his lap and runs his hand along the flat of the blade. “I really thought this was going to be important. The big power-up that saves the day, y’know? Instead, here it sits. Languishing. Forgotten. Not even worth bringing to the moment when they might need it most.” His voice oozes melodrama and Teela half-expects him to lay a hand across his forehead and faint into her lap. “C’mon,” he says when she doesn’t take his bait. “*You’d* be a big help. Admit it.”

“If I were helping them then who’d be guarding you?”

“You say that like Cringer’s not here.”

“He couldn’t guard his dinner from a fly.”

“Teela!” he says in mock outrage. “Cringer saved me from a sabre-cat when he was just a little cub.”

“You saved *him.”*

“Oh?” he grins again. “Then why do I need guarding?”

“Because your idea of fighting it was to run away.”

“I was *seven.”*

“And now you’d be able to beat one?”

“There aren’t any sabre-cats on the Dark Continent.”

“Earlier, you mentioned wyverns.”

“Yeah… Well… Could *you* beat one?”

She shrugs. “I’m sure I could distract it long enough for Cringer to take care of things.”

Adam laughs—it’s a clipped, barking sound that still drags Teela’s lips into a smile. Cringer purrs a little louder.

Behind Adam, a lancing beam of orange light burns against the pale sky.

“What’s wrong?” he asks.

Before she can answer, he’s turning, and then they’re running to the top of a nearby hill. Past the horizon and before the hazy peaks of distant mountains, a dark column of smoke rises in the sky.

Adora coughs. Acrid, black smoke clouds the air, her seat belt digs into her chest and stomach, and she can't think. She can hear fire and someone else is coughing and she can't think. With fumbling hands, she unbuckles herself and tries to stand. Her legs give out.

They were going somewhere.

They had to do something.

Why can't she remember?

Her vision is blurred by smoke and eyes that refuse to focus. She tries to concentrate on a dark patch on the seat in front of her. There's something warm on her face. She touches it, and her fingers come back sticky.

Head trauma, a part of her says.

She stands again, but her body is running on an unnatural instinct drilled into her so many years ago.

She stumbles out of the burning wreck and crashes into the ground. She coughs and inhales the dirt and so she coughs again. She drags herself onto her feet.

Why can't she think?

Concussion, it says. You've been wounded. Run a status check.

She holds her head and tries to focus.

Everything hurts.

She pads a shaking hand along her torso and legs.

No signs of further bleeding.

Nothing broken.

Ribs are likely bruised.

If you’re not dead, you can lead. You’re a Force Captain. Where is your squad?

“Catra?” Adora calls out, aimlessly wandering. “Catra!”

Nothing but smoke and ash and the crackling of fire.

She stumbles and falls to one knee.

“Lonnie? Kyle?”

“Adora,” a gruff voice says. A pair of arms are around her, pulling her up.

“Adora!” someone else shouts. Calloused hands cup her face and wipe something out of her eye.

She knows this one. She grabs his shoulder. “Bow.”

“Yeah, it’s me. Come on.” Melog slinks beside them, meowing loudly to no response.

“Catra. Where’s Catra?”

“I don’t know.”

She fights a knot in her throat and throws her eyes about, searching for any signs. “Catra!” she shouts with a breaking voice.

Past the smoke, the air is clear. Clear enough to see the dozens of Horde bots that surround them, each with weapons charged and readied. In a hovering platform stands a clone, watching them with empty, sparking eyes.

They're purple, Adora thinks with the first semblance of clarity. Their eyes have never been purple before.

Melog growls and shifts red. Adora and Bow gasp.

Beneath the clone is Catra, grimacing and held around the throat by the rifleman, who points a gun to the side of her head. He smiles. “G'day, She-Ra.”

Chapter End Notes

> Since it might be a little confusing, Adam and Teela weren't psychically communicating, they've just known each other so long that they have a really, really good read on what the other's thinking.
>
> Also, I was going to have Kronis say, "G'day, sheila," and then have a whole little bit where Adora goes, "It's... She-Ra," and Kronis is like, "I know," and it would be Funny™ but then I realized it wouldn't fit the mood. Unfortunately, it was also the whole reason I made Kronis Space Australian. I might fit it in later, who knows.

Worthy

Chapter Notes

Alternate title: Chapter 10 pt. 2

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Behind her, the Wind Raider burns. Around her, dozens of Horde bots have their weapons trained. Beside her, Bow, Melog, and Man-At-Arms stand, each of them as helpless as she to stop what's ahead.

The rifleman's arm is locked tight around Catra's throat—her claws dig into his skin, but she doesn't struggle. He holds a gun against her head. His finger is already on the trigger, tensed and pulling back.

It could happen in the time it takes Adora to blink.

Her head throbs.

Her body aches.

She fights the urge to scream.

"Let her go," she says.

"You're not the one who's making demands," he says. His accent is thick and grating. She digs her nails into her palms and her mind reels, searching every aspect of this scenario for a way out.

"What do you want?"

"Money, mostly."

She grits her teeth and—

"Oh, careful now. One more step and we find out how many lives she has left." His arm tightens and Catra grimaces.

“Dying would be better than listening to you talk,” she chokes out.

“Ha! Looks like I nabbed one of the fun ones. I wish all hostages were like you.”

Man-At-Arms says, “You want money, Kronis? A ransom, is that it?”

“You know this guy?” Bow asks.

“Course he does,” Kronis says. “He’s the bloody bastard that locked me up. And don’t think I’ve forgotten about that, Duncy. But no. I’ve already got a boss. And he wants her.” He nods toward Adora. “You are She-Ra, yeah? Thought you’d be taller.”

Adora’s breath comes in ragged, shallow gasps. Her jaw hurts from the strain it’s under and the dwindling rational part of her mind worries that she’ll shatter a tooth. Her eyes are wide—bloodshot from the smoke. But she doesn’t blink. “Let her go.”

“That’s not how this works.” He smiles in mock sympathy.

“Do you have any idea what I did to the last bastard that hurt her?” Her hand twitches. Sparks of energy and a divine glow shine between her fingers.

“Adora,” Bow whispers and puts a hand on her shoulder. She forces a breath through her nose and closes her fist. He turns to Kronis and says, “You work for Keldor?”

“Took you that long to figure it out?”

“What does he want with her?” Bow asks.

“Her ‘power,’ whatever that means. Think he said something about ‘whatever means necessary,’ but I’ll tell you what: I consider myself a pragmatist. The way I see things, Keldor told me to get her, and that’s all I’m getting paid for. Executing you would be a bit of a bore, and I’m not getting any bonuses, so here’s my offer. Paying attention?” He looks at each of them, nodding his head.

“You come with me, and I let her go. Simple as that. Keldor gets She-Ra, I get paid, and the kitty keeps her head. Everyone’s happy.”

“I know you, Kronis,” Man-At-Arms says. “You’ll have those machines kill us all. How can you expect us to agree to that?”

“Because for the last… Honestly, I’ve lost track, but for however long I’ve been out here, I’ve been bored. And I know *you*. All you heroic warrior types. I’ll let you go, you’ll dust yourselves off, get back up, and come following the second I turn around. You’ll die trying to get her back. I think that’ll be funny.”

“Whatever Keldor is promising you, the royal family can actually deliver on. Let her go and we’ll match his terms and forget that you were ever here. You and I can settle our score alone.”

Kronis’ laugh is harsh and wheezing. “And what makes you think *I’d* agree to—”

“Shut up! Just shut up!” Adora snaps. “I’ll do it!”

“Ad—” Catra is cut off by Kronis’ squeeze. His face drops and he looks very bored.

“Thought there’d be more fight in you, but alright. Come on.”

“Adora, you can’t!” Bow says.

“We don’t have a choice. I’ll be alright.”

“You could die!”

“Could?” She looks at Catra, then turns back. “Or will?”

His anguish is plain enough. She can see in his face the same helpless anger she feels, too. But there’s nothing else to be done.

Adora holds her hands up and, waiting for Kronis to nod before taking the first step, walks the distance between them. “Gag her,”

he says to the clone. It steps off its dais and holds out a small metal mask. The inside glows green and when it places the thing against her mouth, hard-light projections wrap around her head and hold her jaw shut. With a similar device, it binds her hands behind her back. The clone pulls her onto its dais and Adora glares at Kronis, who only smiles. "I could just kill her now. Not a damn thing you could do about it." Her eyes go wide and she tries to shout, but all that comes is a muffled groan. "*But* a deal's a deal, and I am a man of my word."

He drops his arm. As Catra gasps for air, he whips his gun across the back of her head and kicks her to the ground. "Now, I think it's high time we—"

"Hey!"

"Eh?"

Atop a hill overlooking the scene stands Adam, Power Sword in hand with Teela beside him. A bot crumples to its knees and its head rolls down the hill, coming to a stop at Kronis' feet. "Let her go," Adam says.

Kronis rolls his eyes and points his gun at Adora.

"If you do anything to her I'll tear you apart!" Catra shouts as Bow and Man-At-Arms hold her back.

Adora tries to tell her to calm down. To wait and let her handle things. She tries to tell Adam to stop, that he's only going to get himself hurt. She tries to tell them—any of them—to wait, to find her later, that it's going to be alright, but she can't even hear her own voice. None of them can hear her, and things keep happening and there's nothing she can do.

Kronis cracks his neck and gestures around. "While you two were off making a royal baby, the rest of us were talking business. Had a nice little deal until you showed up. So tell me, hero. What do you think you're gonna do?"

Adam flinches. Reflexively, he looks at Teela, but she wears the same worried grimace as the others. Adora stares at him with wide eyes. Her face is bloodied and her hair, a mess. A metal gag covers her mouth and she shakes her head.

"You just gonna stand there?" Adam recognizes him. The blue skin, the myriad of weapons, the grating accent. Kronis. An interplanetary mercenary and walking mountain of muscle Duncan had personally defeated. But why was he here? Why was he working with the Horde? Kronis had been locked away for years, deep in the most secure prison the capital—

Uncle.

He wouldn't have.

Would he?

Kronis was a *murderer*—a psychopath that had killed almost a dozen of Duncan's men before they took him down. Uncle Keldor knew that.

Why would he free someone like him?

Adam shakes his head in a desperate attempt to focus. "I can't let you take her," he says. Even he can hear the lack of conviction.

"Adam," Duncan says.

Before he can continue, Kronis says, "And how are you gonna stop me?"

Adam looks back at Teela. He looks at Duncan, Catra, and Bow. When he looks to Adora he realizes they're all watching *him.*

Kronis holds a gun to Adora's head. Half the bots train their cannons on the others—the rest are on Teela and him.

A single step.

One moment of action.

It would be over in the blink of an eye.

Kronis nods as if he can see exactly what he's thinking. "Not very good odds, yeah? You fancy yourself a gambler?"

"Huh?"

"It's just—Hold this," he says to the clone, who takes his gun and presses it against the back of Adora's head. "If anyone except blondie up there moves, pull the trigger." He walks forward with his thumbs looped in his belt. "Your hero routine. I think it's funny. Stupid is what it really is—the only reason you're all not scorch marks on the ground is because I never told Bright Eyes here to blast you all to high heaven. So how about we make a deal?"

"Just let her—"

"No, no, no. Here's what's gonna happen. I'm going to stand *right here.* And *you* are going to hit me." He raises an eyebrow. "Make sense?"

Adam's palms are slick with sweat. He shifts his grip to hold the sword steady. Everyone is watching him.

"I can tell you're confused," Kronis says. "You're gonna hit me with everything you've got. Use all the force you can muster with those little arms and swing that sword as hard as you can. You get one hit. If it kills me, you win. I'll be dead, the bots'll leave, and little She-Ra will be safe and sound. If not…"

Adam swallows.

"He's lying," Teela whispers.

What other choice do we have? he says with a look. Teela holds his shoulder but doesn't pull him back when he starts down the hill.

"That's right," Kronis says. "C'mere."

"Adam, don't—" Duncan is cut off by Kronis, who clicks his tongue. A Horde bot fires a searing blast of green energy at the ground in front of him, knocking him back off his feet.

"You'll get your turn, Duncy. This one's between me and the twink."

Adam stops a dozen feet in front of him. His throat is dry and his heart hammers against his chest. He has to make himself breathe and it feels as if his legs are going to crumble beneath him.

Bow, Catra, Duncan, and Teela watch, frozen utterly in place and daring not speak a word. Like the others, Adora bores into him with wide eyes.

Isn't this what he was training for?

Isn't this why he came?

But the longer he looks at Kronis, each second he stares into his eyes, he sees more clearly something else staring back. Wide eyes, saucer eyes—skin of scales and blackened fur. He feels hands locked around his throat and blades cutting into his flesh. His uncle laughs, and it is a cold sound, so much like his father. He sees bodies, broken and lifeless on the ground. They are dead, and still, they watch him—staring with unblinking eyes, and in his head, he hears their voices, and they hate him and loathe him because he could not save them.

From his boot, Kronis draws a knife the length of his forearm and holds his arms out. “Better make it count, hero.”

The wind whispers his name.

He looks to the blade of the Power Sword. The only eyes that stare back are his own.

When he looks again at Adora, she only shakes her head.

But he can show her. He can show them all.

Those who watch him, who scream out in his mind—his father, his mother, Teela—everyone. He’ll show them, and they’ll see. He’ll save them, and they’ll see.

He tries to slow his breath, but it turns to gasps. He tries to widen his stance, but his legs tremble. As he tries to steady his resolve, it only weakens and the voices in his mind are louder, and the weight of their gazes is crippling and even the wind is speaking, telling him to focus and he can’t and Kronis is sneering and everyone is watching and he points the sword and shouts, “By the power of Grayskull!”

And then there is silence. Within his mind and all around him, he hears nothing. He feels nothing—his legs are numb and his arms are stiff, pointing the sword at a man who only smiles. The others are watching him. He dares not meet their gazes but from the corner of his eye he can see Adora.

The look on her face.

The one he’s seen a thousand times before.

Not worry. Not fear—not for his life or her own.

Pity.

Disappointment.

Just like all the others.

“Was something supposed to happen?” Kronis asks. “Cause let me tell you,” he keeps talking, but Adam doesn’t hear him.

His arms fall to his sides, the sword falls to the ground, and he falls to his knees. His eyes are wide and he can’t even look at Kronis when he kneels in front of him. “I know this is all a little embarrassing,” he says in a voice that almost sounds soothing, “but if you start crying, I will laugh.” His breath stinks of cigar smoke and with a rough, calloused hand he tussles Adam’s hair then stands, popping his back. “Right. We’re going,” he says to the clone, stepping onto the dais with it. He says to the others, “I said I wouldn’t kill you, and I meant it. But I do have to keep you from following me.” He clicks his tongue and the clone presses a button. They rise into the air and speed off toward the mountains, Adora with them and staring back the entire way.

The Horde bots spring to life, firing their cannons and advancing on them as an implacable tide of metal and green fire. The others scramble out of harm’s way. Duncan shields Catra and Bow with his own body—the lasers blast chunks off his armor with each strike and it’s only when Teela lunges at the bots that they’re able to take a position behind the downed Wind Raider to fire back. Catra and Melog leap out to fight with Teela and they eviscerate any bot that comes in range of staff or claw.

A bot lumbers past Adam. He watches it pass and it watches him —the single diamond eye scans him, then it continues on. Another passes and the process repeats. Then a third, and a fourth, each one looking at him, scanning him, then marching forward as if he isn’t even there.

They’re ignoring him.

He destroyed one of their own, walked into their center, and they’re ignoring him. He wants to laugh. He wants to scream.

Adam takes the Sword of Power and pushes himself up. A bot sees him. As it starts a scan, Adam shifts into stance, holding his legs wide and the sword out. “Come on,” he says under his breath. But it scans him, turns away, and keeps marching.

The sounds of battle around him start to fade and soon all he hears is the beat of his heart and a dull roaring in his ears. His breath quickens and his heart thunders, but he doesn’t feel afraid. He grits his teeth and lunges forward and swings the Power Sword in a killing arc that strikes the bot’s shoulder and cuts deep into its torso. Sparks shower and the impact rings along the blade into his arms, but before it can react, he pushes against it with his boot and rips the sword free then puts his torso into a sidelong strike that cuts its leg off at the knee. The bot makes a sound like an alarm and stumbles forward. Adam brings the sword over his head to drive it into the bot’s own, but it turns to him and levels the cannon at his chest.

His breath hitches and as the weapon charges, the bot scans him again. He doesn’t even have time to wonder if he’s going to die before it turns away and fires at the others.

He starts to laugh.

Then he screams.

Adam jumps on the bot and drives the sword’s pommel into its head. The first strike is only a dent, and the bot keeps firing. Adam hits it again, and the metal crumples. He hits it again. And again. And again.

Again.

Again.

Again.

He’s not really breathing anymore, just wheezing when he brings his arm up and snorting like a bull when he smashes the pommel down. His arm is sore from exertion and numb from the impacts.

The skin of his hand burns from flying sparks and smoldering circuitry.

But he keeps hitting it.

Adam brings his arm up and a hand locks tight around his wrist. He struggles against it, trying to strike the machine, unable to look away from the mangled ruin of what used to be its head.

"Adam," Duncan says. "It's over."

He hears him, but doesn't listen.

"Adam," he says again, sternly. *"Look at me."* Duncan's face is stiff, his brows creased, and his eyes dark. "It's done."

Duncan lets him go and Adam jerks his hand away and can't bear to look at him any longer. Panting, he says, "I wasn't… I couldn't…"

"No, you couldn't," he says flatly. "You couldn't help her and you had to sit there and watch as she was taken and there wasn't a damn thing you could do." Adam's face burns with shame and Duncan continues, "You're embarrassed and humiliated and Adora's still gone. Now how do you think *they* feel?"

Across the field of broken bots and shattered machines, Catra stands. Her body is tense, shaking, and her claws are still out, as if the battle were not yet done. Melog nuzzles her leg and Bow is next to her, a single hand on her shoulder, saying something in a quiet voice. Tears line both their eyes.

In the span of a heartbeat, whatever petty rage Adam holds within drains away and then he feels very, very tired. His shoulders drop. Most of his body is limp. "I'm sorry," he says. He doesn't know who he's talking to.

Duncan sighs. "I know you are. Come on." He offers a hand and pulls him up.

Teela wrenches the end of her staff out of a bot's eye and they all meet in front of the burning Wind Raider. Catra wipes her eyes as they near. Adam pretends not to notice.

"Is everyone alright? Good," Duncan says. "Adora was this mission's commander. In the event of situations like this, which of you assumes the role?"

Catra nods at Bow. He squeezes her shoulder before stepping forward. "Adora is our heaviest hitter. We've never taken out a Horde ship without her. The basics would be the same: I'd hack into the ship's teleporter and get us on board, but instead of the engine room, we'd be going for the holding cells. Our top priority would be getting Adora. Once we'd have her, we'd have She-Ra, and the rest would proceed as planned."

"Would?" Teela asks.

Bow's mouth is pressed in a hard line. "Would. We've never taken down a Horde ship without Adora, and we've never fought another magic-user at the same time. Keldor is the Horde's ace, and Adora was our counter. We don't even know if she'll be in the holding cells—Kronis said Keldor wanted 'her power.' I don't like the sound of that, and it introduces too many variables."

"Do you have another plan?" Duncan asks.

"I can use my tracker-pad to find her, but it won't work until we're on board the ship."

"We'd be going in blind."

"And that still doesn't account for Keldor," Catra says. Her voice is hoarse and lined with a dangerous edge.

It's a bitter pill to swallow, recognizing one's uselessness. He can't fight, he knows nothing of strategy, but, as an idea slowly comes to him, Adam reminds himself that there are more things at stake than his pride. "I can draw him out," he says. The others look at him and where before he would be crippled, he now feels hollow.

“All the bots ignored me. Even when I attacked one, it didn’t care. I think he had some kind of protocol put in so they wouldn’t hurt me.”

“Keldor has something planned for you,” Teela says.

Catra gestures to the carnage around them. “And this wasn’t bad luck. He knew we were coming.”

“It might have been part of his plan,” Adam says.

“Do you think that means you can get his attention?” Bow asks.

“On my own? Maybe not. But we have something he wants.” He holds up the Sword of Power. “Un— Keldor spent his entire life trying to find Castle Grayskull. He was obsessed with the power within. If he knows that I have this, he’ll come.”

“What then?” Duncan asks.

Bow says, “We can have Catra and Melog play support. While Adam distracts Keldor, Catra can sneak up and steal the Havoc Staff. Without it, he’s nothing but a man.”

“What about you?” Catra asks. “You want to go into a Horde ship without any defense?”

“Right now, Melog is our only source of magic. We need that against Keldor." He puts on a show of bravado and says, "Besides, with those two? Our defense is pure offense. We carve a path through the ship, find Adora and the king, then She-Ra busts us out of there. It’s a little gung-ho, but I know we can do this. Everybody in?”

Each nods as Bow looks for their approval. When he turns to him, Adam looks to Duncan and says, “If you’ll have me.”

“That’s not my decision to make, lad.”

Bow clasps his shoulder and smiles. “We're in this together. All of us.”

Chapter End Notes

> As I write these End Notes, I am utterly consumed by the idea of a twinswap AU where Adam ends up with the Horde and Catra is like his older sister despite them being the same age. Since Catra is still a gayass there wouldn't be half as much drama between them and she'd go with him to Brightmoon under the pretense of protecting him from the vile rebels' influence and she is NOT sticking around because she likes living in a healthy environment, it's DEFINITELY to gather intel for the Horde which she hasn't communicated with since they left. Adam would get into fights with Glimmer over Bow's attention and Light Hope would be Light Hopelessly confused over why the new She-Ra is a boy.
>
> And then since Glimmer and Bow would still end up together and Gay Love wouldn't give him the power-up he needs, he'd totally die stopping the Heart of Etheria and then when they meet the Eternians Catra would wonder why that princess she's falling in love with reminds her so much of her dead brother and no one would ever find out the truth :^)
>
> Or maybe Catra reminds him that polygamy is a thing idk

The Face of Fear

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The pulse-aching throb in Adora's mind grows worse each minute she spends in the blinding-white of the Horde ship. She stumbles alongside Kronis and a clone holds his gun at the small of her back. What few others they see turn to watch them pass. Since they've entered, all Adora has heard is the quiet echo of their own steps and an annoying, ever-present buzz.

"We're not on the same side, but I do pity you," Kronis says.

Adora misses the buzz.

"Dealing with Keldor, I mean. He's a bit of a prick."

They stop in front of a solid door with a green control panel. The clone opens it.

The bridge is a vast, open room with panels and screens lining the walls, a multitude of identical chairs across the floor, and a massive view-port that encompasses the entirety of the far wall and much of the ceiling. In the central-most chair—otherwise indistinct from the others—sits a figure in regal garb with a ram-skull staff laying across his lap. His shoulders slump and he sits as if asleep, dark hair obscuring most of his pale blue face.

Keldor, then.

"Remove her gag," he says in a raspy voice.

"I know you're not too keen on good decision making these days, but—"

The eyes of the Havoc Staff flash and an unseen force strikes Kronis and sends him flying into the wall. Louder than the impact

is his grunt and the groans he makes as he tries to stand. For the first time since Kronis appeared, Adora smiles.

The clone reaches a hand around her face—Adora forces herself to not flinch—and undoes a clasp. The hard light dissipates and her gag falls to the floor. It leaves the manacles around her wrists, but they're nothing compared to She-Ra's strength.

She could say the words and, in a matter of seconds, have her bonds broken, the staff in one hand, and Keldor's throat in the other. He has to know that Kronis wouldn't be enough to stop her. He knew enough to gag her. Then, he knows what he's done by removing it.

Invisible energies flow around her hand, but she holds She-Ra's power at bay.

Keldor nods, but he looks to the staff when he speaks. "Leave us, both of you." The clone does so silently. Kronis grumbles. When the door hisses shut behind them, Keldor says, "I was worried you wouldn't see past my bait. It was a base strategy, but there are those who would see this done quickly. I wished to talk, first."

"We can talk about you stopping all this before anyone else gets hurt."

Keldor shakes his head. "Would you protect us? Would you lay down your sword and take up the scepter to rule what no others would? What no others can?" He drags a finger down the length of the ram skull. "No. You alone are suited for your destiny, as I am mine. You, mighty She-Ra, and I, the shepherd of our people. You'd protect a thousand and in your shortsightedness sacrifice a million more. I will dredge this planet up from the depths and drag our people into the light. The galaxy knew the name Eternia, once. It will again."

What Adam sees in Keldor, Adora cannot hope to imagine. But if he's willing to speak, she'll pretend to listen. Her friends are coming. She only needs to buy them time. "The galaxy feared the

name Eternia. You know your history, Keldor. You know what the First Ones did."

For the first time, he looks at her. His mouth is half-open, as if in the midst of speaking, but the moment their eyes meet, he only stares. With the staff, he pushes himself up and stalks forward. As Keldor nears, his mouth closes in a sharp line and Adora has to look up to maintain eye contact. His shadow blankets her. She hardens her gaze. Keldor mumbles, "This is how Nul taunts me, tonight? The spectre summons his ghosts?" He looks her over. "Do you hate them, She-Ra?"

"I know what they're responsible for."

"Then what are you, if not a monument to their sins?"

She rolls her eyes. "Yeah, I've already had that talk. She-Ra came first."

"And yet, here *you* stand. Eternian blood in your veins."

"People are more than their ancestry."

"Indeed. We are heirs to it."

"Then we're also responsible for its sins."

"Sins? Or accomplishments?"

"Oh, don't even—" She holds her jaw shut. Stalling, she reminds herself. This is just stalling. Let him run them in a circle and think he's won. "They built a bomb that would have destroyed the entire universe. What do you call that?"

"Power. And all I need is yours. It might not even kill you. Your power, then this staff is mine. With it, I can save our people. You're a hero, aren't you? What hero wouldn't risk their life for those they love?"

"I've had this talk, too."

“Hmph. Unmask her, Scareglow. I would see her truly before this is through.”

Adora looks around, wondering how she could have missed another. But there is no one else in the room. She wonders more about this mask that is upon her—this ghost she is supposed to be. But there is a chance, she thinks, that Keldor is simply mad.

“Scareglow, I command you! Release this enchantment!” He turns, searching for him as much as Adora. His lips curl in a snarl and he slams the Havoc Staff—bursts of sickly, green fire ignite within its eyes, and where it strikes the ground a tidal wave of force pushes Adora back and pulls at Keldor’s garb like the winds of a hurricane.

His face is wrought with sneering satisfaction, but when he looks at her again it twists with confusion. He leans forward until their eyes are level. They widen and he scoffs. He stands tall, his eyes grow wider as he looks her over, and he scoffs again. He laughs, dry and wheezing—never taking his eyes away from hers. “And yet, here you stand.”

Adora decides that he is mad.

“How is Adam?” he asks. “I notice you do not have my sword. Did you give it to him?”

“Why do you care?”

“He’s my nephew. It’s only natural that I care for my family. Please, sit.” He guides her to a chair and she shudders at his touch. He turns another to face her and sits. “Though, since it has been so much longer, I find myself wondering. How have *you* been, Adora?”

A chill, deep and icy-cold runs down her spine and seeps into her limbs. It should not surprise her that he knows her name. He seems to know a great deal of things and though those who know the name She-Ra are many, it is few who have ever heard that of Adora. But what unsettles her and brings to mind an idea that she

has never even dared to consider, are those words which came before. “You know me?” she asks with whispering lips.

Keldor leans forward. “I was there when you died.”

She thinks to ask what he means. She can’t even take a breath to speak the words.

“You don't remember, do you? No. How could you? Little Adam was just a baby—newly born. You have to understand the situation the royal couple found themselves in—Eternia was a wilder place then and infancy is such a volatile time. I advised Randor that they keep him hidden, at least for the first year. But Marlena couldn’t help herself. She’s always been the sentimental type—a product of her world, I suppose. ‘No more than a month,’ she told Randor. There couldn’t have been more than a dozen of us who saw him in those early days.”

“Why are you telling me this?”

“Because near the end of that month, as the kingdom prepared for the revelation of its new heir, something strange happened. I had gone to see him late one night—he really was the sweetest looking thing, you can imagine what he was like when he was sleeping—when I was stopped by the guards at his nursery. ‘I wasn’t permitted to enter,’ they said. By the royal family’s order, none would see him. They weren’t pleased when I reminded them that I, too, was a member of the royal family. Perhaps there was an order. Perhaps they suspected something of me.”

“You were going to kill him.”

His grip on the staff tightens. “The guards thought as much. What else could the bastard uncle want? Everything I did was seen as a bid for the throne. But what happened after… Really, I’m still not sure how to describe it. It was… like energy. The rawest form of energy. It just appeared there, in an instant. It annihilated the guards and half the room with it. It was by pure happenstance that Adam and I survived. Providence, some might say.”

Her breath is heavy, yet she feels faint. The throbbing in her head is a pervasive ache and the room seems so, so cold.

"It was good that they kept him hidden as long as they did. The King and Queen revealed to the world that by a miracle and the sacrifice of his noble guard, their son had survived an attempt on his life. He would be raised as the Crown Prince and one day lead Eternos to greatness. For their people, they celebrated. Quietly, they grieved. It would have broken the kingdom's heart to learn they started with twins."

She doesn't hear his words, so much as understand them through the dull roaring that floods her ears like the ocean's waves. Her breath frosts in the air. The world spins and she wonders if this is all a dream.

"It is you, isn't it? Our lost princess, returned from the stars with a queenly crown upon her brow and a mighty sword in hand, ready to deliver us from the evil of our oldest enemy. It's the stuff of legends. Adam must be terribly jealous. How did he take it? Marlena?" He rests his arms on his knees and looks at her like they're sharing a joke. "They don't know, do they?"

"This doesn't change anything," she spits out. Her friends are coming, she reminds herself. Catra and Bow will be here soon and they'll rescue her and they can end this all. They'll beat Keldor and the Horde and laugh over drinks about the silly little lies he told her. She'll pet Melog and tell Adam about the joke his uncle made and they'll work together to find her family, and when they do she'll laugh and cry and hold them tight as she was never able to before. She'll tell them about the adventures she's had and the family she's found: Glimmer, Bow, and Catra.

Catra!

They'll love her almost as much as she does. They'll love them all and they've never faced a Horde ship without her and they'll die trying to save her and the room is so cold and it's *his* fault—this

Keldor of the House Grayskull who's plunged a planet into darkness and stolen her family and sentenced her friends to die.

He has to die.

Power, unlimited, flows from within and pools in her hand. The shimmering glow is but a prelude to what will come.

He has to die.

It starts to take shape—a pommel, first. Then, a handle. She closes her fingers around it and a blade begins to form and she isn't angry, she realizes. She's just afr—

Kill him!

With a gasp, the power disappears. Her hand twitches. She trembles and cold sweat dampens her skin.

"He wants you to transform." Keldor looks off to her side, following something unseen. The air is freezing, but her shoulder burns from an icy touch. She jerks away.

"Do not touch her," Keldor says with a sternness yet unheard. He stands, and his eyes move back and forth as he speaks. "The plan was under different circumstances," he says, louder.

"Who are you talking to?"

"Silence!" He jabs a finger. "*You*—" He stares and grits his teeth then shakes his head clear. "There are ways forward without you."

"Me? The king?" Adora asks.

"He'll be dealt with."

She stands. "How? Are you going to kill your own brother?"

He closes his eyes and holds a hand against his temple. "Shut up."

"What about Adam? The queen? Do they die, too?"

“Shut *up*.” He digs his hands into his hair and starts to pull.

“He idolizes you, Keldor. He made me promise that we wouldn’t hurt you and that’s a promise I *want* to keep, but how can I if you’re just going to hurt people?”

“Know your place, demon!” he shouts, wide-eyed and seething. He breathes, ragged and rasping, baring his teeth like an animal. His hands flex. He shakes his head again.

Keldor brushes the hair out of his eyes and forces a swallow as he stands straighter. She wonders if he’s always looked so tired. He places the Havoc Staff against a chair and turns the ram skull away, as if to stop it from watching them. Quietly, almost a whisper, he says, “There are things at work here beyond your understanding, child. The powers I command are duplicitous and their price is great, yet it may not be one I have to pay. Stand with me, Adora. I can cast aside that infernal staff and we can save Eternia together. We can save our *home.”* Behind the wild look in his eyes, Adora can feel his desperation. His earnestness. She realizes, with a sinking feeling in her chest, that Keldor might truly think he’s doing the right thing.

She steps back, shaking her head. “I have a home. It’s a world called Etheria. And Eternia doesn’t need someone like you.”

His lips tighten and his eyes grow dark. “You stand against me, then?”

“It’s not too late to stop this.”

“You throw away your life.”

“Only if you chose to kill me.”

His lip quivers and his brow twitches. Then, he just frowns. He grabs the staff and the gag shoots off the floor and closes around her mouth—he strides through the door and an invisible force pulls her with him. She stumbles, trying to keep pace.

Adora knows well the layout of Horde ships, and through the winding corridors and blinding lights, sounded only by their footsteps and an ever-present, terrible buzz, Keldor leads her down to the holding cells.

Only one is occupied. With a wave of his staff, the energy field crackles and fizzles out long enough for him to flick his wrist and force her inside. She stumbles, but rights herself and stands tall. Keldor's face is solemn. “I do not think ill of you. Nor your companions. But I will do what I must.”

His footsteps echo long after he passes out of sight.

The buzz is quiet here, dampened by the shaking breaths of another.

Adora knows who stands behind her. When she turns, she does so slowly. Even slower does she look at him. King Randor wears a heavy, graying beard, and his face is locked in a pained grimace. His eyes glow a strange purple and bolts of energy arc across them. She wonders what they look like behind that fell magic.

She wonders if they’re like Adam’s eyes.

She wonders if they’re like hers.

For the first time in more than twenty years, Princess Adora of the House Grayskull looks into the eyes of her father.

Chapter End Notes

> In case it's confusing, the only relevant characters who know about The Incident are Randor, Marlena, Keldor, and now Adora. Man-At-Arms was never in the baby protection squad and just thought, "wow she looks weirdly similar to Adam," when Adora showed up. Keldor, knowing that there was a missing twin who disappeared in a portal-shaped explosion, put the pieces together when he saw a gender-bent version of his nephew from a planet that just-so-happened to have emerged from an interdimensional portal.

Also, I wanted to make some stuff for the twinswap au but I forgot how much effort digital art takes so this is all I have to show for it
https://twitter.com/ChapstickPenny/status/1490901030921699328

In the Shadow of Snake Mountain

Chapter Notes

> Kept you waiting, huh?
>
> (If you've been reading this fic before this chapter was punished, then I'd recommend that you ~*~*~RE-READ CHAPTER FIVE~*~*~ because it was almost entirely rewritten and some of the stuff in this chapter won't make much sense without the new context. I cleaned up the prose across the whole thing but that was the only chapter with actual changes to the story)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora is gone.

Adora is gone, and it’s Catra’s fault.

Melog murmurs and rubs their head against her leg. She forces herself to breathe. She wills her claws sheathed.

Adora is gone, and it is the fault of the ones who took her.

Adora is gone, and they are going to get her back.

They have a plan. They always have a plan—a contingency, something to fall back on. Catra will never thank the Horde for what it made her, though, in times like these, she knows its training is the reason she will succeed.

She, Melog, Cringer, and Adam crouch behind a jagged boulder, eying the Horde ship, a thousand feet above. A thousand feet away, unseen behind the base of the mountain, Bow, Teela, and Duncan wait for the signal to beam inside.

Catra does not look away from the ship, from Adora, but asks Adam, “You’re sure he’ll come?”

From the corner of her eye, she sees him nod.

"I know he's your uncle, but if anything happens out there—if I have to choose between him or Adora…" Catra isn't sure why she doesn't finish. Maybe she wants to spare him the full truth. Or, she doesn't want to consider what would lead to such a choice. Perhaps it's because both of them already know.

She expects fear on his face—that pain he's shown before. But Adam looks ahead. His face is flat, except for the melancholy in his eyes. "Keldor made his choice."

It's wrong, to say nothing. She knows it. But she doesn't know what to say. Bow would. Even Adora. But not Catra. So she only nods and starts the slow creep between the craggy stones and vents of steam until they reach an open space below the ship, nestled between the bases of two mountains.

Adam scratches Cringer behind his ears. "Stay back until this is all over, okay?" Cringer mews, but slinks alongside Melog, who nuzzles him.

"Keep him occupied," Catra says. "We'll handle the rest."

Adam stands and draws the Sword of Power. "I'll do whatever it takes."

For a fleeting moment that she ignores even as it passes, Catra thinks she hears something of Adora in him.

Melog's magic fades with a tingle. Adam forces himself to take a deep breath of the acrid air and wills his legs forward, out into the open, utterly exposed.

He isn't alone. He knows this, yet part of his mind refuses to believe it. But he doesn't look back.

He knows he won't see them.

The Horde ship hangs silently above, its shadow suffocating the small valley.

It must see him by now.

It has to.

Adam watches the Horde ship and feels as if a thousand eyes watch him back.

He holds the sword up. A single ray of light—the last glint of the setting sun—catches on its blade.

"Keldor!" His voice strains, but it does not waver.

The wind blows cold, carrying the sulfuric steam with it.

From the ship, a horn cries out with a bass warble that shakes the ground and rattles his mind.

A beam of light, piercing and green, strikes the earth. As it fades, a dark silhouette clutching a ram-skull staff steps forward.

Adam grips the sword tighter and fights a knot in his throat.

"Adam," Keldor says, "I thought you'd never come."

Bow warps back into real-space within the Horde Transporter—his body buzzes as if he's made from a holo-screen's static. "Take a second to re-orient yourselves," he tells Teela and Duncan. They stand wide-eyed, so stiff it seems as if a single gust of wind would shatter them. "The first time is never easy."

His tracker-pad dings.

The surveillance systems are offline. For the next few minutes, they only have to avoid being seen in person, but once the systems are up again…

By then, they should have Adora.

Hopefully.

Teela and Duncan shake their heads clear and Bow waves for them to follow. "Come on."

Through geometric rooms and angled corridors lined with pipes and wires that creep along the walls like overgrown vines, they work their way through the bowels of the Transporter.

The lights are bright and the sense of size nearly overwhelming—if not for his tracker-pad and the schematics it holds, Bow thinks they would be lost a dozen times over. In moments like these, he wishes he had Adora's knack for over-preparation.

They stop at a trio of doors, one sealed shut by a buzzing wall of energy. The entrance to the containment cells. Bow connects his tracker-pad to the panel beside it. It beeps as his code infiltrates the firewall. It shouldn't take very long.

"There's no one here," Teela says, casting worried glances over her shoulder and leveling her staff at nothing.

“I expected more resistance,” Duncan says.

It’d odd, Bow admits. And far too convenient given their normal luck. It’s a possibility he’d considered before they’d even warped inside, but one he, despite all reason, wanted to ignore. “Keldor has no reason to think we can get on the ship. If what you guys said is true, then he should be completely focused on Adam. If he’s controlling the clones, and *they’re* controlling the bots, then they’ll be distracted, too.”

The tracker-pad dings again and the door fizzles out. He can’t help a lopsided smile when he shows the Eternians his handiwork.

“Or,” he admits, “we just walked straight into a trap.”

“Sure seems that way,” a voice says over the intercom. From the other two doors, a small army of Horde bots marches out, a cacophony of clanking metal, their weapons aimed and readied. In a flash of green, Kronis warps in. “Real smart, turning the cameras off. Don’t mean much if there’s only one place you’re gonna go.”

Bow, Teela, and Duncan step back and stand shoulder-to-shoulder. They ready their arms.

Kronis spins a pistol on his finger. “Yeah, not your brightest moment, is it?”

Keldor’s cheeks are sunken and hollow. Dark rings shadow his eyes—wild and unfocused, though they look only at Adam—and

his skin, pale before, is pallid and wan. He leans against the staff and takes shallow, shuddering breaths. He seems more like a walking corpse than the living man Adam remembers.

"Where are they?" Adam asks.

"Somewhere safe."

"It's not too late to stop this."

Keldor points with his chin. "You have my sword."

"That's not what this is about."

"But it is. It always has been. That sword—the power it commands. The respect. Grayskull is the only figure revered by all the civilized people of Eternia. We may claim his blood, but whoever holds his *sword*…"

They would be heir to the entire planet. And with it, the Eternia of old: one that dominated the stars.

"You see it, don't you, Adam? My vision?"

"You're talking about an empire."

"I'm talking about peace. Peace on a galactic scale."

"What makes you think the universe wants you to rule it?"

Keldor starts a slow walk, back and forth—the kind he does when he's explaining something he thinks Adam should already know. "It's only a matter of time before a new Horde rises—some other upstart tyrant with a fetish for control. We hold between us the means of stopping them before they even appear."

"You're doing the same thing they are."

"But we know better!" His eyes are wide and he holds a hand out. "Men like us. We must control that which cannot control itself. It's our responsibility as kings—our burden."

“I can’t let you do this anymore.”

“Can’t you? You’ve shown your mettle already—I know you faced Mer-Man. You have nothing left to prove.”

Adam forces his face flat. Though almost imperceptible, he still shrinks back. “How do you know about that?”

“You’re a smart lad. You tell me.”

He shakes his head. “You wouldn’t have.”

Keldor rolls his eyes. “It’s simple politics, Adam: manufacture a problem and show yourself to be the solution. Extremists are all too easy to encourage—a single promise of independence and Mer-Man was back at his old tricks.”

“But you said—”

“Yes, well, I lied to him.” He chuckles. “It’s rather easy to do. Once I secure Eternos I can point to Mer-Man’s attacks as an example of Randor’s failures. Then, I can use the Havoc Staff and annihilate him with a wave of my hand. You can consider that my apology for what he did to you.”

Adam’s head feels light. His breath comes in bursts. “This isn’t you. You wouldn’t do that.”

“Oh, don’t be so naive—you sound like your father.” He tuts. “I did my best to prepare you differently, but I can’t blame you for his weakness taking hold.”

“*Prepare* me?”

“I’m getting old, Adam. My plan, my dynasty—I cannot carry it alone. When the time comes, someone must succeed me. Someone I can trust.” He holds out his hand. “I need an heir.”

Adam shakes his head. It’s all he can do.

“Join me. Learn from me—all I have yet to teach you. When I have secured our dominion and the universe is at last safe, I will step aside. I was born to conquer, but you? You can lead them. All of them. Adam, this is our birthright!”

Adam’s breathing slows. A strange calm settles over him. “How many?”

Keldor furrows his brow.

“How many people died when you attacked Eternos? Do you know? Do you even care?”

“Do you think I—”

“How many have to die for our ‘birthright'? How many people are you going to *kill* before you realize that *you* are exactly what you’re trying to stop?!”

Keldor raises an eyebrow. His lips curl back in a sneer. “You’re going to fight me?”

Adam takes the sword in both hands and holds it firm.

“Tell me, did it answer your call?”

Adam narrows his eyes.

“I know you tried, Adam.”

“It didn’t work for Teela. Or Duncan and Bow.”

“Did Grayskull answer to *you?”*

“No.”

Keldor nods. “No.”

“If they weren’t worthy then—”

“Worthy?” He scoffs. “What’s worth to do with it? Do you think that sword has a… a measure of worth in its handle? Do you think I command this staff because I’m worthy?” He shakes his head. “That kind of power must be commanded. Controlled. It answers only to those with a clarity of purpose and the surest of wills.”

“Your will?” Adam asks, his voice flat.

“Give me the sword, Adam.”

“Give me my father.”

A chill wind blows. The sun hangs low, cradled by the horizon, and though it shines still, the world seems… faded—as if its luster has gone out.

“No.” Keldor points his finger. “Not him. He won’t turn against me.” His eyes grow wider and his lips pull back. “I won’t—Not him—He wouldn’t—” His breathing grows quicker, frantic, until it hitches and stops. Then, he nods. “Adora agreed.” He nods again, as if trying to convince himself. His lips split in a smile. “Adora agreed, Adam. You trust her, don’t you?”

His face twists in confusion. “She wouldn’t.”

“She saw reason,” Keldor says. “She couldn’t bear the thought of fighting her own family. You wouldn’t fight your own uncle, would you? She wouldn’t. Would you fight your sister?”

Adam blinks. “What?”

“Don’t you see? Haven’t you noticed? Why would your parents be so protective over an attack that *almost* killed you? Why would they never have another child? By Zoar, they tore out her throne and covered the base with a *rug!* What do you think they’ve been trying to hide?”

“That’s insane. You’re—”

“The ‘attack’ on your life was the very event that stole Adora from her home. *Our* home. She is our family. Your sister. And she stands with me.”

Impossible.

It’s impossible.

Isn’t it?

It’s absurd. Keldor is deranged. Everything that’s happened has pushed him past the brink and now he clutches at delusions to hold in place of reason—of the realization that he’s failed.

Yet, as Adam denies it, he hears the truth in Keldor’s words just as clearly as the lie. But it’s a truth that will have to wait.

Keldor is beyond reason.

Catra must be in position.

“Even if that’s true, she’d never agree to this. Not to any of it. Neither do I.”

“You have no idea what you’re giving up.”

“I know *exactly* what I’m giving up.” He breathes out, slowly. Adam fights the feeling that it’s a kind of mourning. “It’s over.”

At his signal, the ground behind Keldor explodes in a burst of gravel. Silently and unseen, Catra lunges forward, reaching for the Havoc Staff.

Keldor could have never hoped to react in time. The most he manages is a startled gasp.

But the staff’s eyes flash and arcs of amethyst energy surge forth. They scorch the ground and simmer in the air. Like tendrils, they wrap around Catra and Melog, dispelling their magic with the screams of them both.

Aghast, Keldor looks between them and Adam. “Deceitful child!” The dark magic grips them tighter, singing their fur and drawing out louder, more anguished cries.

“Let them go!”

But Keldor only watches, holding the Havoc Staff with trembling hands.

Catra couldn’t take the staff.

But Adam can destroy it.

His own hands shake as he raises the Power Sword, yet he takes a running leap and swings the blade in a cleaving arc at the terrible, leering skull.

It never makes contact.

The Havoc Staff flashes again and Catra and Melog are sent flying into a boulder. Their cries cut out with a *crack* before they crumple into the dirt. The energy that held them wraps tight around Adam’s limbs, burning through his clothes and searing his skin as the worst pain he’s ever felt lances through his body.

It hurts.

The magic rips the sword from his hand and forces him to his knees.

It *hurts*.

His vision starts to blur and his scream stops only because there is no air left in his lungs.

It hurts!

Keldor whips the staff and sends Adam sprawling. He tries to breathe and coughs from the pain; he inhales the dust in the air

and coughs again. He tries to stand, but can't even push himself off the ground. His body trembles in wracking spasms.

Keldor steps forward, and his face seems worried, yet as he reaches a hand out, he notices the sword it already holds. Keldor stares at its blade. He turns it over and reads the inscription on its guard. When he looks at Adam again, it is with a cold, empty gaze. "In time, you will share my vision. In time, you will understand. Now witness, Adam, the surety of my will."

Keldor holds the Sword of Power aloft.

Streaks of laser-fire, white-hot and searing, burn through the air, scorching the walls and exploding in jets of plasma when they strike the energy-shields of the prison cells. Duncan takes point in an open cell, firing from behind the wall. Teela, as brave and daring as the day he started training her, leaps between cells, ducking under, over, and through oncoming fire to strike at and destroy the machines that make their way in. She cleaves the head off one with a single strike and uses its body as a shield.

"Be careful!" Duncan shouts. But he knows she can't be—not now. Not when they two alone hold back an army in a desperate bid to buy Bow all the time they can.

"It's one girl!" Kronis shouts from behind the drones. "How hard can it be to hit one girl?!" His next shot misses. "Dammit all!"

More bots stream through the door, far more than they can manage.

“Fall back!” Duncan yells.

They dash back behind the cover of his grenade. It explodes in a shower of smoke and fire. Wild and inaccurate shots tear through the smokescreen—one grazes Duncan’s leg, ripping apart the last of the armor on it. He fights the pain through gritted teeth and shields Teela as they make their way further back.

“Adora!” Bow shouts, far down the hall. He kneels in front of a cell, frantically pressing his tracker-pad. The field dissipates and he throws the tracker-pad to the ground, taking her in his arms. “You’re okay!”

She shouts something through the gag.

“Right! Right, I’ll just…” He fumbles with the latch until it falls loose.

Adora, though disheveled and exhausted, seems without injury. She spits at the gag. Behind her stands Randor, bound by magic, his face locked in agony. “My liege!” Duncan grabs his shoulders and looks for any hint of harm. “Is he alright?” he asks Adora.

“He’s fine.” But looking at him seems to wound her—she turns away with pained eyes. “But none of us will be if we don’t get out of here.”

Bow tries to release the locks around her wrists. “It’s no use, I need the remote.”

“Stand back,” Duncan says. He unslings a pistol from his belt. Adora holds her hands away from her body. With an electric *crack*, the pistol blasts apart the bindings.

Adora tears the smoldering remains from her wrists. “Where are the others?”

“On the ground,” Bow says. “Distracting Keldor while we get you.”

Her eyes go wide and she shakes her head. “It’s not safe.”

“Keldor wouldn’t hurt Adam,” Teela says.

“Maybe not before, but there’s something in the staff,” Adora says. “Something… influencing him. It tried to make him kill me. It tried to make *me* kill *him.* None of them are safe. I have to stop him.”

“We have to disable the ship,” Bow says.

“I’ll do it,” Duncan says. “I carry an arsenal half the size of the palace guards’.”

“Will that be enough?”

“Maybe not. But with his?” Kronis shouts out an incoherent mix of commands and swears as the bots push through the wreckage of the hall. “I can lead him to the engine room if you’ll point the way.”

“The right-hand hall,” Adora says. “It leads straight to it.”

Teela frowns. “That just leaves the army of drones standing in our way.”

Adora nods. “Get behind me.” She holds a hand out and a shining light spills from her palm. In a blinding flash, appears a sword. She holds it above her head and shouts, “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

She-Ra’s emergence is tantamount to a supernova—an experience not just seen, but *witnessed:* an old legend emerging from eons past. Her sword shines bright, and in a dazzling burst, it transforms into a shield, brilliant and golden.

The hall’s wreckage melts in a searing blast. Kronis steps through, a steaming rifle slung under his arm. A dozen machines flank him. He locks eyes with the Princess of Power. “‘Ello, sheila.”

“It’s She-Ra.” With a shout, she kicks off the ground and barrels toward them. Kronis and the machines unleash a hail of lasers that would have cut through the heaviest armor Duncan could

create—it's enough firepower to evaporate a Battle Ram. It breaks against her shield like sunlight on a mirror. It is by an unfortunate miracle that Kronis alone emerges from the carnage, but a swift swing of She-Ra's arm sets things to rights. With a pained grunt, he's sent flying and disappears in a tangled mess of debris and broken machines.

They stop at the split in the hallways. "Bow, Teela," She-Ra says. "More will come. Set up a barricade and protect the king. Duncan, deal with Kronis." She closes her eyes and fades until only Adora remains. "Whoever Keldor's working with wants She-Ra's power." She unhooks a telescoping staff from her belt. "They're gonna have to deal with me." She nods to Bow.

He pulls out his tracker-pad and prepares the teleporter. "Good luck."

"Zoar be with you," Duncan says.

In a flash of green, she disappears.

Kronis pulls himself from the rubble.

Duncan pushes the children back into the containment block. "Quietly now," he says. He thumps his chest, the sharp *clang* of metal-on-metal drawing Kronis' attention.

With the back of his arm, he wipes away the smears of dark grease and oil that stain his face. "Where's blondie?" he snarls.

"Dealing with someone far more important than you."

"I don't have time for some washed-out wanker."

"Oh? Or are you just a coward trying to slink away with his tail between his legs?"

Kronis grinds his jaw and wags a finger. "See, I know you're playing me. Still have to kill you for it." His rifle underslung and held in one hand, Kronis unleashes a blistering rain of fire. Duncan

dodges behind the door. The blasts bite off chunks the metal and ravage the circuitry beneath, clouding the air with sparks and smoke. Kronis draws his pistol and fires it in tandem. Duncan falls back, his return fire barely enough to hold Kronis at bay.

Down the corridor he leads Kronis, hiding behind pipes, computers, and generators, each of them left smoldering ruins by the time they pass. Duncan slips through a door, wider and taller than the rest, that leads to a vast, open room with a spider's web of walkways surrounding a central pylon—ribbed and speckled with outcroppings, levers, and panels—that descends so far Duncan cannot even see the bottom. Had he the chance to speak with the one who designed the room, he'd instead throttle them with his bare hands, for none of the walkways have any safety railings.

The heavy thud of his footfalls echoes in the vast chamber, mingling with the ever-present whir of the gargantuan generator.

"So that was your big plan, eh? Running away?" Kronis shoulders his rifle and smirks. "Who's the coward now?"

Kronis fires.

Duncan jumps.

The lasers miss him by inches and he slams into the lower walkway, dozens of feet below, fumbling a roll that leaves him sprawling halfway over the edge. Every bone in his body aches and he groans through closed teeth. He twists onto his back and fires back, blasting red-hot holes in dark metal. It affords him just enough time to stand. Duncan makes a dash for the pylon, energy shots following too close behind. With the generator at Duncan's back, Kronis aims for his head. Duncan dives and the lasers rip through the pylon. Gouts of plasma spew forth and an alarm blares.

Duncan slings the rifle on his shoulder and starts a slow climb up the pylon's side, just out of Kronis' view, each firing blindly at the

other.

The stink of ozone stains the air and thick, acrid smoke billows around them. Now higher than Kronis, Duncan takes a breath and leaps, landing on a walkway that runs parallel to his. In tandem, they shoulder their rifles, take aim, pull the triggers, and—

Are met with nothing but empty *clicks.*

They lock eyes, draw their sidearms, and run. They shoot at each other, wildly dodging and trying to fire in a way the other can't avoid. They sling grenades, draw secondary, tertiary weapons—back-ups for back-ups and experimental arms never before used. As they run, the walkways draw closer. So close, that one could jump across.

So Kronis does.

He growls, leaps, and latches around Duncan's waist, carrying them both over the edge and crashing into a small platform connected by a single pathway.

They groan and roll apart, each struggling to stand—to even breathe under the exertion and toxic air.

Kronis throws a long-barreled revolver aside and, from his boot, draws a jagged knife the length of his forearm. Duncan unhooks an electrified mace from his belt and fires the weapon to life. Sweat drips down his brow. Each breath is pained, the cold air stinging his burning chest. He tastes blood in the back of his throat.

"Didn't think you had this much fight in you." Kronis drags his tongue across the blade. "Let's see what's left."

They lunge.

Steel beats upon steel in a furious flurry of sparks and blood. Each blow Kronis lands gouges Duncan's armor and threatens to pull him over the ledge. What hits Duncan makes—those few not

ducked under and dodged—Kronis simply ignores. The electro-mace hits like a Bashasaurus and splits and scorches his skin. Welts grow and blood spurts, but Kronis fights on like a berserker. His strikes are wild. Uncoordinated. Deadly in their unpredictability. It is a method of fighting that cost Duncan's troops their lives.

Alarms blare and emergency lights strobe, flashing red and casting harsh shadows. The chamber burns around them. The damage dealt has been catastrophic and explosions ring out, throwing the mangled wrecks of vital machines and molten metal onto and through the walkways, which buckle and crash, falling into the depths below.

Still, they fight on.

With a backhand strike, Kronis stabs his knife into the head of the mace and wrenches it from Duncan's grip. The weapon skitters across the platform and slides over the edge.

Above them, one of the walkways teeters, its supports in ruins.

Kronis drives his knife toward Duncan's throat—he catches the blade just as the tip pierces his skin and draws a drop of blood. Kronis puts his other hand against the base of the knife and starts to push. "Gonna cut your arms off, Duncy. Gonna mount them on my walls." His lip is split and blood pours from it. He licks it clean. "I'm gonna drink your blood!"

Duncan takes a step back, failing against Kronis' strength. He takes another, and Kronis is all-too-eager to follow.

"We walked into your trap," Duncan says, strained. "You've walked into mine."

"Eh?"

"Good day, mate." With his chin, Duncan presses a button on his wrist, and from his gauntlet, a small barrel flicks up and fires a thin, keening laser that cuts through the walkway above. It falls

with a scream and crashes into the platform behind Kronis. They both stumble as it shakes loose. Duncan stumbles back onto the stable walkway, holding tight to the platform's edge, while Kronis, as if recognizing the inevitability of his doom, lunges forward as the platform falls and plunges his knife into Duncan's leg. It cuts into his flesh and lodges in the bone. Duncan cries out, a breathless scream as his vision goes white and a terrible pain shoots through his body.

Kronis hangs from the handle. His weight pulls the blade deeper into his knee.

Duncan's grip starts to slip.

"This is how it has to be, Duncy! This is the only way it could end!"

Duncan grits his teeth and wills away the pain.

He pulls his other leg back.

"This is for the children—the pain you've caused them!" He kicks Kronis' face, splitting his nose. "This is for those I commanded, the ones you killed!" He stomps again, reducing it to a ruined stump. "And this… This is to shut you up!" Duncan drives his boot into Kronis' jaw. It cracks and splinters—a spray of blood and shattered teeth shoots past his lips and his grip falters for a fraction of a second. It is a moment too long, and Kronis falls, screaming—down, down into that fathomless darkness.

Duncan breathes a shuddering sigh. He pulls himself onto the walkway and lays there. He watches with a detached interest as the world around him erupts in a firestorm. Distantly, part of him thinks of several ways to improve upon the Horde's engineering, not the least of which being the very basics of safety regulations. More urgently, he knows the children still need his help, and so he rolls onto his good leg, and—through gritted teeth and a fresh well of tears—pulls the knife from his knee, cauterizes the wound

with his wrist-laser, then starts the slow, limping walk back to the others as the engine room burns behind him.

It takes less than a second for Adora to orient herself after teleporting. In only a few more, she takes in the entirety of the scene before her.

Of Catra and Melog, she can see nothing.

Adam lies stricken in the dirt, faint smoke rising from his body.

Keldor has the staff in hand, and the Sword of Power raised.

The primary threat has been identified. Keldor cannot be allowed to wield the sword. In the instants that follow, her body takes over, acting on instincts drilled into it so many years before.

From stillness to action in a heart's beat, she kicks into a sprint. She covers the hundreds of feet between them in a matter of moments. Words pass Keldor's lips, but Adora does not hear them. A kind of calm settles over her mind. Time seems to slow.

Keldor turns his head, only just, and his eyes widen in shock.

Adora swings her staff.

She strikes his hand and with a *crack,* the skin splits, and the sword goes flying. Keldor cries out and stumbles back. He levels the staff at her, but she bats it aside. Streams of energy spray in wild arcs, striking against the earth and kicking up shards of scorched rock. Adora crouches on one leg and swipes Keldor's out

from under him. In the same motion, she rises up and spin-kicks Keldor before he even hits the ground.

Adam shifts and pushes himself onto his elbows.

He’s alive. Confirming that is the most she can do before Keldor is subdued.

The Power Sword is dozens of feet away. All that remains is the Havoc Staff.

Already, Keldor stands. He leans against the staff, his face locked in a scowl.

Adora matches his look, lowers her stance, and readies herself for a final lunge.

“I tried to be reasonable.” He slams the staff against the earth. It weeps dark tears, as thick as oil, and its jaw falls loose, spilling an inky, billowing smoke. It flows like tendrils and the second Adora moves it's as if the sun itself were extinguished. Darkness, impenetrable, surrounds her. The world deafens until all she hears is her own breath and the beating of her heart.

In the shadows, something moves.

Adora spins on her heel. She narrows her eyes and levels her staff.

Nothing.

She feels it behind her.

She twists about, and nothing is there.

It’s just another trick, she thinks. But the icy chill in the air and the hoarfrost that gathers on her skin feel all too real.

The darkness closes in like a suffocating tide and despite herself, her heart quickens, its pace the frantic hoof-beat of a racing

horse.

To her left, it moves.

She turns to face it, and it is behind her.

Then, her right.

Behind her again.

It's in front of her, staring at her, watching from just beyond the void, and though she cannot see it, she feels its gaze—she feels it leering with empty eyes and a rictus grin, creeping closer, ever closer, such that the ice on her body seeps within and her limbs do not obey because they *cannot*—she's frozen, helpless against the dark. From the shadows, a thin hand of bone creeps toward her and—

"Adora," Catra sputters out. Like the coming of the dawn, her voice shines against the night.

It's nothing but a flicker of hope snuffed out the second Adora sees her.

Catra sits on her knees. Her eyes are dim, and her head droops low. She holds her neck.

"No!" Adora rushes down to take Catra in her arms. Blood pools from her fingers. Nothing Adora does can stop the bleeding. Catra coughs, a wet, gagging sound, and more spills from her lips.

She clutches at Adora like a lifeline, but her hands are weak. Her eyes flutter and she tries to speak, but nothing comes except quiet gasps.

"I'm not losing, you!" Adora holds her close. "Not again!"

The night grows dark and all light fades.

There is no hope to be found in a starless sky.

So she will be their sun.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” Like a clarion call her voice rings out and the brilliant light of She-Ra burns against the night.

The tendrils of smoke recede like demons stricken by the heaven’s fire. They fade with an anguished scream.

Catra fades with them.

She-Ra clutches at nothingness and her stomach drops like a stone as realization turns to dread.

The scream turns to a laugh.

She-Ra sits on her knees, face-to-face with the ram-skull head of the Havoc Staff. Its eyes flash a sickly green and from its maw, a phantom flame spews forth.

It surrounds and envelopes her, burning with cold anguish that sears her very soul. It slips through her skin, deep into her flesh, pulling her apart at every level of her being.

It’s agony.

The very definition of pain.

She starts to scream.

“We can’t keep this up!” Teela shouts. Lasers whiz past her head and shear chunks off the makeshift barricade.

“We have to buy him more time!” Bow slings arrow after arrow, his arm a blur, striking the machines down. Those he can’t, she destroys.

And still, they come. They are, Teela thinks with a grim sense of humor, living up to their name.

“Get back!” He fires another, its tip round, onto the ground. Three machines march past, and three are destroyed in a raging blaze.

Teela leaps next to Bow. They fall back to their final position, inside the cell with King Randor. Bow pulls up his tracker-pad.

“The engine’s offline and I’ve got the clones warped out.”

“Then teleport *us* out.” An explosion, distant but booming, rocks the ship. “I think he’s done his job.”

“I can’t. The clones are on a database—the ship tracks them so I can, too. I need Duncan’s exact location and I can’t access the teleporter from outside the ship. We have to wait for him to get back.”

“How’s he supposed to get through all *that?”*

For the first time, Bow’s face creases with worry. He tries to smile, then nocks another arrow and keeps fighting.

Darkness surrounds him. Darkness, and distant screams. His limbs tremble and shake. It takes all he has to push himself to his knees.

That was Adora, he thinks.

Adora came to save them.

Where is she?

Someone cries out and Adam tries to look, to find them, but there is nothing but a black fog darker than the deepest night, and the voice—no, *voices*—come from everywhere.

"It doesn't have to be like this!" It is Keldor's voice, strained, and echoing as if they're lost in a cavern deep below the earth. "Join me! It's not too late!"

Adora screams.

"Adora!" Adam tries to shout, but his voice is weak. Hoarse. He can hardly move his lips.

Another wracking spasm overwhelms him and he doubles over, fighting the urge to vomit.

Darkness surrounds him, yet carried by a faint wind, he hears another voice, and in the distance, he sees a light. It is a faint, flickering thing, like a star about to sputter out. But when his eyes fall upon it it is all he can see, and so through the pain in his body and the terror of the night, he drags himself forward, ever forward, toward that distant light.

A sword.

A brilliant sword, unblemished and shining against the dark.

Its handle is wrapped in leather and words, inscribed in gold, cover the guard. He sees his reflection on the blade.

From the smoke, a shadow emerges, darker and more terrible than the void. Wreathed in the night and bound by iron chains, a thin hand of bone caresses Adam's chin. Its touch is cold as winter

and as biting as a blade. A skull looms over him, leering with eyes that smolder like embers.

“Scareglow,” Adam says, not even a whisper.

“It pleases me to know the heirs of Grayskull remember my name.” His voice is deep and pervades Adam’s being, surrounding him like a tomb, yet it fades like a dying gasp. “You think to draw the sword of your ancestor?” He laughs, a wretched sound, and says, “Look.”

In the shadows, faces emerge. The faces of those he loves. Duncan, Cringer, Teela, and Bow. His friends. Father, Mother, Keldor… Adora. His family.

They look on him with pity. Disdain. They mock him and jeer at his failure. They point and laugh and figures step forth with blades of cold steel, and tendrils of smoke slide across his body and close around his throat then…

The blades never fall.

The laughter stops

The smoke recedes.

“What?” Scareglow asks.

With tired eyes, Adam turns to him. “My greatest fear, is that it?” His thoughts are filled with nothing but worry for the same faces that mocked him—the one who sits on a cold throne and weeps for her lost family. The one betrayed by his own brother. The one stolen from her home. The ones who risk their lives. Even the one who started this all. They stand now on the precipice of doom as he can do nothing but watch. Nothing but wait as he is helpless to help them. Adam shakes his head. “I’m already living it.”

The air grows cold. "Is that defiance in your eyes or despair?" The void deepens and Scareglow, from all around, says, “It matters not. If you will not fear me, then they will!”

Something hits his back. There's pressure in his stomach. A dull ache. Strangest of all is the heat. Everything else is so cold. But his stomach feels so warm.

He pads at it, that sticky heat, and his fingers find something cold.

Something metal.

He looks down.

Half the head of a halberd. It's coming out of his stomach.

It makes sense, he thinks as his vision starts to fade. The old legends said that Scareglow carries a halberd. With a squelching *pop* and the scrape of metal-on-bone, Scareglow pulls it free. A fresh well of blood spurts and Adam pads at his stomach.

"Keldor!" Scareglow shouts. The smoke pulls back and before them, She-Ra lies prone as Keldor holds the Havoc Staff above her. A gout of green fire spews past its fangs and wraps around her as the shining, golden magic of Etheria is drawn into its maw.

Keldor's face, already pained, turns. When he sees Adam, he falls into despair.

"Her power!" Scareglow says. "Grant to me She-Ra's power and I can save the boy!"

"Don't," Adam tries to say. All that passes his lips is a stream of blood.

Keldor wrenches his eyes shut and the staff's jaw opens wider and all Adam hears is She-Ra's pain.

It had to end this way, he thinks. His arms go slack. His head droops low. The sword, so close before, seems as far from him now as the edge of the creation. How else could it have gone?

There's a whisper on the wind, that voice again.

"This story is not over yet."

Sound dulls into silence.

The world around him slows to a stop.

A light, but dim, shines before him.

"Have you journeyed so far to give up now?"

"Eldress," he says, without even the strength to look at her.

She cups his cheek. Hers is a phantom touch, yet Adam leans into its warmth. "Time grows short, Adam. I cannot hold this moment forever."

He knows what she wants him to do. "I can't."

"There was truth in Keldor's words. The sword will only answer to those who have the will to call on its power. You have that will, Adam—else you would not have come so far."

"It didn't work before."

"Because you were afraid it wouldn't."

But it doesn't matter now, does it? Whether he thinks the Power will answer to him, or if he wants the sword at all. Though, still, he doesn't. Never again will he want the sword and the legacy it carries, nor the power it brings.

He *needs* it.

For his friends.

For his family.

For everyone who's risked their lives and for the universe that has languished for a millennium.

He needs the sword because now, they need it too.

They need someone who can wield it.

Not a warrior.

Not a hero.

Eldress takes his chin and looks into his eyes. She smiles, and together they say, “A champion.”

She fades.

The night returns and She-Ra writhes in agony. Scareglow watches in rapture and Keldor’s face hardens in cruel determination. The Horde ship buckles and bursts of fire rock its hull.

Prince Adam of the House Grayskull takes the Sword of Power. With the last strength of his dying body, he holds it aloft. Stars, bright and beautiful, glint along its blade. He sees his face. He knows his resolve.

He’ll save them.

All of them.

With a voice greater than his own, he shouts, “By the Power of Grayskull!”

With the strike of lightning and the booming crack of thunder, power, unlimited, surges through him. He rises from the blackened earth and his body transforms. He is taller. Stronger. Mightier in every regard. In a dazzling flash his smoldering garb is replaced by a suit of black adorned with silver that shines like the stars. Heavy vambraces guard his arms and his hair falls about his shoulders, gleaming like liquid fire. Where he steps, the earth trembles, and where he looks, he banishes the night, for his eyes glow with all the might of Eternia—Scareglow wails, drawn back into the shadows by his chains of iron.

“I have the Power!”

"It didn't have to be this way!" Keldor strains against the raw magic unleashed. "Why did you make me do this?"

She-Ra pushes herself onto her elbows, struggling even as her very soul is ripped from her body. Tears fall and so does she.

A few moments more.

She need only suffer a few moments more.

Then her power will belong to the staff, and he can save Adam.

He has to save—

Lightning rips through the air and strikes the earth with thundering force. The impact throws Keldor back. The link between She-Ra and the staff is shattered.

"No!" he shouts, stumbling to his feet.

Before them is a great cloud of smoke above smoldering earth. Within is the silhouette of a man, shining like the sun. But it is no mere man, Keldor realizes as the figure strides forth, the smoke forced away by his mere presence—this is a titan, wrought of mortal flesh and burning with the strength of gods.

"Grayskull…!" Keldor gasps, his voice trembling with awe.

She-Ra lifts her head. She speaks, weary, yet aflame with desperate hope. "Adam?"

The titan’s voice is booming—radiant and clear. “If it’s power you want, then why not try the most powerful man in the universe?”

Chapter End Notes

UP NEXT: HE-MAN

The Power of Grayskull

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow's skin is slick with sweat and tiredness weighs on him, heavier than iron. The Horde bot has his bow in both of its cold, metallic hands, pressing him against the wall and the weapon into his throat. He kicks at it, the hollow *thuds* lost in the din of battle. He tries to push back. He tries to fight it. He can't even breathe.

The tail-end of Teela's staff juts through its face in a shower of sparks that scorch his skin. She twists and wrenches the thing's head off its shoulders.

Bow falls forward. He clutches his throat, bruised and swollen. She offers him a hand. He tries to thank her, but a green glow shines like a halo behind her head.

"Teela—!" he coughs out.

It should have been too late.

Instead of firing, the bot freezes. Its entire body locks up, the weapon powers down, and it turns. It, and all the others, march away, back down the hall and out of sight.

Teela pulls him to his feet. They watch with unbelieving eyes as the cell block burns, the wreckage of machines strewn across the floor and their own sweat and blood on the walls.

King Randor stands just behind them.

"They're leaving," Teela says, her voice quiet.

Despite himself and the ache that pervades his body, Bow smiles. He quells the relief that washes over him; there's works still to be done. "So are we." He slings his bow over his shoulder. Only two

arrows remain in his quiver: the bolas arrow and the one that fires another, slightly smaller arrow mid-flight. He decides to come up with a better name for it later. "We need to find Duncan and we can't waste time coming back here." Something deep in the ship shudders and another booming *crack* echoes through the halls. "We'll have to see if we can get the king to follow us."

Teela sweeps Randor's legs out from under him, catches him as he falls, and in the same motion, swings him over her shoulders, carrying him like a new-born calf. His expression never changes.

"That works too."

When waiting for rescue, remain where you are; it's a critical rule that was taught to every member of the Rebellion. Moving from your last known location only makes it harder for responders to find you. Bow wishes they could wait. He wishes they could stay in the cell block and watch the door until Duncan returns, but time is a precious commodity they have too little of, and, though he feels nothing but dread at the thought, and it may be he and Teela who need to do the rescuing.

They make slow progress, slipping through the ruined halls and past the marching machines. They try to avoid them at first; with Teela carrying Randor and Bow having so little left in him, direct confrontation seems like suicide. But when they slip up and the Horde bots see them, the bots turn away and keep marching.

"Something's got their attention," Teela says.

"Some*one."*

"Is it egotistical to think they're just scared of me?" Duncan asks.

"Father!"

"You're hurt," Bow says. A deep gash runs through his knee and he limps forward, using a piece of scrap, then Teela's shoulder, to hold himself up.

Duncan checks the king's vitals as he speaks. “Not as badly as our gun-toting friend. I trust we’ll be going now?”

Already, Bow plugs the coordinates into his tracker-pad.

As long as Adora has handled Keldor—there is no doubt in Bow’s mind that she has—then all they have to do now is teleport out, find the others, and run like hell.

“Oi!” At the end of the halls, through dark smoke and back-lit by a roaring blaze, Kronis limps forth. “I ain’ finished wiff you ye’.” He holds the broken wreck of his jaw and speaks through dribbling blood and shattered teeth.

Duncan snarls. “You fell.”

“Wasn’ even tha’ far. Jus’ dark.”

“Get us out of here,” Duncan whispers to Bow. “Let the ship take care of him.”

Bow inputs the commands and Kronis advances.

The tracker-pad dings.

Eleven percent.

Kronis starts to run.

Twenty-four percent.

He’s almost halfway to them.

Thirty-seven percent.

It’s not fast enough.

Bow tosses the tracker-pad to Teela and nocks his bolas arrow. He lets it fly and it bursts apart in the air, wrapping around Kronis’ legs and sending him tumbling to the ground. He grunts, flexes, and the ropes tear apart.

“Update, please!”

“Sixty-eight percent!”

Kronis drags himself to his feet, not even a dozen feet away. Bow draws the last arrow in his quiver. He let’s out a calm, slow breath and takes aim. When the last air leaves his lungs, time slows to a crawl, and the snarling visage of the blue-skinned mercenary seems as still as a painting, he lets his fingers loose and the arrow fly.

Kronis catches it right out of the air.

“Ha! Next ‘ime, bring a gu–ough!” The head of the arrow explodes, firing another, smaller arrow directly into Kronis’ eye. He yowls and staggers back but anger overtakes his pain and he lunges at Bow.

A shimmering, green glow surrounds them.

Teela drop-kicks his leg, snapping it at the knee. They both fall. As Kronis writhes, Teela rolls back into the ring—when he tries to grab her, she wraps her legs around his arm. The glow becomes a wall of energy, encompassing them all and Kronis’ arm with them. He tries to wrest it free, but Teela locks around his limb and holds it firm.

His face falls flat. “Crikey.”

They disappear in a flash.

Like fire, magic radiates off him in a shining aura. Adam follows it the length of his arm and the sword's blade—though it fades, he feels the power within grow stronger. He clenches his fists. Within them, he knows, there is the strength to move mountains.

"I always knew," Keldor says. "I always saw what no one else did. Adam, you are Grayskull's heir, truly. Now, give me the sword and —"

"Keldor." His voice is deep, surprising even himself, and it echoes in the valley. "Lay down the staff."

Keldor narrows his eyes.

Adam stands tall.

He sneers. "Take it from me, *hero."* Keldor swings it above his head. Arcs of energy hurl toward Adam. He blocks them with the sword—it rings and flashes as the dark magic sparks along its blade. With a whip-crack flick of his wrist, he forces it aside. It explodes against the ground, showering them with smoking earth.

Adam speaks as he walks forward. "It's over. You've lost."

"My entire life has been nothing but defeat. Do you think I'll give up now?" He levels the ram-skull at Adam's chest. The jaw falls open and fire spews forth.

Adam crouches low and in the seconds before the raging inferno would have devoured him, he leaps—high, high into the air, higher even than he thought he could go. Fighting a wave of vertigo, he clenches tight his fist and falls. He does not land—it is a meteor strike and his fist is the force of the heavens. The earth splinters and cracks—jets of steam and clouds of dust launch into the air. Keldor coughs, sputters, and stumbles. The heat is extreme, even for Adam's new body, and the sulfur stench, overwhelming.

Amidst the smoke and steam, they do battle. Adam fights with a strength and speed he's never known against dark powers birthed in nightmares. He moves too fast—he strikes too hard. A single,

errant blow could mean Keldor's death, and both seem to know it. Adam brings the sword down against the staff but a crackling shield of fell magic blocks his strike. Keldor strains against him.

"You have power, boy. But you don't know how to *use it!"* He twists the sword aside and simmering beams shoot from the staff's eyes into Adam's face.

It scalds like boiling water and he recoils with a shout. He can see nothing, and then there is only agony.

Cold fire licks at his body and his very soul burns with it.

"Surrender the sword or I will take it from you!"

"Take *this!"* Adam slams his boot. A jagged crack splits the ground beneath Keldor's feet. He gasps and stumbles, the sickly fire failing with his footing.

Adam lunges, reaching for the staff, but its eyes flash and an unseen force pushes him aside. He twists on his heel and surges forward. Keldor grimaces, then whips it up—in a purplish haze, reality itself seems to tear open and Adam falls through. In a fraction of an instant its as if his entire being is pulled apart and put back together.

"Huh?" He stands *behind* Keldor, who turns, seemingly as surprised as he.

Adam tries to swat the staff out of his hands—another rift appears and he strikes his own head.

Adam raises the sword and brings it down on the staff's skull. Reality breaks but Adam stops the blade short—he sweeps Keldor's legs out from under him. He gasps, but before he even hits the ground, a purple rift envelopes him, and then he stands dozens of feet away.

Keldor brushes the hair out of his eyes. "It seems we both have much to learn about our new powers. What say we put yours to a

little test?” Keldor pounds the staff into the ground.

The Horde ship blares.

In the moments following, filled with nothing but echoing silence, bright bursts of green flash around Keldor. Each one dissipates into a dozen Horde bots, until, in only seconds, hundreds of them surround him. From the sides of the ship, hundreds more of its flying drones pour out like a locust swarm. They cloud the dark skies with lights of green, and more machines, entire *ships,* take flight and train their weapons on him. From the bottom of the Horde ship, pods larger than houses fall. They strike the earth with booming crashes and from behind clouds of dust, great tripodal machines rise, blaring out deep trumpet calls.

Adam steps back. He holds the sword tighter—closer to his body.

“It breaks my heart that you, of all people, should need a history lesson.” Keldor waves the staff and dark magic twists the earth, pulling up a rise that stands above the mass of machines. He walks atop it as he speaks. “Grayskull stood alone against the Horde. It was a foe not even he could best. What hope do you have?”

Adam quells the doubt in his heart. He steps forward, but another voice says, “Grayskull wasn’t alone.” She-Ra, as resplendent as the sun, stands beside him. “Neither is he.”

Keldor scowls. “She-Ra could not save him before.”

Adam shakes his head. “That wasn’t Adora.”

“Let us see what difference it makes.” He levels the staff and the machines advance.

Adam and She-Ra nod to the other, hold their swords up, and charge.

Scores of machines are cut down. Dozens more fall under the weight of their fists and the crush of their heels. They fight with

blinding speed—what laser fire hits them is blocked by magical blades and armor, blasting into nothingness or reflected back into the mechanical swarm.

One of the tripods marches forth. In a single blow, Adam cleaves its legs in twain. As it falls, She-Ra leaps and punches the body with such force that it flies into a ship, detonating against its hull and leaving both as a fireball that bursts apart in the sea of metal below.

She-Ra lands beside him. "So, what do I call you?"

He crushes the head of a bot beneath his fist. "What do you mean?"

"Well, 'For the Honor of Grayskull,' Adora becomes She-Ra." She points her sword and downs a trio of drones with a blast of energy. "So, 'By the Power of Grayskull,' Adam becomes…?"

His first thought is that He-Ra would be too derivative. His second is that She-Ra has no actual etymological connection to modern pronouns—every scholar Adam studied recorded it as an ancient Etherian word that roughly translates to Guardian.

She-Ra is a guardian.

Adam must be what Grayskull was.

And so he thinks back to the old texts he studied in what feels like a lifetime ago: the original copies, still transcribed in Old Eternian, and the word they used for Champion.

"Call me He-Man."

She-Ra smiles. "Let's show these bots what She-Ra and He-Man are made of."

They take point beside each other and lower their stances. The Horde rallies, a swell of mechanical monstrosities readies itself against them.

Adam mumbles, “He-Man and She-Ra.”

She raises an eyebrow.

He shrugs. “It sounds better.”

“Whoever breaks more bots gets to put their name first.”

“I hope you’re not a sore loser.”

“Try and keep up.”

The Horde falls on them as a flood, and it breaks upon them as waves break upon stone. Heirs of Grayskull both, side-by-side they stand and shoulder-to-shoulder they fight. Of the machines on which their swords fall, naught but ruin remains. The ringing clash of their blades is unto a song—the machines are ink, and the ground beneath them is a canvas on which they paint a tapestry of destruction. For the first time in more than a thousand years, She-Ra and He-Man stand together against the Evil Horde.

One of the ships trains its gun on Adam. He crouches low, then turns to She-Ra and says, “Watch this.”

“I don’t think that’s a good idea.”

He leaps, but the weapon is already firing.

A searing blast of energy strikes him in the chest. It knocks the wind from his lungs and sends him sailing hundreds of feet through the air. He lands like a boulder in water.

Adam coughs, pulls himself from the crater, and wipes the dirt off his aching body.

Catra watches, obviously unimpressed.

“Wasn’t supposed to go like that,” he says.

“I’d be worried if it was.”

His eyes widen. “Wait, Catra! You’re okay?”

She scratches Melog’s chin. “She-Ra fixed us up before saving you.”

“She didn’t *save* me, it was more of a…” Catra stares at him, her face flat. “So you guys are good?”

“We’re not dead.”

“And Cringer is…?”

“Hiding.”

The tiger pops the top of his head out from behind a boulder.

“Hey buddy.”

He slinks back down.

“So are you guys gonna wait here with him or…?”

They watch as She-Ra annihilates a squad of bots with her bare hands. Dozens more swarm around her and scores of drones fire down.

“I think I’m gonna sit this one out,” Catra says.

Melog chirps.

Adam nods. “That’s fair. I’m just gonna…” He points to the battle.

“Probably a good idea.”

He nods. “Oh! Cringer, c’mere buddy!”

The tiger pokes his head back out.

“I have an idea,” Adam says, waving him forward. “Oh, don’t be such a scaredy-cat; get out here.” With slow, tentative steps,

flinching each time a distant *boom* fills the air, Cringer slinks forward. Adam points the Sword of Power. “Just stand still.”

The ship fires again. The laser explodes against Adora’s shield—she slides back and slams her fist into the ground. The Horde bots fire on her. Her shield protects against them, but the sheer volume of their salvo weighs down, and she cannot stand. The ship rises above her. Its cannon trains on her and with a keening whine, powers up.

A blur of red and green strikes the vessel and it falls in flames. Its wreckage crushes the bots before her, and just ahead lands He-Man, riding atop a tiger the size of a Wind Raider, armored in jagged red plate.

Several bots pull themselves from the burning hulk. The tiger bellows a deafening roar that warps the air itself. The bots rupture and burst, falling lifeless to the ground.

He-Man pats his head. “Nice work, buddy.”

The tiger growls.

She-Ra pats his side. “Cringer, look at you!”

His eyes glow a harsh yellow, filled with a predator’s cunning. “Not Cringer,” he says in a deep baritone that Adora can feel her in chest. *“Battle Cat.”*

He-Man gasps. “You can talk?”

Battle Cat growls again. “I can *fight.”*

They leap back into action, He-Man’s words carried on the wind, “Try and keep up!”

With a smirk, Adora follows.

With Battle Cat on their side, the storm of sword and claw carves through what remains of the Horde.

Though battered and breathless, they three stand against one.

The only one who can match them.

Atop a throne of broken machines, Keldor sits, the Havoc Staff in hand. He watches their approach with a tired scowl.

He-Man slides off Battle Cat and stands next to Adora. Battle Cat stalks behind them with a constant, low growl.

Keldor looks between them and the ruin they have wrought, then nods.

He-Man holds up his hand. “Let the fighting end here, Keldor. Please.”

“Do you really think it’s done?”

“There’s nothing left to fight for,” Adora says. “Your army is gone.”

“You think I need this army? Ah, you look on me with confusion, but there’s so much that you do not know. So much that I can still do. Your power has afforded me this, She-Ra.” Keldor stands. He slams the staff against the body of a drone and the sound that rings out is like the tolling of a great bell. Darkness spills from the staff’s maw and Scareglow, bound in chains with his halberd of dark iron, crawls from the void and clings to Keldor like a twisted shadow. “Now witness Lord Keldor, true heir of Grayskull, and the might of his Havoc Staff!”

Keldor calls down his fell sorceries—bolts of amethyst thunder, darkling flames, and twisted earth, as Scareglow, a spectral horror, slashes from the void.

Three stars shine against the night. So bright are they that the shadows cannot keep them apart, and the warriors of eternity do not falter. But the staff is a black hole, and it feeds on their light. Though they may strike at Scareglow, just as quickly does he disappear, and a mote of their power with him. Every touch of Keldor's wretched magic drains from them their strength and will. They fight on, but the earth itself clings to them like a drowning muck and Keldor is as elusive as the shadows he binds—when at last they reach him, he is already gone, disappeared in a purple haze only to manifest again, laughing, a hundred feet away.

Adora breathes heavy and hard. Her legs tremble and she struggles to keep her eyes open. He-Man staggers forward and Battle Cat limps beside him.

"Can you see, now? She-Ra—that sword. It was only ever a battery." A lance of green lightning splits the sky behind him. "*This* is the power I sought!"

"We can't beat him," He-Man says. "Not like this."

Adora grimaces as her mind works through the tired pain for anything she might have missed, anything to form a plan. And then, a memory flashes in her mind—the detail that will ensure their success. Their survival. "Do you remember what Eldress said about the staff?"

"If he wants power…"

"Let's give it to him."

She-Ra and He-Man stare Keldor in the eyes. He levels the staff and its jaw falls open. A swirling vortex broils within and licks of seething fire spill across its teeth.

They point their swords.

“For the Honor—!”

“By the Power—!”

Battle Cat roars.

Shining energy dances across their blades and they shout, *“Of Grayskull!”*

A supernova of magic, raw and unchained, lances forth. With a comet-strike *crack* that rips through the air and shakes the earth, it collides with the Havoc Staff. Its raging power is enough to shatter mountains, yet the swirling vortex in the staff’s maw devours it as a whirlpool drinks the sea. Its eyes flash with sparking fire and Scareglow cackles with cruel delight. Keldor’s smile is manic.

And then he frowns. The staff starts to shake. The fire in its eyes, first an inferno, starts to sputter and pop like an engine about to burst. Its jaw hinges wider. The spectral maw yet hungers, but it cannot feast upon the sheer power exuded anymore than a mortal can take in all of eternity.

Keldor steps back.

She-Ra and He-Man step forward.

It starts like a whine—a sharp, keening sound that grows louder and louder as if the staff itself were in pain. The light is blinding and its heat, scorching. Keldor cries out. His hand smokes and burns, and though he tries to pull away his grip is locked tight around the staff.

The whine turns to a scream. The light, a blistering fire. She-Ra strains and when it seems they have nothing left to give, all sound is silenced by a deafening *crack* and the rush of air like a choked gasp.

There’s a ringing in her ears.

Coarse gravel digs into her knees, and it's only then that she notices she's on them.

She forces her eyes open. Blinding white stains her vision, fading in patches as sight slowly returns.

A hand, strong yet gentle, rests on her shoulder. "Think you can stand?" He-Man asks. She takes it and lets him pull her up.

A cool wind carries the sulfur stench of the Dark Continent, stained now with the ozone smell of raw magic.

She checks herself over. Despite the leaden-weight exhaustion, She-Ra is unharmed.

"I've had worse," He-Man says when she checks him.

"And what about him?"

Keldor sits on his knees. His hair is disheveled and his clothes are torn. His eyes are wide. Vacant. He cradles his left hand in his lap —now nothing but a curled mass of blackened bone.

The Havoc Staff lays before Keldor. His empty eyes fall upon it.

"I don't think so." Catra skulks out from behind the wreck of a tripod and snatches the staff. She holds it close, eyeing Keldor as she makes her way beside Adora.

He-Man watches Keldor with an expression she can't place. He sheathes his sword and holds out a hand, but a burst of green energy appears between them.

Bow, Teela, and Man-At-Arms stand with King Randor, a dismembered blue arm at their feet.

"You're okay!" Adora says.

"He isn't." Teela kicks the arm away.

“You’ll have to count me with him,” Man-At-Arms says. A deep gash scars his knee and his face is bloodied and bruised.

Adora channels what magic she can into her hand and holds it out.

“There’s no time,” he says. “The ship is going to crash.”

“Right here,” Bow says. “On top of us.”

“Why didn’t you teleport away?” He-Man asks.

“We wanted to make sure you guys were—” Bow stops himself. His eyebrows almost reach his hairline and he looks over He-Man, slack-jawed.

“Adam?!” Teela stomps forward. She pats his torso as if checking to see that he’s real then measures the difference in height between them. She doesn’t even clear his chest.

“We’re going with He-Man, actually. It’s because—”

“You’re *taller* than me!”

“I used to be.”

“When we were—! *Cringer?”*

“Battle Cat,” he grumbles.

“This is all very exciting,” Man-At-Arms says, “but I feel the need to remind you all—” A burst of fire rocks the ship and a massive shard of its hull falls, embedding in the earth. “That is happening.”

The Wind Raider is nowhere to be seen. There’s only one way out.

“Battle Cat,” He-Man says; he takes Randor by the shoulders and sets him on his saddle. “Duncan.” He takes him and does the same.

Another *boom* echoes from the ship as the hull splits and chunks of it fall like rain.

"Adam," a rasping voice says.

He-Man's face falls. He turns to Keldor.

"You understand, don't you? You know I was doing the right thing." His face warps with some kind of madness and despair. "It was the right thing, wasn't it? Why didn't you help me?"

"Stop," He-Man says, his voice strained.

“It was mine." Keldor holds the charred ruin of his hand toward the raging sky. “My responsibility. My destiny. My power!” Flickers of dark fire ignite along the blackened bone and he stretches his hand out. The Havoc Staff tears itself from Catra’s grasp and Keldor takes it with a growl. He struggles to his feet and points the ram-skull at them. Its jaw falls open and fell power blazes in its eyes.

And then it turns.

“Huh?” A jet of fire spews from its maw and spills across his face. Keldor screams. Raw and agonizing, his voice cracks and fails as his flesh bubbles and melts under the cold heat of the spectral fire.

“Uncle!” He-Man rushes forward, but molten wreckage falls between them. He tries to push it aside, but more comes, smashing and bursting apart.

“He-Man!” Adora shouts. She pulls his shoulder. “We have to leave!”

His face is twisted with distraught, but when he sees the others, and as the entire ship starts to plummet, falling toward them like a comet, he steels himself, and with a final look back—as Keldor’s cries are drowned by the raging inferno—they start to run.

“Catra!” Adora says. Catra and Melog leap, each latching onto one of her shoulders.

Without breaking stride, He-Man takes Teela and Bow in his arms.

Battle Cat snarls and rushes beside them.

They run. Fast—faster than any mortal, with preternatural speed they race across the barren, wasted land as Keldor’s arrogance burns behind them. Claws dig into her skin and the air whips past her face. No matter how far they go, the heat only seems to grow and the destruction of the Horde ship sounds out like artillery fire. She steals a glance over her shoulder.

Nothing but a glowing mass of twisted metal, the ship finally strikes Eternia. Behind the wall of earth it throws around it, there is a silent pin-prick flash of light that balloons out and explodes.

The reactor-core, a part of her passively thinks. It’s gone into meltdown.

They can’t outrun *that.*

“Everyone, behind me, now!” They skid to a stop. She summons her shield and into it, she pours the last of her strength and all of her will. It grows, a shining wall of golden magic. Adora braces herself against it. He-Man takes point beside her and the others huddle behind them.

It strikes with the force of a tidal wave. In an instant, they are surrounded by the firestorm as its terrible roar floods their ears and the entire world seems to burn.

It’s like fighting a mountain—an inexorable force that can only be stood against—an inevitability, delayed. She falters for but a moment. It is a moment too long. Her knees buckle and slowly, surely, she is forced back, the coarse gravel grinding beneath her heel.

She can’t fail.

Not now.

Not when they’re so close.

She can’t!

And yet, even the power of She-Ra pales against the inferno. Her divine body flickers, fading with her strength as the shield that guards them all—their last hope against certain death—falters with her. Had she stood alone on this day, Adora has no doubt she would have failed.

But she is not alone.

He-Man stands beside her, and his strength is her own. He digs his boots into the earth and holds firm.

Battle Cat presses his shoulder into the shield. He roars and holds firm.

Teela, Bow, even Melog follow, each offering everything they can. Before her, Catra stands. She says something that Adora cannot hear, but Adora does not need to, for she knows well the fire in her eyes and so she grits her teeth, shouts through them, and together they hold firm, denying oblivion.

And then, there is nothing but an echo, a lingering heat, and smoking earth.

Her shield fades, and she falls to her knees, gasping. Dry air coats her throat and her vision blurs—her body feels as if it’s made of stone, yet it seems that she has to fight just to keep herself from melting apart. It’s nothing but exhaustion, she knows, and the urge to lie down, close her eyes, and never open them again seems like a very reasonable one.

He-Man holds a hand out. They clasp their arms and pull her up. Together, their power fades in a gentle wave that washes over the

others with a soothing warmth that quells their pains and heals their battered bodies. She-Ra and He-Man are gone. Adora and Adam remain. She smiles at him, but it's a slight thing that he struggles to match. Already, he looks back to Snake Mountain and the burning cloud of smoke at its base.

"I'm sorry," Adora says.

He shakes his head.

"My liege!" Man-At-Arms kneels.

King Randor rubs his head and groans through a clenched jaw. "Stand, my friend." His voice is deep and tired, yet at the sound of it, Adora feels a warmth she's only known in dreams. "Where are we?"

"The Dark Continent, sire."

"Why…?"

Adam swallows and tries to put on a smile. "Some might call it a rescue mission."

"Adam!" Randor puts his hands on his shoulders and Adora tries to hide behind Catra and Bow. It's not easy, being the tallest of them. But Randor sees only his son, and he pulls him into a hug. "How did *you* get here?"

"Would you believe me if I said I was on the mission?"

"Against their wishes, no doubt."

"I tried to stop him," Teela says, her back ramrod straight and her eyes locked forward.

"But," Man-At-Arms says, "Adam proved himself an invaluable asset. We would not have succeeded without him."

“Enjoy the glory while it lasts, my son.” He ruffles his hair. “Pull another stunt like this and I won’t even let you read.” There’s a taunt to his words, but far too much love for any bite. Adam—to Randor’s surprise—pulls him into a hug and buries his face in his shoulder. Adora wonders what it must feel like, and something in her chest hurts at the thought.

“I was so worried,” Adam says.

“There’s nothing to be afraid of.” He lowers himself to Adam’s height. “We’re safe now, I’m sure; else Duncan would not look so calm.” He chuckles, but Adam’s face falls. Randor furrows his brow. “Aren’t we, Duncan?”

Man-At-Arms, in a somber voice, says, “He’s not mourning us.”

“Mourning?” Randor follows where they look, to the shadow of Snake Mountain—to the funeral pyre beneath it. No words come. Darkness passes over his eyes and he forces himself to swallow. Then, he nods. “I notice that we’re not alone.” He turns to them—to *her*—and says, “Friends, I hope?”

“Through our darkest hours,” Adam says.

“I would thank them, if you’ll introduce me.”

“Catra and Bow of the lost planet, Etheria. Mighty warriors and even kinder friends. Melog of Krytis, the last of their kind.” They step forward as Adam calls their names, and Randor shakes their hands and pets Melog’s head after they nuzzle his leg.

Then, at last, he looks to Adora and the dreadful pain of her exhaustion is nothing next to the icy pang in her heart. She wants to speak, to say anything, but a knot swells in her throat and her lips can only quiver. She can only look at him. He can only look back. His eyes are wide. His lips move as if to speak but no words come.

“Father,” Adam says. “I’d like you to meet someone.”

“It can’t be.”

It’s only when she sees the gentle, reassuring faces of Catra and Bow that Adora offers a short, trembling wave. “Hi, dad.”

“Adora!” he says, nothing more than a gasp as he rushes forward and takes her in his arms. He sweeps her off the ground and holds her tight and the knot in her throat spills out into choking sobs as she holds him more closely than she ever could before. His warmth is like a blanket and the steady beat of his heart is a rhythm that echoes in her mind. Catra’s hand is on her back and she knows Bow is close. Melog rubs against her leg and the exhaustion pulls on her like a stone. She lets it carry her down into gentle darkness and Adora falls asleep in her father’s arms.

Chapter End Notes

F in the chat for everyone's favorite murder uncle. That's what you get for using Skeletor's toys ¯_(ツ)_/¯

I hope the ending didn't come as too... "woobifying" I think is the right word, for Adora. She's had a very stressful couple of days

MotU CGI season 3 is confirmed and we're getting a sequel to Revelation, so I'm in a pretty good mood. Revolution is bringing in the Horde and despite all reason, I'm hoping they've figured out the wonky rights issues and can use She-Ra. I've heard Kevin Smith was interested in a cross-over with 2018 She-Ra specifically, so I'm going to keep huffing my copium, if the rest of you don't mind.

Champions

Chapter Notes

Kept you waiting, huh?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora dreams.

She dreams of Eternos and its winding streets. She dreams that she walks along them, with Catra, Bow, and Glimmer at her sides, following Adam as he weaves through vendors and alleys, spinning stories of the past. She dreams that she's always been there, that he's always been her brother, and that the war, She-Ra, and all her hurts were nothing more than fleeting nightmares, already forgotten.

She dreams, and they walk, and then they are alone. Bow and Glimmer are gone. Catra is gone. Adora calls for them, but her voice is as silent as the world around her. Adam asks something she cannot hear. Behind him, a Horde Destroyer looms.

Adora wakes to the sound of singing.

She lies in a bed—too comfortable, too soft. The air is cool and smells of flowers and honey. A gentle voice fills it with words too quiet to understand. Adora knows it should be calming. Peaceful. Yet in the distant reaches of her mind, a part of her longs for a firmer mattress, acrid air, the clang of machinery, and the march of soldiers. It is a consequence of her upbringing. She wonders if it will ever go away.

Adora stirs, and the singing stops.

She rubs the sleep from her eyes and pulls herself onto an elbow. A heavy blanket falls from her shoulders—a silken nightgown covers her.

"It's one of mine," a woman says. "I didn't think your old ones would fit." Any mirth from her joke is drowned by the melancholy in her voice.

"Queen Marlena," Adora says, her own voice quiet and haggard. She sits in a chair next to the bed, wearing the same green gown as before. Her hair falls loose and her eyes are still tired and dark. A thousand memories return. *Mom.*

"Hello, Adora."

For the span of several heart beats, they only look at each other. Adora reaches out, but stops herself short. She tries to sit straighter, but her body is too weak and her mind too tired to fight it.

She tries to think of something—anything to say. She wracks her mind for words that won't come. Her eyes flit across Marlena's face as hers stay locked with Adora's, slowly twisting with sorrow as tears line their edges; a pit of dread fills Adora's as core she realizes she never really planned for this.

"I—"

Marlena's hand—her *mom's* hand—covers hers. "Adora." She says the word as if she's testing how it sounds, like it's an old skill or forgotten memory. "Adora," she says again as the tears start to fall. "I'm so sorry."

She tries to ask, *Why?* but her throat locks tight and her heart seems as stiff as stone.

"I never stopped believing. I never gave up hope. I'm so, so sorry."

It wasn't your fault, she wants to say, but all that comes is a stunted sound that breaks through the stillness in her chest.

"We spent years searching. All of Eternia, any planet we could reach. But there was so much to do… Randor wouldn't let the

kingdom fall from his grief. I shouldn't have let him give up. *I* shouldn't have—" Marlena cups her cheek and wipes away the first of Adora's tears. "I'm sorry."

She whispers, "There was nothing you could have done." Adora wonders at the truth of the words even as she speaks them.

"But there's so much we can do now." Marlena composes herself and says, "Starting with… water. You need water. Your voice is as hoarse as a snakeman's." She looks about, fretting and muttering beneath her breath about a glass that should be on the table. When she sees it, she reaches out, but Adora already has it in hand and forces herself to swallow. The water, cool and smooth, still hurts in her raw throat.

Something flickers in Marlena's eyes. But she sighs and her hands fall back into her lap, resting on—

"Catra," Adora says.

She sits cross-legged on the floor, her shoulders and head slumped, snoring as she leans back against Marlena's knees. She's still wearing her battered clothes and her fur is still stained with soot and smoke, but her hair is pulled back into a long, shaggy braid.

"She hasn't left since you got here," Marlena says. "It wasn't easy getting her to sleep."

"It'll be even harder to wake her up."

Marlena laughs, quiet and brief.

Adora's lips move as if to speak, but no words come. Nothing in the Horde could have prepared her for this. Seeing Glimmer and Angella, Bow and his dads, even the uncountable families she's reunited in her quest across the galaxy… None of it helps. None of it makes this make sense.

Marlena seems to notice, so Adora says, “Is everyone else alright?”

She nods. “They’ve been coming to see you. Adam seems very excited to speak with you.”

Adam.

“My brother.”

“Yes.”

He-Man.

“I have a brother.”

Marlena smiles. “You do.”

King Randor.

Her father.

Queen Marlena.

Her mother.

Her heart starts to quicken and fresh, strange tears well.

My family, she thinks.

“I found you.”

Marlena sobs and takes Adora in her arms. Adora trembles against the warmth of Marlena’s body. Slowly, she wraps her arms around her.

“I found you,” she says again.

“You came back,” Marlena—*Mom*—says.

“I found you.”

Marlena brushes Adora's hair behind her ears and kisses her forehead. "And we'll never leave you again."

No, Adora thinks. You won't.

"There's going to be dinner later—a feast. Do you think you can make it?"

Adora's stomach growls louder than Battle Cat.

Marlena laughs. "Let's see if you can stand."

She twists her way out of her seat, carefully resting Catra's head against the cushion, and holds out her hands.

Adora takes them and struggles out of bed. Her legs feel like liquid stone and every muscle in her body aches from the fleeting exertion.

"How long was I asleep?"

"Almost three days."

Adora stumbles and Marlena steadies her.

"Do you have any formal attire?" Marlena asks. "Your clothes were a tad… battle damaged."

"I have another jacket."

She tuts. "You'll have to borrow something of mine. Something to impress her." Catra slumbers, purring, with her arms folded. "She's lovely, Adora. Despite everything that happened…" She cups her cheek again and despite the tears in her eyes, Marlena smiles. "You made a life for yourself. Friends, a wife—"

A deep flush rushes to her cheeks and Adora sputters out, "Ah, we're not… married."

"Forgive me, from the way she spoke of you, I just assumed."

"We haven't… It's not that I wouldn't… But there's so much, and…" She forces her mouth shut as the blush burns on her skin.

"Well," Marlena says, "Should you ever decide, your father and I have the authority to change that."

Adora clears her throat. "Thanks… Mom." The word feels weighty and unfamiliar on her tongue. When she looks at Marlena again she expects to feel a bloom of warmth and finally know the comfort of belonging, yet as she looks into her eyes there is nothing but a strange melancholy and a feeling of loss.

"My daughter."

They're seated at a small table in a private wing of the palace. The only ones in the room are the Best Friends Squad-minus-Glimmer, Man-At-Arms, Teela, and the royal family. Adam sits to Adora's right and Catra to her left. Teela is beside her, and then Man-At-Arms and Bow. Randor and Marlena are side-by-side next to Adam. Next to Randor is an empty chair.

The only others who've entered are the myriad of chefs and servers bringing in trays of food and a single palace guard who whispers into Man-At-Arms' ear.

"A ship has entered the atmosphere," he says, interrupting Randor's story of their youth. "If you'll excuse me."

“I won’t,” Randor says. “You have an entire palace of capable guards and just finished another life-threatening adventure. I think you can enjoy an evening off.”

Man-At-Arms purses his lips, but sits back down. “If my King insists.”

“He does, because we haven’t even gotten to the part where you saved my life again. You see, Adora, in my younger days I had a bad habit of needing him to rescue me. It seems I haven’t entirely shaken it.”

“It wasn’t just Duncan,” Marlena says with a smug smile.

“No.” Randor hides his sheepish look behind his hand. “You had your share of the glory. Your mother is an accomplished pilot, Adora. And it’s not just ships she can fly. On the back of a dragon, she caught me straight out of the air. Instead of the mouth of a volcano, I landed in her arms.” Randor puts his hand over hers and says with a familiar, roguish smile, “I think that was the moment I fell in love with you.”

It’s Marlena’s turn to hide behind her hand as her face starts to match the color of her hair.

“Father, please,” Adam says. “We have guests.”

“I remember a time not so long ago when you begged to hear stories like these. Now you *and* your sister have the privilege of listening to all the misadventures of our youth. What was it we called ourselves back then, Duncan?”

“As I recall, 'The Masters of the Universe'.”

“Awfully egotistical.”

“It was your idea,” Marlena says.

They laugh, and Randor coaxes the rest of the story out of Man-At-Arms—something about a great beast he had to woo with a

song.

Adam watches with rapt attention. Bow laughs along with every joke. Even Catra seems interested.

Adora smiles.

She only smiles.

Is this what it's like? she wonders. Is this how it's supposed to be? There is no worry. No paralyzing fear over what will happen if she missteps or fails. She tells herself that Randor and Marlena would not hurt her—they would not hurt Catra. Already, she wants to say that she *knows* they won't.

Yet when she searches again for that joy, the elation of knowing that she found her family—she has found *her family*—her heart is only hollow.

Glimmer and Angella, Bow and his dads—this is what they did, isn't it? Did they feel like this?

Micah.

Glimmer and Micah.

They know. They'd have to know. They were separated for so long. Adora remembers how they stumbled and tripped over themselves as they tried to find some semblance of what they used to know. Glimmer said that feeling never really came back, that instead, they found something new.

But they seem happy. Are they? Or does Glimmer hide this same empty feeling whenever she looks at her father?

"...but you'll remember," Randor says, "It was Keldor who—" He cuts himself off.

Adam's fork freezes halfway to his mouth. He sets it back on the plate. The clang echoes.

Randor clears his throat.

"I'm sure Adora and her friends have heard enough about us," Marlena says. "There's so much we'd love to know about all of you."

Adora meets their shining eyes and sees their royal garb, the banquet of food on their table, and the cushioned palace they live in.

There's so much she could tell them.

So Adora tells the story of how she and Catra found each other in the Horde, though she does not say what happened to them inside it. She tells them how Glimmer and Bow rescued them and brought them into the Rebellion's fold, though she does not say how long it took, and what they went through to do it. She tells them of how she found the sword and all the good She-Ra brought to the world, though she tells them nothing of the pain it brought her. There are some things, she thinks as Catra takes her hand under the table, out of sight of everyone else, that only they will know.

"She-Ra herself, sitting at our table," Randor says. He takes Marlena's hand. "Our own daughter."

"I only wish we could have seen you grow into the woman you've become," Marlena says. "But there will be plenty of time to know you, now."

Adora smiles.

Plenty of time.

"I hope you aren't too jealous, Adam," Randor says. "We can only have so many royal heirs gallivanting around with magic swords."

Adam shifts his shoulder. The Sword of Power hangs heavy on it.

Adora tilts her head. "But—"

“You won’t have to worry about me, father,” Adam says. “He-Man will do all the gallivanting. This magic sword just lets him know when I’m in trouble.”

Adora moves to speak, but Adam bores into her with wide, unblinking eyes.

“Yes.” Randor cuts into a piece of roast. “Our new friend. I’m saddened to see that he couldn’t join us.”

“He-Man is a manifestation of Eternia’s magic and King Grayskull’s will. He only appears when and where he’s needed.”

“I see.” Randor takes another bite.

Adam stares at his.

Marlena looks between them both, then Adora, and takes a long drink of her wine.

“Actually,” Bow says, “There’s something we’ve been wondering.”

“Anything you’d like to know, my friend,” Randor says.

Bow puts his elbows on the table and laces his fingers together. “Adora’s name.”

Catra pinches the bridge of her nose and Marlena almost spits out her drink.

Randor coughs into his hand. “Yes. Well. It’s something of a long story.”

“We have all night, dear,” Marlena says.

“You see, we didn’t want to worry about names until the two of you were born. Your mother already knew she’d name a boy Adam, but neither of us knew what to name our new little girl. When I held you for the first time, I looked into your eyes, and you smiled.”

“Is that all that happened?” Marlena asks.

“I said that you were adorable. And then I knew.”

Marlena nods. “He was crying so hard that he couldn’t even finish the word.”

“I was overwhelmed.”

Bow nudges Catra. “Told you.” She rolls her eyes, then his tracker-pad dings. “Why would she—? No, of course, she would.” He shakes his head, stands, and in his ‘dignified and official’ voice says, “To the most esteemed members of Eternos’ Royal Court, it is my honor and pleasure to properly introduce you all to—”

In a sparkling flash of pink and purple, Glimmer bursts into the air above the table. She lands with a quiet, dignified grace that evaporates into a full-mouthed smile when she sees Bow. Marlena and Randor quell their surprise while Teela and Man-At-Arms quietly sheathe their weapons.

"Surprise!" she says. "Bow told me you were dealing with a magic guy. Thought I'd pop-in in case you needed a rescue. Figured we could get started in some good old Etherian diplomacy, otherwise." She nods to Randor and Marlena. "Your majesties."

"Your majesty," they say in unison.

Glimmer looks at Adora. She looks at Adam. She raises an eyebrow. She looks at Adora. She looks back at Adam. Her lips purse. She looks at Adora. She looks at Adam again. Her eyes go wide. She looks back at Adora. “Tell. Me. *Everything.”*

Adora stays in Eternos. She tells Marlena tales of her youth—the kinds she'd want to hear, like those of Catra and how they fell in love. Adam shows her the palace and its storied halls and shares the misadventures of his and Teela's youths. Invariably, they all return to Keldor, and Adam stops talking, so Adora tells him of Brightmoon, and her time with Glimmer and Bow. With Teela, she trains, recovering her strength and finding a new friend in someone who appreciates fighting with a bo staff as much as she does.

Adam talks with Glimmer about the differences between Etherian and Eternian political theory. Bow steps in when the discussions get too heated. When he isn't with them, he's with Man-At-Arms, devising some new invention that always ends in a pile of smoke and a flurry of curses—still, they leave the workshop smiling and discussing new ideas.

Adam leads them on proper tours of the city—it took reminding Randor of Adam's new guardian and Adora's own status as a divine warrior to convince him they did not need an entire platoon accompanying them (he settled for a squad)—and no one questions how the sheltered prince should know these streets so well.

But when she sees Randor—*Dad*—there is something in his eyes, something about the way he seems to look past her smile as he starts to frown, that makes her turn away. On the fourth night, they find themselves alone in the private wing of the palace, walking toward the dining hall, as Marlena has insisted they all eat together as often as possible. To make up for lost time, she said. Yet as they walk and their footsteps echo through the cold stone corridor, neither of them says a word.

There will be plenty of time, Marlena's voice echoes in her mind, *Now that we're together again, there will be plenty of time.*

It’s on the seventh day, after a sparring match with Teela as she makes her way back to her quarters—the room that had once been her nursery—that she sees Randor waiting to knock on the door.

“Oh, there you are,” he says.

“Here I am.”

“I wasn’t sure where you were.”

“Just training.”

“I can tell, what with the…” He points to the sweat on her brow then flexes his arm.

They both chuckle. It is a stilted and empty sound.

Randor stands clear of the door. He isn’t in the way of her entering. He wouldn’t stop her if she tried.

Would he?

She wants to be anywhere else, to not have to say what she has to, yet her feet remain in place and she forces herself to look him in the eyes before she speaks.

“You’re not going to stay, are you?” he asks.

She shakes her head.

He closes his eyes. “Would you humor me and listen to a story from a tired, old man?"

Adora nods and Randor leads her to a balcony that overlooks the city and the rolling fields beyond. The sun is setting and its light catches on the grass, likening it to a vast swathe of shining gold.

"After you were stolen from us, and the days turned to weeks… Then months…" His hand tightens on the banister and his voice falters. "Years… Your mother never gave up hope. Even when I

stopped the search, she still believed that one day, you would come home. I didn't. I told myself that I couldn't. I thought that it would be improper for a king to sacrifice the well-being of his people over personal pain." He shakes his head. "I was afraid. I was scared that you were still alive. That one day you'd come back and resent us for not being able to protect you. I couldn't bear the thought of looking into your eyes and seeing that you hated me. But when I look at you now… I know your face. I see you are my blood and I tell myself, 'Randor, look at her. This woman is your daughter.'" His head hangs low and his voice is weary. "But I only see a stranger."

Adora watches a bird fly into the clouds. "There was nothing you could have done."

"We both know that's not true."

"All my life I wondered where I came from. If I had a family waiting for me. I never really thought of what I'd do when I found them. I still don't know what I'm doing."

"Then we have something in common."

They chuckle, and the sun feels a little warmer.

"I don't hate you. And I hate that I can even say this, but I don't know if I love you, either. Because I don't know you."

"You never had the chance. Who's to say you ever will? I can't convince you to give up who you are. And *I* hate that I want to. How selfish must I be, to wish for a daughter over the universe's savior?"

"I don't know a lot about this family stuff, but I think that just makes you a dad."

His smile is sad. "You'll always have a place here. You, and the family you've found. It will always be my greatest regret that I never got to see you grow into the woman you've become, but I am so, so proud of you." He puts a hand on her shoulder.

For a moment, Adora only looks at him. She thinks to return the gesture, then she says, "This isn't goodbye. Not forever. One day, we'll all have more time."

"One day." He kisses her forehead. "My sweet Adora."

Adora is the first to wake. It is hours before the sun will rise and the cool light of the moon still streams in through curtained windows, blanketing the room in an ethereal glow. Long shadows are cast across the walls from cabinets of clothes; tapestries and unlit torches on the walls; and the sprawl of furniture across the floor. The old nursery is far more cushioned than Adora would have made it if given the chance, though after years in the clutter of Brightmoon it is something she has grown to appreciate, if only so. The nights of Eternia are not unlike Etheria: warm, and filled with the distant sounds of life. When she closes her eyes, she can sink back into that pseudo-slumber and pretend as if she’s home.

Adora slips through Catra’s grasp and past Glimmer and Bow. They each murmur and turn before settling back into sleep. From the back of a chair, she takes a heavy robe and ties it shut as she opens the door. It creaks on iron hinges, the sound deafening in the quiet. She slips into the hall. The entire palace is a shadow, a monument to the breadth of the First Ones’ empire, and Adora is haunted by memories born from its labyrinth of halls. She does not know how long she wanders them, alone in the dark, broken only by scarce, flickering torches.

She passes through a door that opens to a wide, open room, empty save for the portraits along its walls and the figure who stands beneath them, his hair disheveled, and his eyes sunken and dark.

"Adam."

He doesn't look at her when he speaks. His voice is hardly more than a whisper. "I wish you knew him differently." A portrait of Keldor looks down on them. He wears the same purple garb Adora remembers; there's a coy look in his eyes and a smile upon thin lips, as if he were privy to a secret only he knew. A plaque beneath reads, *Lord Keldor of the House Grayskull, eldest born of King Miro. Beloved brother to King Randor.* Adam shakes his head and wipes his eyes with the back of his hand. "But maybe that's who he always was."

Adora steps closer. "I'm sorry."

He turns to her. The Sword of Power is sheathed, held in his hands. "This is all he ever wanted. This sword is why this all happened. Eternia still needs someone to carry it."

"Is that why you never told them that you used it?"

He shakes his head. "I understand why they always tried so hard to protect me. I used to get so mad about it, but now? Knowing the reason why? They just got you back, and you can't even stay."

"I don't *want* to leave—"

"It's alright. The universe still needs She-Ra. I think it always will."

It's a thought Adora has had before. It's not one she likes.

Adam squeezes her shoulder. "You deserve to rest. More than anyone else, you do. But we both know you won't stop. It's not who you are. And if you're out there saving the universe, I don't want Mother and Father to have to worry about me, too."

Adora nods. She reaches for the sword, but Adam says, "But… I'll never pretend to understand what you've been through. What being She-Ra has done to you. What it cost. It's only been a few weeks since I've had this sword, but I look around and see what it's done to my life… I think about what it would do to someone else… I can't bear the thought of putting that weight on another. I can't bear the thought of asking you to do that." He tries to smile. "Adora, Eldress asked you to make a choice. But you've already done so much. There's still so much you have to do."

"You're taking the sword?"

"Yes." There's conviction in his voice. A clarity she's only heard from him once before, when thunder struck the earth and a champion emerged from the fire. Yet still, there is the same fear in his eyes that she's seen in the mirror.

"You don't want it."

"No." He looks as if he means to say something else, but he turns away.

"What?"

A faint flush spreads across his cheeks. "It's just… Taking it anyway…" He shrugs. "It's what you would do."

She pulls him into a hug. "Thank you, Adam."

"What else is family for?"

In the dark halls of Castle Grayskull, Eldress' voice rings clear. "Do you swear to wield this sword justly and true?"

"I swear it," Adam says, kneeling before the orb—the last of Eternia's magic. The light from within dances across his face.

"Do you swear to guard this castle and its secrets from those who would use them to do harm?"

"I swear it."

"Do you swear to protect Eternia and her people? To defend all those who cannot defend themselves?"

"I swear it."

He does not have D'Vann's face. Yet, when Eldress looks upon him, she sees the shadow of something familiar. "Then rise, Adam, Prince of Eternos and Champion of Castle Grayskull."

It was a small ceremony—little more than a formality, even by Eldress' admission—attended only by those few who knew Adam's new secret. Each of them promised they would do everything in their power to keep it.

He-Man kneels outside the castle, the Sword of Power plunged into the earth. Adora—who decided attending as She-Ra was more appropriate—coaches him through the process of restoring magic to a sterile world.

“It should feel natural,” she says. “Let it come to you. Remember, you’re a conduit.”

He closes his eyes. A shimmering glow dances across his body and pours into the earth. A burst of thunder splits the skies and in its deafening wake, waves of silver-gold light spill out like an aurora. They dance through the clouds and weave between the stars in a dark purple sky, then shoot off toward distant horizons as the sun shines stronger, and the world around them grows a little brighter.

“Is it like this every time?” Teela asks Catra.

She nods. “And it never gets old.”

He-Man fades with the wind, and Adam stands.

Eldress appears beside him. “Eternia has been too long without its natural power. There is much still to be done before she has been restored. Only then can your real work begin.”

“How’s the most sheltered prince in the universe going to find an excuse to get off-planet?” Adora asks, letting She-Ra’s power dissipate.

“Diplomatic missions,” Adam says. “Entirely peaceful. Nothing dangerous. I already have Father’s permission. He says it’s time Eternia finds its place in the wider universe. I’m looking forward to putting some of my political theory into practice.” He side-eyes Glimmer. She sticks out her tongue. “We’ll be leaving anything too exciting to our new friend.” He pats the sword.

“Are you ever going to tell them?”

“They kept you a secret for twenty years. I think they can handle me having an alter ego. But… yeah. Later. When they’re ready.”

“Whatever you say…” Adora pauses for a moment and decides to try something. “...Bro.”

“Sure thing… Sis.”

They both turn to Bow. Confused pain is wrought in his features.

“Siblings don’t do that, do they?” Adora asks.

He just shakes his head.

“It’ll only be a few space adventures, I *promise.”* Glimmer’s voice is muffled, coming from Darla’s bridge. “You didn’t have to deal with any paperwork for, like, ten years. You can survive my first vacation.”

Adora stands at the base of Darla’s entrance ramp, one foot still on the palace grounds. Teela, Man-At-Arms, and the royal family—*her* family—stand before her. “I’ll come back. I promise I’ll come back.”

“You have the schedule saved?” Marlena asks. “It’s in three months, remember.”

Her and Adam’s birthday. It has, also, a collection of other noteworthy holidays and important events Marlena has said are essential that they meet as a family for, stressing the significance of something called Christmas and that Glimmer and Bow were not exempt from attendance. “I remember,” Adora says.

“There doesn’t have to be a reason. If ever you feel the need, you will be welcome here,” Randor says. "All of you."

“We’ve got a lot of trouble to get into if we’re going to make up for lost time,” Adam adds.

Bow, says, “I can give you guys some pointers for sibling mischief.”

Catra, as light as a breeze, smacks the back of his head, then nods to Teela. “We’ll keep them in check,” she says to Marlena and Randor. Melog and Cringer nuzzle each other’s faces and purr so loudly Adora can feel it through her feet. “And there will be plenty of play-dates,” Catra says, scratching their heads.

“If you ever get into any trouble out there,” Adam says, “I’m sure He-Man will be willing to lend a hand.”

“And keep an eye on Adam if you happen to be in the same system,” Randor says. “Danger has a habit of finding him. I know it could never be that he seeks it out.”

Marlena perks up. “We’ll have to prepare for your official unveiling. It will be somewhat of a shock to the people, but I know they’ll love to meet you.”

“I’ll prepare a new room so you don’t have to stay in that old nursery,” Randor adds.

And so it goes, with more promises of better days to come, and no one willing to say goodbye. All things that have been said before, that they cannot stop themselves from saying again.

Everyone knows what will happen when there’s nothing left to say.

But Adora doesn’t mind, not really, and even though there will be plenty of time later, she decides that it’s all right if they stay here, just for a little while longer.

Chapter End Notes

In case it wasn't obvious, this is the final chapter. There's going to be an epilogue releasing in a day or two, but I think

you can all guess what that's going to be about :)

We might have missed the one-year mark but about a month, but it's been a real blast going on this little trip with you all and I'm really happy with how this story has turned out. Even if you aren't a MOTU fan (or ever planning on being one) I hope you've enjoyed this little slice of He-Man's world and seeing the Best Friends Squad mess around in it.

Take care, friends, and Good Journey!

Epilogue

Keldor stood on the rampart. He leaned lazily against the cool stone and drank in the afternoon's gilded warmth. A gentle wind blew, carrying on it the smell of flowers and honey. The city Eternos lay below, sprawling over the field, next to the ever-clear river. He smiled at the memory of Randor first learning to swim as Father watched with worried eyes and Keldor stood waist-deep in the banks, laughing at how his little brother shirked from the cold.

Keldor looked on the city's vast expanse. He knew how much of it was empty. Empty houses and empty streets that had not known the sound of laughter nor the joy of life for over a thousand years. Randor was too focused now on preserving what they had, rather than reclaiming what once was. There was so much Keldor knew he could do, if only he had the power to enact it.

He shook his head and sighed.

Behind him came the pattering of tiny feet and panting breath. Little Adam ran through the door and stumbled as he stopped himself. "Uncle!" he said, "Look what I found!" With bright eyes and a beaming smile—one of his teeth missing, as he was often so proud to mention—he held up an old scroll.

"And what's this?" Keldor asked, taking it from him. He noticed for the first time that Adam had grown to the height of his elbow.

"A scroll!"

"I see that."

"It's about King Grayskull!" He pursed his lips. "I think. I can't read all of it."

That he could read any *of it, Keldor thought as he looked it over, was enough to make him smile. He knew Old Eternian (some of it) at such a young age. Adam might have had Marlena's spirit and Randor's heart, but his* mind*—that spark, the* fire*—that much,*

Keldor let himself think, was because of him. "Grayskull, indeed," Keldor said. "In fact, it's about this city."

"Really?"

Keldor nodded, then grabbed Adam by the waist and hoisted him up so he could see over the rampart. He tried to ignore how heavy he was getting. "All this was his design. Did you know that?"

"Nuh-uh."

"Well then. Let me tell you a story."

The air stinks of sulfur and burning rubber. The Horde ship, once so white and so pure, now smolders amidst broken earth, now nothing but a heap of ash and twisted metal.

A charred hand of blackened bone grips tight a ram-skull staff.

Each step is a struggle, but still, he walks.

Every breath is agony; acrid, poison air stains his dry tongue and aching lungs, but still, he breathes.

He drags a man by the only arm he has left. He does not remember his name, nor why he is with him, down here in the dark. All he remembers is that he must serve. He coughs, spitting out congealed blood past shattered teeth and groans as he’s pulled along a shard of glass. He still breathes, and so he still lives, and so he must serve.

The charred hand of blackened bone slams the ram-skull staff against the metal floor. A hollow clang rings out and a dark cloud of smoke clears. Further in the bowels of the wreckage, dozens of tanks filled with emerald plasma line the walls, illuminating the chamber in a sickly, green glow. Many are broken. Their glass is shattered and the plasma spills across the floor. Decrepit bodies spill out with it.

This much, he saved from the firestorm.

This much, he would have to use.

He does not remember why he is down here in the dark.

He drags the man into a tank and watches as the vile liquid spills over his body.

He does not remember his name.

He looks down at his hand of blackened bone. The fingers flex, and charred muscle splits and pops. It should be excruciating. But he has known true pain.

He sees his reflection in the green: a ruined face with reddened, lidless eyes. He brings his hand of bone to his cheek. Putrid flesh sloughs off at his touch.

He does not remember his name.

He digs in until he feels bone. What was once his face spills through his fingers like mud.

He does not remember his name.

The ram-skull staff clatters on the ground as he pulls and tears.

He remembers a face. Not his, not what it was like before, but another. Someone else, facing him amidst the fire.

Hair falls in clumps with the rest of his scalp. An ear follows.

He does not remember his name.

He remembers *his* name. He remembers something… Something taken from him.

"Grayskull," he mutters past lipless teeth. "Sword."

He stares into reddened eyes that smolder like embers and drags his hands across a fleshless skull.

He remembers the only thing that matters.

“He-Man.”

He starts to laugh.

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